

ESCOLA SUPERIOR DE PROPAGANDA E MARKETING
POST- GRADUATION PROGRAM IN BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION

ANTONIO PEDRO CRUZ COSTA ALVES

BRAND RELATIONSHIP IDIOSYNCRASY

The peculiar bonds consumers have with brands they love and hate

SÃO PAULO

2026

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This doctoral thesis was presented as a requirement for the Doctor in Business Administration degree, with an emphasis on Marketing, from the Escola Superior de Propaganda e Marketing (ESPM).

Supervisor: PhD Professor Vivian Iara Strehlau

SÃO PAULO

2026

Alves, Antonio Pedro Cruz Costa

Brand relationship idiosyncrasy : the peculiar bonds consumers have with brands they love and hate / Antonio Pedro Cruz Costa Alves. - São Paulo, 2026.
141 f. : il., color.

Tese (doutorado) – Escola Superior de Propaganda e Marketing, Programa de Doutorado em Administração – Gestão Internacional, São Paulo, 2026.

Orientador: Vivian Iara Strehlau

1. brand relationship. 2. branding. 3. brand relationship idiosyncrasy. 4. consumer behaviour. 5. brand management. I. Strehlau, Vivian Iara. II. Escola Superior de Propaganda e Marketing. III. Título.

To those who believe that where dogma fails, thinking prevails.

“Os olhos, por enquanto, são a porta do engano; duvide deles, dos seus, não de mim. Ah, meu amigo, a espécie humana peleja para impor ao latejante mundo um pouco de rotina e lógica, mas algo ou alguém de tudo faz frincha para rir-se da gente...”

(Guimarães Rosa, O Espelho)

“He used to wonder at the shallow psychology of those who conceive the Ego in man as a thing simple, permanent, reliable, and of one essence. To him, man was a being with myriad lives and myriad sensations, a complex multiform creature that bore within itself strange legacies of thought and passion, and whose very flesh was tainted with the monstrous maladies of the dead.”

(Oscar Wilde, The Picture of Dorian Gray)

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

My academic journey began late in my career, after I had worked for several companies, most of them in marketing. The reasoning and the types of questions that academics ask and answer are much deeper and more challenging. I am grateful to have chosen this new life cycle and to be able to contribute to society, academia, my colleagues, and students. Completing a doctorate is a burdensome task that often feels overwhelming and tiring. It is an intellectually strong effort to put your thoughts on paper, organise them, concatenate your ideas, integrate them with theory, and make your research interesting, original, and meaningful. Learning and effort are continuous and never-ending, not stopping after earning a degree. A doctorate gives you critical thinking and methodological tools to move ahead and continue the goal of any researcher: to understand and theorise about what is not known.

I want to give my deepest thanks to everyone who walked alongside me in this journey, helping me, guiding the way, and supporting me with their friendship. First, without my family, I would never have come this far. My family's academic background strongly influenced who I am and how I think, starting with my grandfather, who is an indirect influence on my academic interests. Although he passed away the same year I was born, his influence, stories, and being one of the most prominent philosophers in Brazil have always made me proud. My mother was a good companion during my PhD, enhancing my critical thinking and always questioning the status quo. My father, my stepmother, and my aunt incentivised my studies, giving me the strength and confidence to change my career to academia. Many thanks to my brother, my sister-in-law, and my nephews for their support throughout my academic life.

My most respectful gratitude to my professors, who were kind enough to teach me, be willing to discuss my ideas, and debate how to sharpen them. I do not have enough words to thank my supervisor, Vivian Strehlau, who was a strong supporter of my work, a good listener, and a friend with whom I could call or meet anytime to chat about my research. My special thanks to Miriam Salomão, my co-supervisor during my exchange PhD programme in Portugal, for welcoming me so well, supporting me, and giving me the opportunity to teach master's students. Another warm appreciation and thank you to professors Suzane Strehlau and Roberta Campos for inviting me to joint projects, discussing my work, and incentivising my research. Thank you, Professor Benjamin Rosenthal, for participating in the examination committee and for your thoughtful comments and constructive critique. I would also like to thank Professor Fabiano Rodrigues, my first supervisor in my master's, for his guidance and friendship;

Professor Thelma Rocha, for her kindness in discussing and sharing ideas; Professor Evandro Lopes, for inviting me to participate in research projects and believing in my work; Professor Flávio Bizarrias, for being a true partner and friend in research studies and academic discussions; Professor Manolita Lima for her counselling and tireless efforts to unveil the best of my teaching skills; Professor Sílvio Vasconcellos for supporting my academic journey and my research; Professor João Ciaco for the good conversations about brands and semiotics, and for allowing me to be your assistant professor. My sincere appreciation to CAPES and ESPM for granting me a scholarship during my PhD studies and for allowing me to spend six months in an exchange programme in Portugal. And a special thanks to IPAM professors and faculty for opening the doors to my international research and for granting me the status of visiting professor.

My greatest gratitude goes to all my friends who followed my doctoral path and were patient enough to listen to my thoughts. My deepest appreciation to all my ESPM colleagues, in particular, Rafael Sadocco, for our discussions, partnerships in articles, and friendship; Tamara Natale, for thinking alike, our always good conversations, and our joint projects; Cássia Pizani, for our long work history and friendship; Miguel Kanaan Coelho, for the joint studies and companionship; Siliane Ferrari Voltolini, for our shared opinions about academic life and for your humbleness; Alexandre Gidaro, for the fun moments during our classes together; Joana Carvalho, for being a good friend during the doctorate and for sharing your impressions about the PhD exchange programme; Edgar Miyake, for the companionship and debating our research interests; and Sidney Vitorino, for your kindness and opening doors for me to be a supervisor for MBA students.

Finally, I would like to express my warmest gratitude to you who is reading this PhD thesis and is interested in my work. As a researcher, professor, and student, my greatest satisfaction is sharing knowledge with anyone interested enough to learn and read it. I hope that my studies might inspire you to pursue an academic life, start a research project, learn more about branding, foster curiosity, or, at least, unleash your critical thinking. If anything has sparked your interest, my work will have achieved its objective.

O presente trabalho foi realizado com apoio da Coordenação de Aperfeiçoamento de Pessoal de Nível Superior – Brasil (CAPES) – Código de Financiamento 001.

This study was financed in part by the Coordenação de Aperfeiçoamento de Pessoal de Nível Superior – Brasil (CAPES) – Finance Code 001.

ALVES, Antonio Pedro Cruz Costa. *Brand relationship idiosyncrasy: the peculiar bonds consumers have with brands they love and hate*. 2026. Tese (Doutorado em Administração) – Programa de Pós-Graduação em Administração, Escola Superior de Propaganda e Marketing (ESPM), São Paulo.

RESUMO

O objetivo deste trabalho foi investigar as relações peculiares e idiossincráticas que os consumidores cultivam com as marcas, sejam elas negativas, positivas, neutras ou ambíguas. Nossa pesquisa revelou que as marcas funcionam como sinalizadoras de identidade pessoal, carregam significados simbólicos, atuam como parceiras em relacionamentos, enfatizam sentimentos polarizados e desencadeiam comportamentos e emoções negativos. Com base em uma abordagem fenomenológica, aplicamos uma gama de métodos qualitativos para investigar as relações entre consumidor e marca, incluindo entrevistas em profundidade, netnografia e dados secundários. Contribuímos para a teoria ao identificar e definir 34 relacionamentos idiossincráticos novos ou pouco teorizados, como terapeutas/pacientes, vigaristas/trouxas, prazeres com remorso e agnosticismo. Uma segunda contribuição diz respeito a como essas relações auxiliam os consumidores em seus projetos de identidade, influenciando seus eus individuais e sociais. A terceira contribuição consiste em uma proposta de modelo para explicar as relações negativas entre consumidor e marca, abrangendo personalidades sombrias da marca, avaliação de situações, emoções suscitadas, relacionamentos falhos, bem como mecanismos e comportamentos de enfrentamento. Este trabalho também tem implicações sociais relacionadas à saúde mental (por exemplo, bullying e dependência), à proteção dos direitos do consumidor e aos Objetivos de Desenvolvimento Sustentável da ONU.

Palavras-chave: relacionamento com marcas, branding, relações idiossincráticas da marca, comportamento do consumidor, gestão de marcas.

ALVES, Antonio Pedro Cruz Costa. *Brand relationship idiosyncrasy: the peculiar bonds consumers have with brands they love and hate*. 2026. Doctoral Thesis (PhD in Business Administration) – Postgraduate Research Program in Administration, Higher School of Advertising and Marketing / Escola Superior de Propaganda e Marketing (ESPM), São Paulo.

ABSTRACT

The objective of this work was to investigate the peculiar and idiosyncratic relationships that consumers foster with brands, either negative, positive, neutral, or ambiguous. Our research revealed how brands work as beacons of self-identity, carry symbolic meanings, function as relationship partners, emphasise polarised feelings, and trigger negative behaviours and emotions. Drawing on a phenomenological approach, we applied a range of qualitative methods to investigate consumer-brand relationships, including in-depth interviews, netnography, and secondary data. We contribute to theory by identifying and defining 34 new or less theorised idiosyncratic relationships, such as therapists/patients, crooks/suckers, guilty pleasures, and agnostics. A second contribution regards how these relationships help consumers with their identity projects, influencing their individual and social selves. The third contribution concerns a proposal for a framework to explain negative consumer-brand relationships, encompassing dark brand personalities, appraisal of events, elicited emotions, flawed relationships, and coping mechanisms and behaviours. This work also has social implications regarding mental health (e.g., bullying and addiction), consumer rights protection, and the UN's Sustainable Development Goals.

Keywords: brand relationship, branding, brand relationship idiosyncrasy, consumer behaviour, brand management.

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CHAPTER 1 - INTRODUCTION

1.1 Motivation for the research

Several authors have studied brand relationships since the seminal work of Fournier (1998), who introduced the brand relationship quality (BRQ) framework and examined the various meaningful relationships between brands and consumers (Alvarez et al., 2023). Consumers develop deep emotional bonds with brands, which vary in polarity and strength (Fetscherin et al., 2019; Fetscherin & Veloutsou, 2024). In this sense, the brand relationship research stream expanded the brand loyalty construct, considering the interconnections with brands as a dynamic phenomenon more in line with the post-modern fragmented consumer (Fournier & Yao, 1997). Researchers have delved into the myriad of relationships and followed several streams related to brand trust, brand communities, brand love, brand cult, self-connection, culture, and storytelling (Fetscherin & Heinrich, 2015).

First, scholars explored the positive emotions and behaviours associated with the connection between brands and consumers. The brand love construct was proposed, which comprises positive emotional associations, self-brand integration, and passion-driven behaviours (Batra et al., 2012). In this sense, consumption products are used to create meanings, extending the self (Belk, 1988), as the effort dispensed in loved objects helps consumers establish a coherent self and solves potential existential conflicts (Ahuvia, 2005). Brand love is also associated with brand loyalty and positive word of mouth, with the effect being more significant in hedonic categories (Carroll & Ahuvia, 2006). Depending on the consumer's susceptibility to influence and the brand's self-expression, consumers can experience harmonious or obsessive passion (Swimberghe et al., 2014).

Academics later studied negative emotions related to brand-consumer relationships. In contrast with brand love and other positive-related constructs, brand hate, avoidance, retaliation, anti-consumption, and other subversive behaviours were identified (Wilson et al., 2022) but are less theorised (Mushtaq et al., 2024; Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022). The intensity of consumers' negative emotions towards brands can range from severe to mild, influenced by personality traits (Kucuk, 2019). Brand hate has active and passive components, with behavioural outcomes including complaints and negative word of mouth (Zarantonello et al., 2016; Zhang & Laroche, 2020).

Not only have studies investigated negative and positive emotions and behaviours related to brands, but they have also explored polarised relationships. Oppositional brand loyalty refers to the meanings consumers derive from brands they consume, rather than those they do not (Muñiz & Hamer, 2001). Identifying with a brand makes consumers oppose rival brands, as these rivals might threaten their self-concept (Liao et al., 2021). Scholars have discussed brand rivalries and found that they are related to *schadenfreude* (feeling happy at others' misfortunes) (Phillips-Melancon & Dalakas, 2014), humour and ridicule (Ewing et al., 2013), an increase in the likelihood of adopting new products (S. A. Thompson & Sinha, 2008), and enhance brand and consumer group distinctiveness (Berendt et al., 2018). The effect of polarisation might also be harmful, with a negative impact on returns but a lower perception of risk (X. Luo, Raithel, et al., 2013; X. Luo, Wiles, et al., 2013). More recently, brand polarisation has been studied as a more general phenomenon, with scholars arguing that rivalry is a particular type (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, 2024).

Apart from studies on individual relationships and emotions, another academic stream examined brand communities and how they foster deep connections among consumer groups and brands. Brand communities partake in rituals, foster a sense of members' distinctiveness from outsiders, and share a sense of moral responsibility (Muñiz & O'Guinn, 2001). They develop collective and collaborative values via practices, behaviours, and performances (Schau et al., 2009). Brand communities enhance community engagement, though they also stimulate reactance to normative rules (Algesheimer et al., 2005) and heighten tensions against the brand to preserve the community's independence (Korunum et al., 2017).

The intense emotions associated with brand-consumer relationships and a sense of community are intrinsic to how people understand themselves. Consumers' self-concept is based on contrasting ingroups versus outgroups (Tajfel & Turner, 2004). Therefore, individuals have a stronger self-brand connection with brands that are consistent with their ingroup (Escalas & Bettman, 2005), as they seek self-congruity (Sirgy, 1982, 2018). The brand-consumer connection can go further when individuals feel an identity fusion with brands (Swann et al., 2012), being immune to transgressions and negative feedback (Lin & Sung, 2014).

Although brand relationship scholars focused on positive and negative emotions and behaviours towards brands, explored the functioning of brand communities, and investigated brand-self interactions, few studies explored intense and idiosyncratic relationships between consumers and brands, focusing more on particular types of relationships such as brand love, hate, and friendships (Alvarez et al., 2023). Moreover, brand hate and avoidance remain nascent

topics in the literature, as scholars have paid more attention to positive relationships such as brand loyalty, love, and attachment (Mushtaq et al., 2024; Roy et al., 2022; Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022). Regarding brand polarisation, which comprises positive and negative emotions towards brands, the topic is still scarcely studied (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019) and underdeveloped (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024).

1.2 Research objectives

First, we explore consumers' idiosyncratic connections with their most loved and admired brands in light of the consumer-brand relationship theory and consumer culture theory (CCT). The CCT examines how consumers perceive meanings embedded in brands and consumer products to make sense of themselves and incorporate them into their lifestyles (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). Second, our work investigates some brands that elicit polarised consumer feelings, as they have lovers and haters. Brand polarisation comprises four dimensions: brand passion, self-brand benchmarking, intra-group identification, and inter-group dissociation (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024). Third, this thesis explores the negative or dark side of the relationship with brands, focusing on negative feelings and behaviours. Brand hate is a multidimensional construct (Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022) that includes negative emotions (anger, contempt, fear, disappointment, etc.), which lead to reactions such as attack (negative word of mouth), avoidance (reduction or cessation) or approach (complaining and protest) (Zarantonello et al., 2016).

In summary, our doctoral thesis explores consumers' peculiar relationships with brands, which can be positive or negative, and brands that provoke both polarising feelings, answering a call to investigate new brand-consumer relationship types (Alvarez et al., 2023). To clarify what we understand by idiosyncratic relationships, we provide the following definition: *brand relationship idiosyncrasy concerns the peculiar and characteristic bonds, mannerisms, habits, and mental conditions that consumers have towards brands, which are susceptible to particular stimuli*. We intend to answer the following research question: *How do consumers have intense, idiosyncratic relationships with brands they love and hate?*

We adopted qualitative methods to better understand the idiosyncratic relationships consumers have with brands, a research stream that remains underdeveloped and less theorised. While positivist ontology and quantitative studies focus on measuring reality and proposing general laws, interpretative approaches hold that reality is socially constructed and emphasise understanding behaviour rather than predicting it (Hudson & Ozanne, 1988). Choosing a

qualitative approach for the current thesis is adequate since few qualitative studies researched the different types of brand relationships (love, passion, hate, friendships, addiction, and others) in the past years, and the most prominent methodological approaches were Structural Equation Modeling (SEM) and experiments (Alvarez et al., 2023; Gilal et al., 2023; Mushtaq et al., 2024; Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022).

1.3 Contributions

This research examines why consumers have peculiar bonds with the brands they love and hate, unearthing new types of idiosyncratic relationships and how they are enacted. More specifically, we contribute to theories of the self in consumer behaviour and branding, exploring their interconnections with brand identity, personality, and core values. The intensity of the relationship can be beneficial, nurturing passion and love (Gilal et al., 2023), helping structure the self and provide meaning (Fetscherin & Heinrich, 2015), or might be associated with hate (Mushtaq et al., 2024; Roy et al., 2022; Zarantonello et al., 2016; Zhang & Laroche, 2020), addiction (Cui et al., 2018; Mrad et al., 2020; Mrad & Cui, 2017), and aversion (Park et al., 2013b).

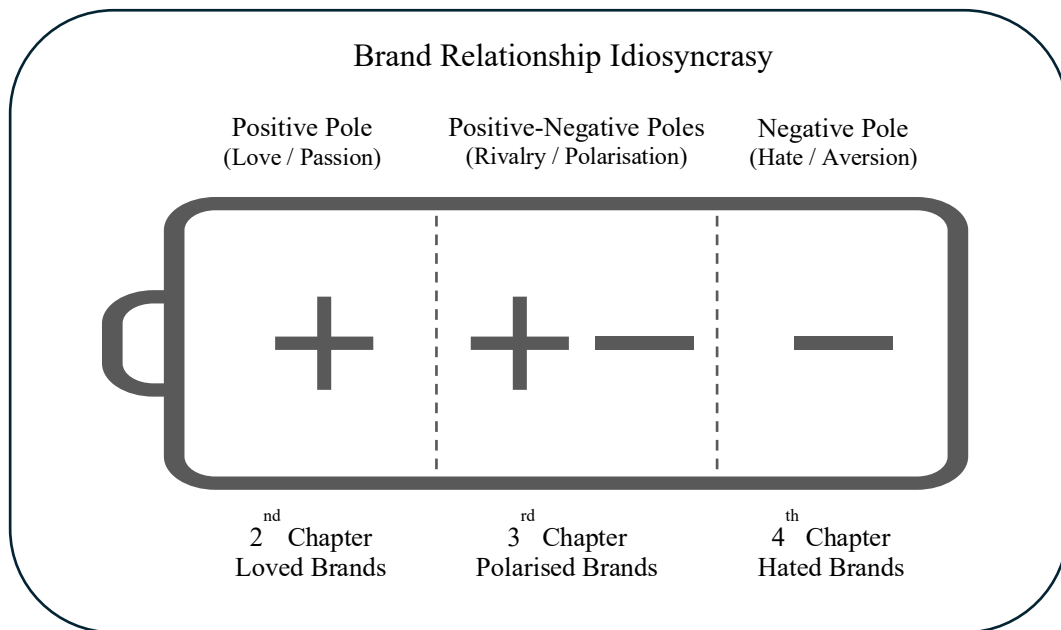
More specifically, this thesis contributes to consumer-brand relationship theory as follows: (1) by theorising and defining the idiosyncratic relationships; (2) by understanding how the relationships affect the consumer self and are a reflection of culture; (3) by proposing a flawed consumer-brand relationship framework to explain the connections among dark brand personalities, relationships, emotions, and coping mechanisms. The practical implications of our study are to show marketers how consumers interact passionately with their brands and how businesses can respond, nurture, foster, or manage these unique relationships.

1.4 Thesis structure

To accomplish our goals, we divided our doctoral thesis into three articles. The first article focused on the positive pole of the idiosyncratic brand-consumer relationship, explaining why consumers have tattooed brands. The second article discussed brands that elicit polarised consumer reactions, examining the different motivations that lead consumers to either love or hate them. The third and last paper explored flawed consumer-brand relationships, proposing a framework to explain the interactions with negative brand personalities, elicited emotions, and coping mechanisms.

Figure 1.1 shows the overall structure of the doctoral thesis. The first article on brand tattoos represents the positive pole of brand relationship idiosyncrasy: consumers' most alluring feelings toward a brand. The second article concerns the negative and positive emotions and behaviours that polarising brands elicit in consumers. The third and final article is at the negative pole, discussing brands consumers dislike. The three articles examine consumers' idiosyncratic behaviours when engaging with brands.

Figure 1.1 - Structure of the Doctoral Thesis.



Source: author's own work.

CHAPTER 2 – POSITIVE POLE: BRAND LOVE VIA BRAND TATTOOS¹

2.1 Introduction

Consumers have relationships with brands as they would with people (Fournier, 1998; Fournier & Alvarez, 2012). They develop deep emotional bonds with brands, sharing affinities and enthusiasm with other like-minded individuals in communities (Fetscherin et al., 2021; Fetscherin & Veloutsou, 2024). Scholars have studied the deep consumer-brand bonds, such as brand love (Batra et al., 2012; Carroll & Ahuvia, 2006; Rahman et al., 2021), brand passion (Gilal et al., 2023; Swimberghe et al., 2014), brand attachment (Park et al., 2010; Shimul, 2022; Thomson et al., 2005), brand engagement (Fernandes & Moreira, 2019), and brand pride (Kaur & Verma, 2024). Strong connections with brands have also been theorised under negative relationships of brand hate (Mushtaq et al., 2024; Zarantonello et al., 2016; Zhang & Laroche, 2020) and, more recently, polarised brands, which attract passionate feelings of love and hate (Monahan et al., 2023; Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024).

Although studies have advanced in understanding consumer-brand connections, there is a gap regarding new brand relationship types to capture the diversity of connections, their valence and strength (Alvarez et al., 2023; Fournier & Alvarez, 2013), and how they interact with the consumers' identity projects. The literature is also silent about multiple and dynamic relationships consumers have with the same brand, as scholars have theorised only about single steady relationship types (e.g., brand love, pride, addiction, friendship, and hate) (Alvarez et al., 2023) or changes from one to another (e.g., love turning to hate or vice versa) (Grégoire & Fisher, 2008; Langner et al., 2016; Zarantonello et al., 2018).

Consumer Culture Theory (CCT) scholars complement the brand relationship literature describing consumers' profound feelings for their beloved brands and discuss consumers' identity projects under a fragmented sense of self (Arnould & Thompson, 2005). The understanding that people use objects and brands as part of their extended self (Belk, 1988) is an evolving set of ideas which is transitioning to digitalised (Belk, 2013) and transhuman (Lima & Belk, 2024) versions of personhood. Consumer researchers are shifting their view from considering people to have stable core selves to understanding them as a network of assembled experiences, practices, and narratives (C. J. Thompson, 2024). This view has also been

¹ This article was published in the *Journal of Business Research* with the following title: "It's no skin off your nose: why do consumers tattoo brands?". Doi: 10.1016/j.jbusres.2025.115508.

discussed under the dialectical division of the consumer's self and body as agentic and stable versus unbounded and dynamic (Appau et al., 2020; Preece et al., 2024).

This paper discusses particular and multiple interrelations between brands and consumers, epitomised by brand tattoos. There are few studies focused on extremely sturdy connections between consumers and brands, including brand sacredness (Fuschillo et al., 2024; Wang et al., 2019) and brand addiction (Cui et al., 2018; Ghorbanzadeh, 2024; Mrad & Cui, 2017). From this perspective, brand tattoos represent a deep bond between consumers and brands but are only tangentially mentioned in the literature. For instance, studies show Harley-Davidson aficionados tattooing brand symbols to represent their devotion (Rahman et al., 2021; Schouten & McAlexander, 1995).

The interrelatedness between loyal consumers and tattooed brands seems straightforward due to the identification of the self with the brand lifestyle (Orend & Gagné, 2009). However, a small number of studies have discussed the meaning of tattooed brands and have not explored it from the consumer perspective, focusing on sponsorship tattooing (Weidner et al., 2016), tattooist perceptions related to brand tattoos (Bengtsson et al., 2005), the body commodification by tattooed corporate logos (Orend & Gagné, 2009) or the extension of brands to the body via advertising (Bjerrisgaard et al., 2013).

Scholars have explored the relationship between tattoos and post-modern consumption, which considers the individual fragmented, seeking freedom of movement and not subjecting to a single reality or way of being (Firat & Venkatesh, 1995). Tattoos are in the middle of the fragmented tension between the post-modern self and the search for a coherent identity (Patterson & Schroeder, 2010). Tattooing brings out contemporary cultural contradictions, showing a dynamic tension between durable versus transient consumption (Steadman, Banister, et al., 2023; Steadman et al., 2019). It exposes the body's and identity's malleability, although permanently marking them (Patterson, 2018), and fits the self-narrative as points of reference that allow individuals to control their lives and express their idiosyncrasies (Oksanen & Turtiainen, 2005).

This study aims to analyse the intense bond between consumers and their tattooed brands by understanding why they tattoo them and theorising implications for the brand relationship literature. Since there is scarce theorisation about branding and tattoos, this work aims to fill this lacuna by contributing to the literature regarding consumer-brand relationships, self, body, and tattoos and presenting the results from consumer interviews. Interpretative

Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) was adopted to explore the following research question: what types of relationships do consumers have with the brands they tattoo?

This research has two main contributions to the literature. First, it extends the brand relationship literature by discussing new types of consumer-brand connections uncovered through brand tattoos that are new or scarcely theorised (Alvarez et al., 2023; Fournier & Alvarez, 2013): best friends forever (BFF), family ties, childhood buddies, teammates, dealers/addicts, therapists/patients, gurus/disciples, soulmates, partisans, and vintage mates. Second, this study reveals that consumers can have multiple and dynamic relationships with the same brand, impacting their identity projects. Brand tattoos are polysemic and incomplete symbols representing a desire for a stable sense of self.

2.2 Literature Review

2.2.1 Consumer-Brand Relationships

The relationship between consumers and brands has been extensively researched over the past decades since the first seminal papers in the 1990s (Fetscherin & Heinrich, 2015; Fetscherin & Veloutsou, 2024). This research stream assumes that individuals see brands as relationship partners (Fournier, 1998), while the level of passion determines the strength of the connection (Fetscherin et al., 2019). Consumers develop feelings and want to be close to brands (Veloutsou, 2007), cultivating several interconnections (Bagozzi et al., 2021) and psychologically benefiting from engaging with them (Razmus, 2025).

A variety of relationships have been proposed and analysed, such as arranged marriages, best friendships, and enmities (Bagozzi et al., 2021; Fournier, 1998). Even after years of development from the original brand relationship typology (Fournier, 1998), only brand love came up as a core construct in the last decades (Alvarez et al., 2023). There is a need for more studies concerning new brand relationship types to capture a broader aspect of the phenomenon (Alvarez et al., 2023).

Moreover, scholars have not focused on consumers' multiple and dynamic relationships with the same brand, studying single positive and negative consumer-brand bonds (Fetscherin et al., 2019, 2021; Fetscherin & Heinrich, 2015; Fetscherin & Veloutsou, 2024). Existing research has focused on changes in the relationship (Alvarez et al., 2021), such as love turning to hate (Grégoire et al., 2009), ruptures that lead to divorce (Ferraz & Dallabrida, 2024), functional, symbolic, and moral transgressions triggering consumer animosity (Tolunay &

Veloutsou, 2025), in paths that evolve from neutral or disliking to brand love (Langner et al., 2016) or trajectories culminating in brand hate (Zarantonello et al., 2018). Another recent research stream has discussed polarised brands, which simultaneously have haters and lovers (X. Luo, Raithel, et al., 2013; X. Luo, Wiles, et al., 2013; Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024) but not examined multiple or mixed relationship types with the same brand (e.g., love-hate).

The literature has also focused more on positive relationships than negative ones (Bagozzi et al., 2021; Brandão & Popoli, 2022), which led some researchers to propose that brand relationship should be defined as a bond based on positive experiences (Schreuder et al., 2024). Scholars have explored the strength and intensity of relationships, proposing constructs such as brand attachment (Park et al., 2010; Shimul, 2022; Thomson et al., 2005), brand love (Batra et al., 2012; Carroll & Ahuvia, 2006; Rahman et al., 2021; Robertson et al., 2022), brand passion (Gilal et al., 2023; Swimberghe et al., 2014), brand engagement (Fernandes & Moreira, 2019), brand spirituality/sacredness (Fuschillo et al., 2024; S. Luo & Hamlin, 2022; Wang et al., 2019), and brand pride (Helm et al., 2016; Kaur & Verma, 2024).

Although consumers seem to benefit from positive interactions with brands, they might as well develop addictions to fulfil self-expression needs and status (Mrad et al., 2020), have compulsive and obsessive uncontrollable urges (Cui et al., 2018; Le, 2021), be influenced by their dark personality traits intensifying competitive behaviours (Shimul et al., 2025) or develop brand addiction as a consequence from love and jealousy (Ghorbanzadeh, 2024). Addiction is just one negative side of consumer-brand relationships since consumers can be subversive and incorporate harmful behaviours, leading them to engage proactively or reactively against firms (Wilson et al., 2022). They might take extreme measures like brand sabotage (Kähr et al., 2016) and anti-brand activism (Dessart et al., 2020; Rodrigues et al., 2021; Romani et al., 2015), or less strong reactions such as brand avoidance (Lee et al., 2009; Odoom et al., 2019). Nevertheless, most studies explored hate towards brands as a more general phenomenon, characterised as an attitude, motivation, or emotion (Mushtaq et al., 2024). There is multidimensionality in brand hate, which comprises a constellation of emotions such as dislike, fear, and hatred (Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022; Zhang & Laroche, 2020), with consumers showing passive or active brand hate (Zarantonello et al., 2016).

In sum, the literature review shows a need for further studies concerning new types of brand relationships and a lack of investigation of multiple and dynamic relationships with the same brand. There was a concentration on positive relationships and less on negative ones, with few discussions related to mixed feelings.

2.2.2 Self & Body

The way that consumer research scholars discuss the mind-self-body interrelations is first related to a contraposition between the inner self (personal) and the outer self (social) (Featherstone, 1982, 2010; Kuuru, 2022), which is a dynamic socio-cultural process that varies in a continuum (Turner et al., 1994). The social structures are embodied by constituting practices external to the person (Murphy et al., 2018), reflecting preferred social meanings and ideologies of self-control (Thompson & Hirschman, 1995). For instance, there are tensions and anxieties related to the mothering body against the exercising body (Spotswood & Gurrieri, 2024), advertising depicting women's bodies (Balog, 2024; Joy & Venkatesh, 1994), normal versus deviant personal appearances (Holbrook et al., 1998), or changes during pregnancy and immigrants' acculturation (Min & Peñaloza, 2019).

The second focus is related to the fragmentation of the post-modern self (Belk, 2017) as the extended self (Belk, 1988) transitions from a coherent and stable state to an assemblage of life narratives structured under consumer distributed networks (Thompson, 2024). Consumers are agentic and self-determined individuals with a core stable self and clear internal and external boundaries. At the same time, they are also unfinished and dynamic individuals with many porous composites in which social structures are embedded (Appau et al., 2020). Multiple embodiments separate the person from the self-identity via disembodiment and re-embodiment (Min & Peñaloza, 2019; Preece et al., 2024), which can be a permanent or transient process (Appau et al., 2020). The fragmentation can eventually lead to merging with technology or creating new versions of transhumans or even post-humans that transcend bodies and selves (Lima & Belk, 2024).

The third dialectical discussion in consumption related to mind-body-self regards perceptions and practices. Several forms of embodiment happen when consumers are involved in bodily sensorial engagements that affect their behaviours and thoughts (Merleau-Ponty, 1962; Zanette et al., 2024). For example, body techniques like swimming and motorcycling help people embed shared knowledge and social practices (Murphy et al., 2018). Consumer subcultures mingle mind, body, and senses via embodiment (Kuuru, 2022), which can help people feel inside and outside themselves, culminating in a cathartic moment (Preece et al., 2024).

Consumer research also deliberates on imaginative and subjective relationships between consumers, brands, and bodies. Even though it is impossible to escape one's body when using

masks, tattooing the skin, and putting on makeup, people are projected into an imaginary utopian body when doing so (Foucault, 2006; Roux & Belk, 2019). In this sense, brands and consumption objects are imbued with aesthetic meanings, passing through a process of aestheticisation that transforms them into sublime, beautiful, and moving things (Dagalp & Hartmann, 2022). The brands' aestheticisation is incorporated and embedded by consumers via their bodies and tattoos.

To summarise, scholars have contraposed inner (personal) versus outer (social) selves, exploring the fragmentation of the consumer identity. There is a change from a coherent state to an assemblage of narratives and distributed networks, as consumers are divided between individuals with single, finished, and stable selves to individuals with multiple, unfinished, and porous characteristics. The meanings, subcultures, and knowledge are incorporated and embedded by consumers via aesthetics, perceptions and social practices.

2.2.3 Tattoos, Culture, and Consumers

It would be possible to consider tattoos as symbols without meaning, fashion accessories or temporary body modifications (Sweetman, 1999) since they are increasingly consumed and widespread (Roux & Belk, 2019; Sierra et al., 2013). However, tattoos are different from consumption objects because they are permanent, cannot be divorced from their production, and are a combination of body modification and cultural artefacts (Sweetman, 1999). Tattoos are time markers as they inscribe memories on the body, bring continuity and stability (Steadman et al., 2019), delineate the body's limitations (Fisher, 2002), and are used as a medium to cope with life transitions (Krtalić et al., 2025). However, neither identity nor meanings attributed to tattoos are necessarily fixed in time (Owens et al., 2023; Steadman, Banister, et al., 2023).

As the self acquires meaning when expressed through an assemblage of narratives (Thompson, 2024), the same process occurs with tattoos. People tattoo themselves to control their lives and to serve as reference marks for their stories and personal myths (Oksanen & Turtiainen, 2005; Velliquette et al., 2006). Since the body is intimate and controllable, it offers a safe, close, and unique place for tattoos that remind deceased loved ones (Steadman, Medway, et al., 2023). Tattoo consumption reproduces a coherent and personalised narrative that connects the past, present, and future (Patterson, 2018).

Some authors examined how people tattoo themselves and their motivations, from aesthetics to personal narratives, affiliations, resistance, and spirituality (Wohlrab et al., 2007).

Body art is part of the extended self and brings satisfaction, but it might also lead to addiction and regret (Velliquette et al., 1998). Once considered a form of transgression, stigmatisation and marginalisation, tattoos are increasingly accepted by society, although there are still negative attitudes associated with tattooed individuals (Zestcott et al., 2018). The decision to tattoo oneself is influenced by trust in the tattooer and a desire for self-expression (Sierra et al., 2013).

Tattoos are employed in advertising, digital media, and brands as a marketing strategy. When tattoos are used in advertising, they reproduce subcultures and express the fashion industry mindset (Bjerrisgaard et al., 2013). For instance, for younger people, digital tattooed influencers are seen as unique and authentic, as their non-conventional appearance can help build trust and effectiveness (Fernandes et al., 2022). On the other hand, when athletes are sponsored to tattoo corporate logos, the connection between the consumer and the brand will be higher when there is congruence between the sport and the tattooed athlete (Weidner et al., 2016).

The literature also explored consumer identity by scrutinising tattoos through CCT. Consumers' tattoos are polysemic emblems of identity construction, agency, and deviancy, part of a body with permeable borders between self and the world (Patterson & Schroeder, 2010). Tattoos personify consumers' tensions, contraposing the body's plasticity and self-expression against the act of permanently marking it (Patterson, 2018). Tattooed individuals seek personal projects to fit themselves in better places, considering body modifications enlightening and transforming the body into an enacted mythical utopia (Roux & Belk, 2019).

Apart from discussing motivations, cultural meanings or personal narratives, some academic studies have adopted a more critical approach. The body is commodified when individuals tattoo corporate logos since it expresses loyalty to the cultural industry, particularly brands and their lifestyles (Orend & Gagné, 2009). Corporate logo tattoos reproduce symbols of capitalism, transforming people into human billboards (Orend & Gagné, 2009) and helping construct post-modern consumer identities. They can also imprison consumers as companies control the brand meanings, which might be changed according to the marketing strategy (Bengtsson et al., 2005). Nevertheless, tattooing is a way to reappropriate the physical body against the social and diseased one, resisting the cultural forces that commodified it (Fisher, 2002).

In sum, studies contrapose the permanent and transient tattoo characteristics, as memories and meanings are not unavoidably fixed. Tattoos are a collection of personal stories and myths that connect past, present, and future. They are polysemic emblems of consumers' identity projects and fragmented selves, wishing to propagate their self-expression and reappropriate their bodies. The brand tattoos are in the middle of a contrast between being creative and personalised with the dangers of becoming commodified symbols controlled by marketing strategy.

2.3 Method

This exploratory research intends to understand why individuals tattoo brands and how they make sense of them. The Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis (IPA) was adopted to answer these questions. The IPA examines the personal experience, combining phenomenological and hermeneutical approaches, and recognises the need to interpret a person's involvement with the phenomenon (Smith et al., 2009). The interpretative phenomenology method opens the expectation that previous findings will be challenged and new assumptions will be uncovered, respecting the participants' voices, actions, and texts (Benner, 2008). IPA is adequate when the researcher wants to understand the person's interaction with the phenomenon, interpreting and attempting to make meaning from it (Smith et al., 2009).

The phenomenological interview format was used to explore the participants' experience in a first-person view, allowing them to describe the phenomenon in detail (Thompson et al., 1989). The interviews followed an interview guide, opening with a non-directive question to be as unobtrusive as possible, called "grand tour" questions (McCracken, 1988): "Can you tell me about the relationship between your brand tattoos and yourself?". Additional questions covered how the person experienced brands and the decision to tattoo them, the possible regret of tattooing a brand, and how the participant would feel if the brand owner were to change the brand meanings.

Participants were recruited by snowball sampling and mainly via Instagram using hashtags such as "Coca-Cola tattoo". After that, the posted images and videos were analysed to ensure they had brand logo tattoos. The users were directly messaged and invited to participate in the research. Table 2.1 shows the list of participants and the interview duration, which lasted an average of 49 minutes. The interviews were conducted online, recorded, and transcribed verbatim. Before beginning, the interviewer explained the study's objective, that the

participation was voluntary and confidential, and that pseudonyms would be used, asking if the interviewee agreed to participate. The participants were also asked if they would consent to share a photo of their brand tattoos. The ones that agreed (12 out of 18) decided to grant the rights to use their tattoo images for academic purposes.

The inductive reasoning and axial coding were used to analyse the results, following the premises of grounded theory (Corbin & Strauss, 2015) and IPA's hermeneutical approach (Smith et al., 2009). The analysis was conducted with the support of Atlas.ti to code and categorise data. The transcripts were understood and interpreted as a whole. After that, each interview was related to each other to see commonalities, using axial coding to reduce and reassemble initial coding (Saldaña, 2013) with a mix of emic and etic perspectives.

Four global themes emerged from a higher level of abstraction (Corbin & Strauss, 2015; Smith et al., 2009; Thompson et al., 1989): close friendship and intimacy, acute bonds, catharsis and sublimation, and ideology and subculture belonging. Each theme was analysed using a hermeneutical circle approach, where the meaning of the whole text is determined by the individual parts and vice versa (Arnold & Fischer, 1994).

Table 2.1 - Research Participants.

Pseudonym	Sex	Age	Occupation	Interview Duration	# Tattoos	Tattooed Brand	Tattoo Body Location
Daniel	Male	43	Researcher, Postgraduate Student	34min	8	Univali	Back, arms, shoulders
Eric	Male	41	Lawyer, Martial Arts Instructor	57min	23	Coca-Cola	Back, arms, chest, legs, neck
James	Male	35	Digital Marketer	28min	8	Volkswagen (Kombi)	Back, arms, chest
Clara	Female	23	Accountant	37min	2	Mercedes-Benz	Arms
Peter	Male	40	Public Servant, Former Professor	43min	26*	Skol, Instagram	Arms, legs
Keith	Male	24	Stylist	59min	43*	Nike	Arms, chest, legs, abdomen
Paul	Male	40	Entrepreneur, Firearms Instructor	60min	11	Harley-Davidson	Back, arms, legs
Carol	Female	33	Agricultural Engineer	60min	3	Harley-Davidson	Back, arms
Andrew	Male	36	Teacher, IT Professional	77min	31	Linux (Tux)	Arms, shoulders
Mark	Male	22	Undergraduate (Advertising)	18min	1	Skol	Ankle
Thomas	Male	31	Entrepreneur	52min	Not disclosed*	Nike (Jordan 1 High)	Full sleeve (legs and arms), shoulders, head, neck, face, chest, abdomen
Jessica	Female	37	Journalist	48min	17	Coca-Cola (Zero Sugar)	Arms, legs, abdomen
Steven	Male	20	Undergraduate (Physical Education), Teacher	58min	7	Vans	Arms
Linda	Female	44	Nurse Technician	64min	20	Chevrolet, Opala	Back, arms, shoulders, legs, abdomen
Barbara	Female	42	Veterinarian, Former Lawyer	62min	81	Oreo, M&Ms, Nutella, Lindt, Coca-Cola, Bubbaloo, 7 Belo, Chanel, Valentino, Hermès	Back, arms, chest, shoulders, legs, neck, feet
Amanda	Female	19	Undergraduate (Advertising)	49min	7	Sony	Arms, shoulders, ankle
Melody	Female	23	Undergraduate (Astrophysics)	25min	8	M&Ms	Arms, legs, chest
Charles	Male	24	Administrative Assistant and Undergraduate (Accounting)	51min	25	Lacoste	Arms, legs, chest

* Lost count or stopped counting.

2.4 Findings

The four identified themes represent the dimensions that organise consumers' relationships with the brands they tattooed. The first two are realistic relationships, and the latter are idealistic. Close friendships are realistic and outward-directed, comprising relationships related to family ties, childhood memories, best friendship bonds, and teammates. Acute bonds are also realistic but inward-directed, surfacing sturdy connections related to therapists/patients and dealers/addicts. On the other hand, catharsis and sublimation are idealised and inward-directed relationships between gurus/disciples and soulmates. Ideological and subculture belonging are idealised and outward-directed, consisting of partisanships and nostalgic memories.

2.4.1 Close Friendship and Intimacy

The interviewees considered their tattooed brands similar to close friends. They built relationships and anthropomorphised their loved brands (Fournier, 1998), applying human-like characteristics to them (Sharma & Rahman, 2022) and reciprocating the brand's social and economic investment in customer-brand relationships (Krishna & Kim, 2021).

Best friendships concern high trust, intimacy, and attachment (Fritz et al., 2014). They also involve constant interactions, self-disclosure, self-congruity (Su et al., 2015), loyalty, dependence, mutual obligations, and social support (Price & Arnould, 1999). The participants considered their relationship with the tattooed brand as *best friends forever* (BFF), trustful and a partner when needed. Peter tattooed Skol and Instagram brands (Figure 2.1) because they helped him cope with loneliness: "Usually, on weekdays, I'm always there with a can, and it's a can of Skol, right? ... But that's because my company is Skol, you know?" Similarly, the reciprocity and mutual obligations (Price & Arnould, 1999) needed to be perpetually materialised for Mark, who tattooed Skol to represent his connection with his best friends (Figure 2.1).

The close bond between consumers and their tattoo brands can be associated with family ties and be seen as *childhood buddies*. The participants showed loyalty to brands that reminded them of their familial roots and positive associations with the past (Shields & Johnson, 2016). One example is Melody's M&M's tattoo (Figure 2.1), which makes her feel close to her family since the three M&M's letters represent each family member's favourite colour and their interpersonal relationship: "But the meaning of the tattoo, in fact, it isn't the brand, it's not that I like M&M's (although I like them a lot) ... I don't know, it's my family".

Figure 2.1 - Brand tattoos: Mark (Skol), Peter (Instagram and Skol), and Melody (M&M's).



A further friendship connection is based on partnering to achieve goals. The interviewees understood the tattooed brands as allies with whom they can work together as *teammates*. With the proper coordinated effort and embodied experiences (Kuuru, 2022; Zanette et al., 2024), it is possible to immerse oneself in the task with the brand's assistance. Eric talks about one championship in which he was reluctant to fight with heavyweight competitors and how Coca-Cola (Figure 2.2) helped him:

I went there ... bought a can of Coke at the snack bar, opened it, and drank it. Man, I felt so invigorated! I said: "I'm going to fight". Then, I fought and became the champion ... So, not as a talisman [Coke], but a bit of a placebo effect. Like, I drink Coke and feel more energetic (Eric).

The teammate relationship was also expressed by an interviewee who tattooed the Kombi (Volkswagen brand) logo to give him focus and pursue a lifetime goal. When asked how he decided to tattoo the brand, James answered: "I was very relaxed. I wasn't focused on buying a Kombi. So, I said: I'm going to do something here to look at it every day ... to think every day what I have to do to get this Kombi". Perseverance and teamwork were likewise reported by Charles, who tattooed the Lacoste crocodile on his chest at the same spot it would be in a shirt (Figure 2.2). He sees the brand as a status symbol and accessible luxury, related to his striving to succeed and increase his economic, cultural, and social capital (Bourdieu, 1984). The Lacoste tattoo also symbolises Charles' family ties with his father, who gave him his first shirt. After tattooing the brand, the connection with Lacoste even increased:

I was already a fan because it was an exclusive designer brand, with this image in the songs of reaching the top. That's why I use Lacoste: because I got one, which was my only Lacoste, which my father also had: the only Lacoste that my father got, and he gave it to me ... But after getting the tattoo, I think I started to like the brand even more (Charles).

Figure 2.2 - Brand tattoos: Eric (Coca-Cola), Charles (Lacoste), and Jessica (Coca-Cola Zero Sugar).



The participants explained how they viewed the bonds with their favourite brands, not having a stable and unique relationship but dynamic and multiple ones. For example, brands were simultaneously considered teammates to help achieve professional goals and childhood buddies. That is the case for Thomas, who tattooed Nike because he has been a fan since he was very young, and the brand is the biggest seller in his sneakers store today. Another example is the intersection of familial ties with teammates. Amanda uses her Sony camera to work, achieve her professional goals, and express her creativity and independence. At the same time, the camera is a connection with her mother, a professional photographer, and her childhood.

2.4.2 Acute Bonds

Acute bonds are concerned with the extreme personal relationships consumers have with brands. These bonds can be positive, as in a therapist and patient relationship where the brand helps the consumers cope with their problems, and, in turn, they reciprocate with higher loyalty and commitment. However, the acute relationship can also be harmful, as in an addictive bond, where the consumer feels threatened and anxious if prevented from consuming the brand.

The first acute bond regards the *dealers/addicts* relationship. Brand addiction refers to a constant urge to buy brand products and services comprising dependence, obsession, lack of self-control, hoarding, and other compulsive feelings and behaviours (Mrad & Cui, 2017). It

also involves positive affectivity, gratification, irritability, bonding, and mental and behavioural preoccupation (Cui et al., 2018).

Some participants described their relationship with the tattooed brand as beyond loyalty, with a feeling of dependency and an irresistible desire to be together with it. One example is Jessica's addictive relationship with Coca-Cola Zero Sugar. She experiences an abstinence crisis when not drinking it (bad mood), and even family members and store clerks hide some bottles in case the brand is out of stock (they know she cannot live without it). The brand tattoo (Figure 2.2) expresses Jessica's strong relationship with her favourite brand, which is anthropomorphised and compared to an animal companion who is always there with her. The brand addiction is so strong that Jessica thinks it would be a tragedy if the flavour ever changes or the brand stops being sold.

Apart from the beneficial feelings of loyalty and dedication, the negative emotions felt by the participants in their dealers-addicts relationship with the brand contrast with previous research that focused more on positive emotions and behaviours (Cui et al., 2018; Mrad & Cui, 2017). Besides the abstinence crisis that Jessica felt, Linda expressed her synchrony with the Opala brand (Figure 2.3) and her obsession with it. When her husband crashed her car, and it was a total loss, she was devastated: "It felt like a piece of me was being taken away". Tattooing the brand and the car was her creative way of compensating for her loss (Belk, 1988).

Figure 2.3 - Brand tattoos: Linda (Opala and Chevrolet) and Carol (Harley-Davidson).



The dealers-addicts relationship can represent a symbiosis between tattoos and hedonic pleasures that are impossible to resist. Barbara has two sets of brand tattoos (Figure 2.4): one

has food brands like Lindt and Oreo, and another has luxury brands like Chanel and Hermès. She faces dichotomies related to living more relaxed and joyfully (represented by the food brands) and paying tribute to glamour and sophistication (represented by luxury). Both are part of her compulsion for tattoos and brands, contrasting her new life as a veterinarian student looking to indulge herself with candies with her former life in the status-driven law business. Even though luxury brands signal admired lifestyles and bring differentiation and belonging (Mrad et al., 2020), she is conscious of their high prices. Tattooing was how she managed to own them: “Well, actually, I love Chanel, and the quickest way for me to have a Chanel bag was this tattoo [laughs]. I’m not going to spend R\$ 30,000 on a bag!”.

The other relationship that fosters acute connections is the *therapists-patients* dyad. Some participants expressed deep feelings about their tattooed brands and how they are related to dealing with depression or marking decisive life moments. Brand tattoos were therapeutic, helping them cope with troubles. Carol explained that she was not happy with her profession and job, which led to depression and a feeling that she was not listening to herself. Her life changed when she quit her job, bought a Harley-Davidson, and tattooed the logo in a visible place. Carol tattooed the brand on her arm (Figure 2.3) in a place she could see while riding her bike:

I’m always seeing it [Harley tattoo]. If I’m driving, I’m seeing it. If I’m going to say hello, I’m seeing it. So, it’s a symbol to me that [says] “You’re awesome!” ... “You rock! You’re different. Go ahead!” Because I had depression ... I had a very difficult time with depression. So, having this symbol for me does me a lot of good (Carol).

Linda also talked about her depression and anxiety crises. She mentioned a passion for drag racing and how it helped her forget her problems. When driving an Opala, Linda wants to give her best, which brings more pleasure than anything else. Her connection with tattoos, the brand, and drag racing contraposes criticisms for being a tattooed woman and not following the stereotype of a sweet nurse. The same feeling is shared with Barbara, who started tattooing when she had postpartum blues, lost a family member, and decided to change her career from lawyer to veterinarian.

Figure 2.4 - Barbara's tattoo collection: Chanel, Hermès, Valentino, Lindt, Coke, 7 Belo, Oreo, Bubbalo, Nutella, and M&M's.



2.4.3 Catharsis and Sublimation

Catharsis is the process of releasing intense emotions to cleanse and purge them (Aristotle, 1992). The result is a desired renewal brought to people, detaching them from the work of art and author and resulting in exhilaration (Frye, 1957). Brand tattoos serve as a form of revelation to the interviewees, as a cathartic moment (Oksanen & Turtiainen, 2005) to mark a turning point in their lives and a symbol of healing and salvation from a personal crisis (Velliquette et al., 2006). The brand is seen as a magical entity capable of saving the participants and restoring their lives, for which they can be grateful and devote themselves (Fuschillo et al., 2024).

Catharsis and sublimation are experienced in the *gurus/disciples* relationship. This relationship has a veneration and enchantment component (Wang et al., 2019), as participants are mesmerised by what the brand represents. It is also a totemic relationship between consumers and brands expressed by their brand tattoos. The tattoo totems signal the individual feelings of attachment ritualised in collective conduct, fixed or materialised into emblems or arbitrary signs (brand tattoos) representing the group (Lévi-Strauss, 1963).

The brand is the guru that guides disciples and enlightens their path to the greater good. The tattooed participants considered their loved brands as moral models to inspire their conduct, devoting themselves to learning from their masters and being grateful for achieving higher development. Daniel tattooed his university logo (Figure 2.5) after receiving his master's degree and starting his PhD studies. The university embraced the participant and was a tutor that

allowed him to achieve his dreams. The brand tattoo is a trophy he can display and a way to thank his guru, incorporating it into the self.

Figure 2.5 - Brand tattoos: Daniel (Univali), Clara (Mercedes), and Andrew (Linux).



The relationships between gurus/disciples are consecrated with the brand tattoo, condensing the spiritual connection and the symbolic meanings. For instance, Clara tattooed the Mercedes logo on her right arm (Figure 2.5), which she considers her spiritual side, to symbolise what she wants to accomplish as a symbol of prosperity, success, and status. Similarly, Steven believes that the most essential things in his life must be marked. His tattoos are visible on his right arm, stressing that they are indeed his “right arm”, supporting him: “For example, whenever we are going to take some kind of oath ... we always raise our right arm, you know? It’s always something that is used to symbolise”.

The consumer-brand relationship of *soulmates* triggers another cathartic and sublime experience. The soulmate theory states that there is only one right and idealised person to be loved passionately and discovered, contrasting to work-it-out theorists who believe that partners can change and be moulded (Franiuk et al., 2002). For soulmates, assuming that the partner is ideal is crucial for the satisfaction of the relationship. It can make them positively distort the perception of the idealised partner, downplaying the faults, or negatively distort them if they think they are not with the right person (Franiuk et al., 2004).

Andrew’s connection with Linux is strong and is related to collaborating with other enthusiasts: “Linux, for me, represents a philosophy, a philosophy of life: the philosophy of collaboration, that we all collaborate for the greater good”. The Linux brand is an idealised soulmate that can teach about rebellion and creativity, free from the perils of commodification and commercialisation. The Linux penguin mascot (Tux) symbolises a totem filled with the

brand's values, which Andrew tattooed to reinforce his attachment to the brand (Figure 2.5) and his communal relationship. The participant's personal myth (Oksanen & Turtiainen, 2005; Velliquette et al., 2006) is to think about the brand as a linchpin that allows his career change from music teacher to IT programmer, which interlaces with the guru and disciple relationship.

2.4.4 Ideology and Subculture Belonging

This study understands ideology and subculture belonging as a wish to be part of a cultural group of like-minded people. The participants expressed their values and related them to what they understood to be the brand's cultural codes, myths, and ideology (Holt & Cameron, 2010). They are affected by marketplace mythologies, which construct an ideal consumer lifestyle towards an ideological direction, although not free from competing interests (C. J. Thompson, 2004).

The socio-cultural and ideological relationships with the brand tattoos are expressed via partisanship and nostalgic proneness. Both are idealised views of society concerning the present and the future (partisanship) or the past (nostalgia). The brand purpose impacts them, which involves contributions to the betterment of society and transcends the company's profits (France et al., 2024). Brand activism also influences these brand-consumer relationships, as it involves the discussion and challenge of existing moral judgements via persuasion or controversies (Sibai et al., 2021) and is a result of a process that formulates, articulates, and implements the activism as a marketing strategy (Pimentel et al., 2024).

The first type of ideology and subcultural belonging is related to *partisans*. Participants expressed their ideological preferences and connected them with their brand tattoos. For example, Keith tattooed the Nike Jordan tennis to show his affinity with the brand's cultural codes and activism, which are linked to the black movement, rap and ghetto, and the bidding of fashion (streetwear) and aesthetics:

So, today, Nike is a brand that sponsors many black people, taking many activities and things to suburban areas to somehow help and collaborate with this culture, which itself created around it ... mainly in sports. So, I think there's a lot of that too, you know? ... This victory issue, the suburban issue. It's a combination of many things that led me to be part of this club, to be a fanboy, up to the point of marking my skin somehow (Keith).

Another strong subculture affiliation is outlined by Steven, who tattooed the Vans brand and its slogan ("Off the wall"). He praises the brand for sticking with skating since the

beginning, rebuffing Louis Vuitton's sponsorship of a Brazilian professional skater as illegitimate and opportunistic (Sibai et al., 2021) since it is not part of the underground spirit of skating. Steven summarises the "off the wall" subculture ideology as this:

When you skate, I think your view of the city changes. Because if you don't skate, you'll see a sidewalk. You'll say: "A sidewalk". And, if you skate, you'll look at that sidewalk and say: "Wow, that trick would be perfect here!"... So, I think this different vision would be "off the wall" (Steven).

Partisanship can also be expressed via participation in brand communities (Muñiz & O'Guinn, 2001; Schouten & McAlexander, 1995), which was the case of interviewees who tattooed the Harley-Davidson logo. However, the brand meanings and cultural influences were not the same for them. Paul engaged with aficionados of the Harley Owners Group (HOG), considering himself a brand fan stereotype and associating the brand with conservative values: "So, the Harley-Davidson owner, the Harley-Davidson guy, is a right-wing guy. That is because Harley is an American brand, right?". He cannot conceive that any Harley fan would not be close to the idealised brand consumer (e.g., Caucasian, man, tall, and strong).

Carol shares another point of view about the brand. She praises the brand's heritage, the status it brings her, and family and friendship values. On the other hand, she is empowered as a woman to strive despite struggles and win in a men's world, deciding not to be part of the HOG and ride with a women-only Harley group or with bikers who own other brands. She understands the brand from a feminist perspective, rejecting male superiority and subverting males-dominated culture (Joy & Venkatesh, 1994). The contraposition between Paul's and Carol's visions shows the competing views of Harley's marketplace mythology.

The same feeling of feminine empowerment is shared with Linda. She is part of the first women's Opala brand community (Chevrolet's car brand launched in the 1970s in Brazil). Linda explains how the members gather at events and share their experiences and passions, stating that the Opala community is 90% masculine. However, she stresses her feminist point of view that she can strive in a male-dominated environment, tattooing the Opala and Chevrolet brands (Figure 2.3) and expressing her affiliation with drag racing.

The second idealised relationship is associated with nostalgic proneness: a favourable longing for the past and days of yore (Holbrook, 1993). Nostalgia proneness is a broad concept that can be narrowed to bonded nostalgia when focussed on a particular object or childhood brand nostalgia, a positive attachment to a brand due to fond memories of one's youth (Shields

& Johnson, 2016). Brands might explore nostalgia via symbolic stories, utopian past worlds, the contrast between old and new, and authenticity (Brown et al., 2003).

Some participants thought about their tattooed brands as *vintage mates*. James has a special connection with the Kombi brand, which reminds him of the good old times and how everything was better assembled. The brand epitomises a utopian past when life was simpler and easier, as everyone could travel freely without worrying about troubles. Similarly, Linda thinks that the Opala brand is an iconic brand that reminded her of the car's history, how it was presented to the public in the 1960s and 1970s, the changes it has gone through and even that former presidents used it. The brand is her connection with this idealised past, which is consecrated via an old car brand community.

2.5 Discussion and Conclusion

2.5.1 Theoretical Contributions

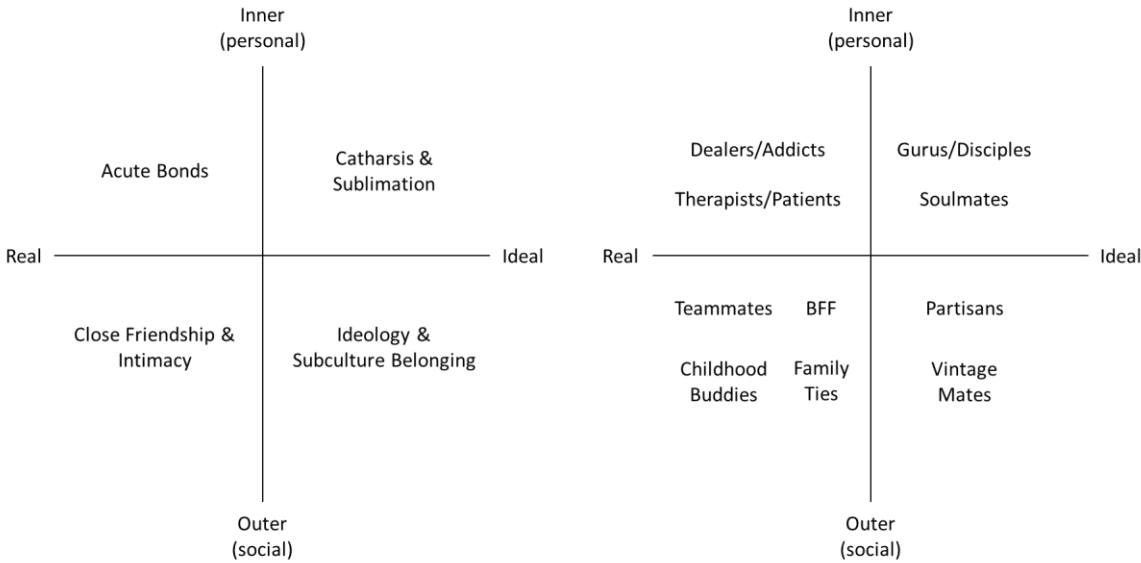
This paper's objective was to understand why consumers tattoo brands and how this phenomenon contributes to their identity projects. This research's first major contribution concerns identifying new or under-theorised brand-consumer relationships, which answers a call to expand and diversify the coverage of relationships (Alvarez et al., 2023). The second significant contribution adds to the literature that consumers can have multiple and dynamic relationships with the same brand since they transit between a core stable self and a multiple porous one (Appau et al., 2020).

First, this research extends the brand relationship literature by presenting new types of brand-consumer relationships (Table 2.2). Previous studies have pinpointed and commented on some of these relationships, such as best friendships (Alvarez et al., 2023; Fournier, 1998; Fritz et al., 2014), childhood friendships (Fournier, 1998; Shields & Johnson, 2016), dealers/addicts, therapists/patients, teammates, and soulmates (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013). However, they have neither defined nor explained how consumers could express them. The brand-consumer relationships are organised under four quadrants, depicted in Figure 2.6. The first axis concerns consumers' inner and outer connections, and the second refers to the realistic and idealised bonds with brands.

Recent research has conceptualised the relationships between consumers and brands (Schreuder et al., 2024), stating that consumers experience them as more functional and less emotionally intense. Nevertheless, the inner consumer-brand relationships show that the

interviewees undergo deep feelings in a relationship exchange, benefiting from the interaction (Veloutsou, 2007) and creating a bond and a sense of oneness with the brand (Yoshida et al., 2021). These relationships can be mixed-valenced as some participants expressed their addiction to brands (Cui et al., 2018; Ghorbanzadeh, 2024; Mrad & Cui, 2017) while others sought therapeutical and soulful characteristics in them (Franiuk et al., 2002, 2004; Fuschillo et al., 2024). Brand tattoos end up acting as mnemonic signs of crucial events (Steadman et al., 2019), giving meaning to life (S. Luo & Hamlin, 2022).

Figure 2.6 - Dimensions and types of brand-consumer relationships.



Source: author’s own work.

On the other hand, the outer consumer-brand relationships show that consumers are not simply human billboards (Baudrillard, 1998; Orend & Gagné, 2009), contained in predefined stereotypes (Bjerrisgaard et al., 2013), commodified bodies (Bengtsson et al., 2005; Orend & Gagné, 2009) or reflecting the cultural industry message (Horkheimer & Adorno, 2002). The practices, knowledge, and brands’ cultural discourses are incorporated (Kuuru, 2022; Murphy et al., 2018; Spotswood & Gurrieri, 2024) as a person’s sense of self is constructed by interconnections of the body with society (Merleau-Ponty, 1962).

On the realistic and idealistic axis, consumers seek down-to-earth relationships based on close familial and friendship ties or as comfort for their troubles and problems. At the same time, they develop idealised bonds with brands, using their brand tattoos as totems (Lévi-Strauss, 1963), reinscribing and reinforcing group affiliation (Razmus, 2025) and subculture belonging (Fisher, 2002), and being affected by media culture imagery (Velliquette et al., 1998).

Interviewees are proud to be part of marketplace cultures (Patterson, 2018; Patterson & Schroeder, 2010) while simultaneously expressing themselves as cultural producers.

Contrapositions and contradictions exist in the brand-consumer relationships, which place one foot in reality and another in idealisation. For example, brand tattoos can empower participants, particularly women, to resignify brand values, incorporate them to fit their life stories, and not be subject to dominance, submissiveness, and weakness (Balog, 2024; Foucault, 1995). However, they might as well reinforce prejudice and be incorporated by consumers as a type of polarised partisanship (Schoenmueller et al., 2022), which could lead to boycotts, boycotts (Flecha-Ortiz et al., 2024) and culture wars (Hashmi et al., 2025). The idealised relationships are also ambiguous since they positively and negatively distort brand characteristics, potentially triggering passionate consumer behaviours and emotions that can impact brand equity.

Finally, this research shows how consumers build their sense of self through brands (Holt, 2002; Razmus, 2025), cultivating multiple relationships with them and broadcasting their brand commitment through dynamic bonds. Brand tattoos symbolise polysemic and incomplete meanings, representing a search for a desired and stable self (Appau et al., 2020) that stands out and reclaims the body. They also reinforce individuality by representing personal life stories, homages, and myths (McAdams, 1993; Oksanen & Turtiainen, 2005; Steadman, Medway, et al., 2023; Velliquette et al., 2006).

Table 2.2. - Brand relationship types

Dimension	Relationship	Definition	Representative Quotation	Interviewees
Close Friendship & Intimacy	Best Friends Forever (BFF)	A solid and close interpersonal relationship with someone who shares similar worldviews. It is characterised by affection, social support, trust, self-disclosure, self-congruity, and intimacy.	“I was talking to myself, something like: but, since I like to drink one [beer] every now and then and such, why not pay homage ... why not mark [the Skol brand] then? Since everything for me is so symbolic, and there comes a time when beer also keeps you company.” (Peter)	Andrew, Carol, Eric, James, Jessica, Keith, Mark, Paul, Peter, Steven
Close Friendship & Intimacy	Family Ties	A long-term intimate relationship between members of the nuclear and extended family. Feelings of safety, nurturance, commitment, respect, and emotional understanding characterise it.	“And the M&M’s [the tattoo] ... I did it for my family because, in my family, everybody starts with an M ... Thus, our WhatsApp group was always M&M’s. So, I picked the favourite colour of each one and tattooed M&M’s here.” (Melody)	Amanda, Barbara, Charles, Melody
Close Friendship & Intimacy	Childhood Buddies	A long-time mutually-reciprocated friendship that was formed and built when one was young. The relationship evokes good memories and emotional support across the years.	“I started following Vans when I was about twelve years old... So, from the age of twelve onwards, that's when I started to have more of a sense of the brand, of really getting into skateboarding because this could be cool, it could be a sport, it could be a thing, a skill that I have.” (Steven)	Amanda, Barbara, Eric, Jessica, Melody, Steven
Close Friendship & Intimacy	Teammates	Enduring commitment by group members where each contributes to effectively achieving a goal. The relationship requires that the teammates know their roles, trust and complement each other, and work as partners.	“I sell sneakers, and today my biggest supplier is Nike. Whether you like it or not, this is part of my business. It’s what makes me earn money: there’s no way around it.” (Thomas)	Amanda, Andrew, Charles, Clara, Eric, James, Peter, Thomas
Acute Bonds	Dealers/Addicts	An obsessive relationship where the person is devoted and dependent on another. It involves feelings of distress, anxiety and uneasiness as if the person is unable to live without a loved partner.	“Coca-Cola Zero Sugar is really my addiction. There are days when I wake up, and I believe it even changes my mood.” (Jessica)	Eric, Jessica, Linda

Acute Bonds	Therapists/Patients	It is a working alliance between therapist and patient where both develop bonds and strive to achieve goals based on the patient's concerns. The relationship evolves under a friendly and affectionate feeling towards a beneficial and healthy change in the patient.	"I'm always seeing it [Harley tattoo]. If I'm driving, I'm seeing it. If I'm going to say hello, I'm seeing it. So, it's a symbol to me that [says] 'You're awesome!' ... 'You rock! You're different. Go ahead!' Because I had depression ... I had a very difficult time with depression. So, having this symbol for me does me a lot of good." (Carol)	Barbara, Carol, Linda, Peter, Steven
Catharsis & Sublimation	Gurus/Disciples	A committed relationship in which the person devotes love and respect to a guru. The relationship is based on helping the disciples search and improve their inner selves.	"Because this was an achievement, something I never imagined I would do: a master's degree, a doctorate. And I did the Univali tattoo when I started my doctorate ... I'm going to get the Univali tattoo, which was an institution that embraced me, that... I don't know, I have a very good relationship with Univali, you know?" (Daniel)	Charles, Clara, Daniel, James, Steven, Thomas
Catharsis & Sublimation	Soulmates	It is a powerful bond that makes one believe there is only one right person to be passionately loved and discovered. It is an idealised relationship that positively distorts perceptions, allowing one to consider the partner as the perfect fit, dismissing problems and avoiding conflict.	"I don't think about tattooing other brands. '[Andrew], why tattoo Tux?', because I don't see Tux as a brand. I think it's not a brand: it's a symbol of a philosophy, you know? It's a symbol of a story because you don't see anyone charging for it; you can use the little penguin wherever you want." (Andrew)	Andrew, Daniel, Keith, Paul
Ideology & Subculture Belonging	Partisans	Ideological identification with values and beliefs of one socio-cultural or political group. Partisanship can be positive and expressive, as part of the core self-concept, or negative and extreme, where the person strengthens their prejudices and is willing to defeat opponents.	"It's been seven, eight years since Trump became president of the United States. There was a politicisation of motorcycling ... So, the Harley-Davidson owner, the Harley-Davidson guy, is a right-wing guy. This is already evident because Harley is an American brand, right?" (Paul)	Andrew, Carol, Keith, Linda, Paul, Steven
Ideology & Subculture Belonging	Vintage Mates	Admiration for an idealised and nostalgic earlier era. It is a longing feeling for the past, bringing warmth and comfort to the person.	"It has always been my dream to have a Kombi, I think, for several reasons. Because of the stories my grandfather used to tell me about how he would travel in a Kombi with my mother and uncle, and he would just put a mattress in there and sleep." (James)	James, Jessica, Linda

Source: author's own work.

2.5.2 Managerial Implications

Marketers aim to build strong customer relationships and create and sustain iconic brands. The first practical implication of this study is that adopting a cultural strategy for a brand pays off. Highly attached consumers have deep emotional connections with brands, expressing their authenticity and values by tattooing them. Brand-tattooed consumers can be considered cultural brand codes, reinforcing the brand's identity and personality. Understanding their behaviour and bonds with loved brands can guide marketers in developing their cultural strategies and avoiding culture wars (Hashmi et al., 2025).

Companies should be aware of consumers' multiple relationships with their brands. They need to understand the different types of bonds and how they are formed. Through brand tattoos, consumers signal a solid relationship and manifest their sturdy bonds. However, they can also broadcast their relationship strength via different expressions, such as cosplay or cult-like interactions. Marketers need to identify the cues that tie consumers and brands and understand what types of relationships they fit in. For example, a guru/disciple relationship could require more counselling, while subcultural belonging should be enhanced for partisanship connections.

The findings also show that consumers might present mixed feelings, either negative or positive, and ambiguous relationships with brands. They can resist brand identity changes or twist it to fit their cultural values, reinforcing prejudices or stereotypes. The implication for practitioners is strategically managing the relationship types and fostering initiatives to influence positive behaviours and affection while minimising negative ones.

2.5.3 Limitations and Future Research

This paper presents some limitations that need to be pointed out. Only participants in Brazil were interviewed, although with a balanced sample regarding age, gender, and number of tattoos. Since the brand tattoo phenomenon is global, the perspectives of other cultures might differ from what has been concluded in this paper. Interviews were conducted with consumers who have tattooed mainly consumer goods brands but not B2B, sports teams, or music bands. Future studies could compare the types of brand tattoos and understand if their meanings are different.

Future research could study other dynamic and multiple relationships between brands and consumers. Understanding how these diverse relationships affect brand identity,

personality, equity, and other brand constructs is necessary. Scholars should also investigate harmful relationship types, how they are formed and stimulated, and the consequences for brand management. It would be interesting to compare single with dynamic relationships and negative with positive ones, adding to the attachment-aversion theoretical proposal (Park et al., 2013a, 2013b) and the recent polarisation research stream (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, 2024).

Further research should also look into how archetypes and storytelling interact with brand tattoos and the psychological implications for brands. Are tattoos enacting personal archetypes or reflecting brand ones? How can both co-exist? Researchers could study the relationship between brand tattoos and other tattoos on consumer bodies. Since they also tattoo unbranded products and symbols, what are their connections?

CHAPTER 3 – POSITIVE-NEGATIVE POLES: POLARISED BRANDS²

3.1 Introduction

Polarising brands attract both lovers and haters, aiming to boost positive outcomes while avoiding harmful consequences (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019). The more polarised a brand is, the greater the heterogeneity in evaluations, which has a direct impact on stock returns but with lower risk due to less price sensitivity or brand switching (Luo et al., 2013). Relying on polarised brands can be advantageous because they offer stronger self-expression, distinctiveness, and a sense of belonging (Berendt et al., 2018; Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019). On the other hand, intense rivalry can lead to avoidance, trash-talking, schadenfreude, and harmful actions (Liao et al., 2023; Marticotte et al., 2016), impacting brand equity (Luo et al., 2013; Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014).

Brand polarisation differs from brand rivalry since it involves the simultaneous presence of love and hate, not necessarily requiring a feud or a strong opponent (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024). Brand rivalry is a particular type of polarisation in which, instead of considering strong feelings towards one brand, two rivals are considered (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019). While polarised brands have been scarcely theorised and studied (Monahan et al., 2023; Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, 2024), brand rivalry has received more attention in the literature. It has been conceptualised as oppositional brand loyalty since consumers define themselves by what they consume and do not (Muñiz and Hamer, 2001). The rivalry is considered an ongoing battle between competing brands (Alvarado-Karste and Kidwell, 2022; Berendt et al., 2018, 2024), is driven by consumer-brand identification (Liao et al., 2021), and enhanced by participation in brand communities (Cheng et al., 2024; Thompson and Sinha, 2008).

Although brand polarisation studies addressed its conceptualisation (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019), proposed a scale to measure it (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024), analysed the effect of hate-acknowledging ads (Monahan et al., 2023), and the impact on stock returns and risk (Luo et al., 2013), there is a gap in the literature on understanding the conditions that foster brand polarisation (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019), how consumers behave toward it, and the similarities

² This article was published on the Journal of Product & Brand Management with the following title: “The lightning rod effect: salvation and damnation in polarised brands”. Doi: 10.1108/JPBM-08-2025-6237.

and differences between negative and positive feelings concerning polarised brands (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024).

This paper aims to address this lacuna by posing the following research questions. *RQ1: Why do polarised brands elicit antagonistic consumers' feelings and behaviours? RQ2: How does this polarisation process unfold?* Previous research investigated polarised feelings of love and hate toward brands (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, 2024) but did not seek to understand why particular brands evoke those feelings. Drawing from studies that identified polarised brands and brand rivalries (Berendt et al., 2018; Cheng et al., 2024; Luo et al., 2013; Monahan et al., 2023; Muñiz and Hamer, 2001; Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019; Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014), five brands were chosen since they trigger intense polarisation: Apple, Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé, and Starbucks.

This exploratory study interviewed consumers to understand their relationships with polarised brands, adopting the Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis method (Smith et al., 2009) to investigate the significance of the phenomenon and how consumers experience it, as most research in brand polarisation and oppositional brand loyalty relied on quantitative methods. The main contribution of this paper concerns understanding the brand polarisation phenomenon more broadly as a *lightning rod effect*. This effect occurs because polarised brands elicit strong responses from consumers, who consider them as either iconic (loved) or anti-iconic (hated), precipitating four distinct emotional states: brand salvation, brand damnation, brand ambiguity, and brand agnosticism. They are driven by underlying, basic individual values (Schwartz et al., 2012) and the expectations associated with the brand promise (Bhargava & Bedi, 2022).

3.2 Literature Review

3.2.1 Brand Relationship Extremes: Love and Hate

The brand relationship literature has been growing over the last decades, investigating consumer-brand deep bonds, polarity, and strength (Fetscherin and Veloutsou, 2024). It has developed under diverse streams of brand loyalty, love, community, self-connection, and storytelling (Fetscherin and Heinrich, 2015). Drawing from the seminal initial works that identified different types of relationships (Fournier, 1998), scholars have discussed intense affectionate connections such as brand love (Batra et al., 2012; Carroll and Ahuvia, 2006; Robertson et al., 2022), hate (Kucuk, 2019; Mushtaq et al., 2024; Zarantonello et al., 2016; Zhang and Laroche, 2020), and passion (Gilal et al., 2023).

Depending on the degree of intensity, the brand-consumer relationship can vary from brand satisfaction or indifference to love and hate (Fetscherin et al., 2021). The brand love and hate constructs are related to brand attachment, which is associated with self-brand interrelations and prominence (Park et al., 2010). To measure the strength of emotional attachment, scholars identified three first-order dimensions: affection, passion, and connection (Thomson et al., 2005).

Another perspective analysed both brand attachment and aversion, including consumers' negative relationships with brands (Park et al., 2013). However, this model was criticised for not adequately capturing these negative relationships, as they are not necessarily the opposite of positive ones (Fournier and Alvarez, 2013). For example, some relationships (e.g., secret affairs and masters-slaves) are mixed-valenced and imbalanced. In contrast, others are neutral, lying midway on the attachment-aversion continuum (Fournier and Alvarez, 2013).

Although studies have explored the extremes of brand love and hate, less attention has been given to other brand-consumer relationships, and most research has focused on broader marketplace phenomena instead of scrutinising one type of relationship (Alvarez et al., 2023). Additionally, recent research has explored the phenomenon of love turning to hate (Tolunay and Veloutsou, 2025), but few studies have investigated ambivalent, contradictory, and mixed-emotion relationships.

3.2.2 Oppositional Brand Loyalty

Scholars have studied rivalries between brands, such as Coke versus Pepsi, coining the term oppositional brand loyalty to describe antagonistic choices that help consumers define themselves (Muñiz & Hamer, 2001). Previous research has identified the ambivalent effect of rivalries (Berendt et al., 2018; Luo et al., 2013), focusing on their negative consequences. The intense competition leads to *schadenfreude*, which is the pleasure felt from others' misfortune (Cheng et al., 2024; Marticotte et al., 2016; Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014), and to trash-talking against contestants (Ewing et al., 2013; Liao et al., 2023; Marticotte et al., 2016; Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014). Stronger feelings may also be elicited by brand rivalry, such as anti-brand actions (Cheng et al., 2024), rumination, resentment, and feelings of unfairness (Alvarado-Karste and Kidwell, 2022), as well as a desire to harm the opposing brand (Marticotte et al., 2016).

The rivalry between brands influences not only the consumers' behaviour, but also represents a risk to brand equity (Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014), lower stock

performance (Luo et al., 2013), a threat to consumer identity (Liao et al., 2021), and, if used in communication pieces, it might backfire (Berendt et al., 2024). On the other hand, studies have identified positive aspects of oppositional brand loyalty, such as defending the brand that is under attack (Muñiz and Hamer, 2001), reinforcing the brand's distinction and uniqueness (Berendt et al., 2018), ingroup identification (Ewing et al., 2013; Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014), engagement, and willingness to pay a premium price (Cheng et al., 2024).

Studies have also debated the antecedents of brand rivalry regarding three main aspects: brand, self-identification, and engagement with rivals. The brand aspects that influence oppositional brand loyalty include brand prestige, uniqueness (Liao et al., 2021), and loyalty (Marticotte et al., 2016). Consumer self-brand connection (Liao et al., 2021; Marticotte et al., 2016), moral identification (Cheng et al., 2024), identification with the preferred brand (Liao et al., 2023; Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas, 2014), and disidentification with the opponent brand (Liao et al., 2023) concern the psychological motivations that enhance rivalries. Regarding the engagement with rivals, the literature identified as crucial aspects of oppositional brand loyalty the brand community participation (Ewing et al., 2013; Marticotte et al., 2016; Muñiz and Hamer, 2001; Thompson and Sinha, 2008) and long-running rivalry history (Alvarado-Karste and Kidwell, 2022; Berendt et al., 2024; Ewing et al., 2013; Muñiz and Hamer, 2001).

3.2.3 Brand Polarisation

Brand polarisation is defined as “an affective phenomenon where beliefs and emotions of a significant number of people induce a simultaneous move to the extremes involving passionate positive and negative feelings and convictions towards the brand, like-minded consumers and opposite-minded consumers” (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, p. 620). However, few studies have investigated brand polarisation (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019), as it remains underdeveloped in the literature (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024) and has received limited attention (Monahan et al., 2023).

The brand polarisation construct was conceptualised based on characteristics from political science, social psychology, polarised products, and oppositional brand loyalty (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019). Polarisation in political science refers to partisanship, the tendency to identify with one party, viewing co-partisans positively and adversaries negatively (Iyengar & Westwood, 2015). Polarisation can be affective and lead to animosity, but it is not necessarily ideological (Iyengar et al., 2019). Polarised feelings shape consumption patterns, as consumers acquire products as a defence mechanism against events that threaten their identity or group

affiliation, such as the election of an opposing party or when a brand takes a political or ideological stand (Schoenmueller et al., 2022).

Brands face a double-edged approach to polarisation. Their communication might lead to boycotts and buycotts (Flecha-Ortiz et al., 2024), and their marketing communication might be seen as a moral failure (Biedenbach, 2025). Brand activism could be considered inconsistent (Malik et al., 2025), trigger advocacy or backfire (Kim & He, 2025). Nevertheless, remaining politically silent can be seen as a betrayal and a lack of care (Zaman Malik et al., 2025).

In social psychology, scholars have studied group polarisation. When exposed to group discussions, individuals adjust their position to maintain social desirability (Myers & Lamm, 1976), not deviating significantly from their ideal position and remaining close to the group's central one (Isenberg, 1986). Polarisation happens when there is a shift toward the preferred pole, while extremisation is the movement away from neutrality (Myers & Lamm, 1976). This change depends on the number and strength of pro and con arguments, but they will be considered invalid and unpersuasive if there is intense animosity toward an outgroup (Isenberg, 1986).

Past research has applied social psychology and political science definitions and concepts to brand polarisation, revisiting the oppositional brand loyalty construct (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, 2024). In this sense, brand rivalries were considered a special type of polarisation involving intense hatred and love among supporters and detractors toward two opposing brands rather than one (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019).

Although the literature has discussed consumers' perceptions about the advertising of polarised brands (Monahan et al., 2023), the performance of polarised brands in the stock market (X. Luo, Raithel, et al., 2013), and identified the dimensions of brand polarisation (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024), there is a gap on understanding why and how particular brands evoke polarisation, which the present research aims to fill. More exploratory research is also needed since most papers employed a quantitative research strategy (Table 3.1), primarily using structural equation modelling and conducting experiments.

Table 3.1 - Relevant articles on oppositional brand loyalty and brand polarisation.

Authors	Approach	Method / Analysis	Focus	Brands Rivalry / Polarisation
Muñiz and Hamer (2001)	Qualitative	Ethnography	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Coca-Cola vs Pepsi.
Thompson and Sinha (2008)	Quantitative	Hazard Modeling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Intel vs AMD.
Ewing et al. (2013)	Qualitative	Ethnography	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Ford vs Holden.
Kuo and Feng (2013)	Quantitative	Structural Equation Modelling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Ford, Honda, Mazda, Mitsubishi, Nissan, and Toyota.
Phillips-Melancon and Dalakas (2014)	Quantitative	Survey	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Apple vs Microsoft.
Angell et al. (2016)	Quantitative	Structural Equation Modelling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Newcastle United vs Sunderland.
Marticotte et al. (2016)	Quantitative	Structural Equation Modelling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	PlayStation vs Xbox.
Kuo and Hou (2017)	Quantitative	Structural Equation Modeling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Ford, Honda, Mitsubishi, and Nissan.
Berendt et al. (2018)	Quantitative	Experiment	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Apple vs Samsung and Nike vs Adidas.
Liao et al. (2021)	Quantitative	Survey	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Smartphone brands.
Alvarado-Karste and Kidwell (2022)	Quantitative	Experiment	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Red Bull vs Monster.
Liao et al. (2023)	Quantitative	Structural Equation Modelling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Smartphone brands.
Berendt et al. (2024)	Quantitative	Experiment and Archival Study	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Borussia Dortmund vs Schalke, McDonald's vs Burger King, Coca-Cola vs Pepsi, and T-Mobile vs Verizon.
Cheng et al. (2024)	Quantitative	Structural Equation Modelling	Oppositional Brand Loyalty	Xiaomi vs competitors.

Luo, Wiles, et al. (2013)	Conceptual	Conceptual	Brand Polarisation	Acer, Apple, BP, Coca-Cola, HP, McDonald's, Microsoft, Nike, Starbucks, T-Mobile.
Luo, Raithel, et al. (2013)	Quantitative	Dynamic Modeling	Brand Polarisation	Acer, Apple, BP, Coca-Cola, HP, McDonald's, Microsoft, Nike, Starbucks, T-Mobile.
Rozenkrants et al. (2017)	Quantitative	Experiment	Product Polarisation	N/A
Osuna Ramírez et al. (2019)	Qualitative and Conceptual	Systematic Literature Review and Interviews	Brand Polarisation	Several, including Apple, BP, Coca-Cola, Nestlé, Nike, Pepsi, Samsung, and Starbucks.
Monahan et al. (2023)	Quantitative	Experiment	Brand Polarisation	Apple, Chick-Fil-A, and Crocs.
Osuna Ramírez et al. (2024)	Qualitative and Quantitative	Scale Development	Brand Polarisation	N/A

Source: author's own work.

It is essential to understand the similarities and differences between positive and negative emotions toward a polarised brand (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024) and to examine further the reasons for fostering brand polarisation (e.g., consumers becoming detractors and supporters) (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019). It is also unclear whether polarising brands trigger only brand love and hate relationships or if they might have ambivalent and mixed-valenced connections with consumers (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013).

3.3 Method

The Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis was employed in this research, as it is suitable for understanding consumers' relationships with the world, focusing on the attempt to interpret and make sense of their behaviours and activities (Smith et al., 2009). The emphasis is on analysing the informants' experiences and points of view, grasping the phenomenon's essence and broad cultural perspective (Spiggle, 1994).

The interpretative phenomenology method enables researchers to uncover new assumptions and challenge existing ones (Benner, 2008). It also stresses that reality is socially constructed, multiple, holistic, and contextual, and that it involves an interactive and interpretive research relationship (Hudson & Ozanne, 1988). As the brand polarisation phenomenon is scarcely researched and underdeveloped (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2024), interpretative phenomenology can yield new understandings and propositions by combining phenomenological and hermeneutical insights.

Since this work aims to investigate why particular polarised brands elicit negative and positive feelings and behaviours, five brands were selected: Apple, Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé, and Starbucks. These brands were chosen based on past research on oppositional brand loyalty and brand polarisation (Table 3.1). To recruit consumers to participate in the study, the authors searched online communities on Reddit and Instagram posts using the brand's name and negative keywords such as "fuck", "boycott", or "sucks". The same process was undertaken using the brand's name and positive keywords such as "love", "enthusiast", and "fan". The authors scrutinised the posts to ensure that the users were active members, directly messaging and inviting them to participate in the research.

In-depth online interviews were conducted in English, Portuguese, and Spanish, with 26 consumers from the selected brands (13 lovers and 13 haters), as seen in Table 3.2. The interviews were recorded and transcribed verbatim, lasting an average of 61 minutes. Verbal consent was obtained during the interview, with participants informed that it was confidential,

voluntary, and recorded, in accordance with procedures approved by the local ethics committee. Data collection ceased when theoretical saturation was reached, as the sample was deemed adequate for theory development, and further efforts would lead to redundancy or the discovery of minor new elements (Saunders et al., 2018).

The software Atlas.ti was used to codify and analyse the data. The codification considered the grounded theory premises (Corbin & Strauss, 2015), using structural coding as the first cycle method and axial coding as the second (Saldaña, 2013). The data structure was organised into first-order concepts, second-order themes, and aggregate dimensions, following the Gioia methodology to explain the phenomenon of interest with increasing abstractness (Gioia et al., 2012). The hermeneutical circle was employed to complement the interpretative phenomenology, allowing for the understanding of the meanings of the entire set of interviews as determined by the individual elements, and vice versa (Arnold & Fischer, 1994).

Table 3.2 - Research participants.

#	Pseudonym	Sex	Age	Country	Occupation	Brand	Affection	Duration
1	Peter	Male	36	UK	New Business Development	Nestlé	Hate	58min
2	Roger	Male	28	Argentina	Plastic Artist	Coca-Cola	Hate	61min
3	Amelia	Female	22	Denmark	Gastronomy Student	Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé	Hate	60min
4	Evelyn	Female	48	Portugal	Yoga Teacher	Apple, McDonald's, Nestlé	Hate	52min
5	Henry	Male	30	UK	Supply Chain	McDonald's, Nestlé, Starbucks	Hate	70min
6	Dylan	Male	27	Denmark	Post-Graduate Student	Nestlé	Hate	56min
7	Jack	Male	27	USA	R&D Engineer	Apple	Hate	71min
8	Violet	Female	35	USA	Finance	Coca-Cola, Nestlé	Hate	70min
9	Oliver	Male	25	Brazil	Dentist	Apple, Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé	Hate	69min
10	Edward	Male	31	Canada	Ramp Agent	Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé, Starbucks	Hate	44min
11	Finley	Male	32	Brazil	Energy Engineer	McDonald's	Hate	73min
12	Karen	Female	43	Canada	University Staff	Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé, Starbucks	Hate	72min
13	Albert	Male	26	USA	Engineer	Apple, Nestlé, Starbucks	Hate	63min
14	Theo	Male	18	USA / Venezuela	Undergraduate Student	McDonald's	Love	64min
15	Freddie	Male	35	Romania	Freelancer	Coca-Cola	Love	33min
16	Cooper	Male	26	USA	Server	Apple, Coca-Cola	Love	55min
17	Lucas	Male	65	USA	Marketing	Apple, Coca-Cola	Love	78min
18	Aaron	Male	33	UK	Influencer	McDonald's	Love	44min
19	Hudson	Male	21	Brazil	Business Analyst	Apple	Love	70min
20	Eleanor	Female	62	USA / Lebanon	Quality Assurance	Apple, Starbucks	Love	57min
21	Ava	Female	30	USA	Administrative Support	Apple, Starbucks	Love	53min
22	Mia	Female	56	Brazil	Sales	McDonald's, Nestlé	Love	58min
23	Stanley	Male	50	USA	Security	Coca-Cola, Starbucks	Love	105min
24	Penelope	Female	20	Brazil	Undergraduate Student	Apple, McDonald's, Nestlé	Love	56min
25	Charlotte	Female	18	Brazil	Undergraduate Student	McDonald's, Nestlé	Love	43min
26	Iris	Female	47	Brazil	Healthcare	Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé	Love	68min

3.4 Findings

Four aggregate dimensions emerged from the data collected from the interviews. The first dimension is named *brand salvation*, as consumers viewed their favourite brands as idealised and trustworthy partners, with whom they had a strong positive attachment and a self-brand bond. These interviewees adhered to a teleological approach to ethics, morally evaluating actions by their consequences (Macdonald & Beck-Dudley, 1994). The second dimension concerns the opposite pole, referred to as *brand damnation*, as participants had strong negative feelings towards polarised brands because they felt betrayed, considered that brands violated moral and ethical codes, and wanted to get back at them by boycotting or spreading negative word of mouth. These participants followed a deontological approach to ethics, judging actions by their characteristics rather than their consequences (Macdonald & Beck-Dudley, 1994). The third dimension, *brand agnosticism*, considers how detached or indifferent participants felt towards polarised brands, being more concerned with utilitarian benefits rather than showing positive or negative affections. The final dimension, *brand ambiguity*, is related to a mix of love and hate, as consumers had conflicted relationships and feelings towards polarised brands.

3.4.1 Brand Salvation

In brand salvation, brands are used as a symbolic system of positive precepts to cultivate virtue and promote finer qualities (Douglas, 2001). Salvation is a spiritual goal achieved through efforts that contribute to that end, and it has implications for how individuals should behave morally (McCleary, 2007). Past research has explored how brands act as a conduit for revelation and healing (Fuschillo et al., 2024) and how consumers develop a spiritual relationship with them (Ryu et al., 2025). Ultimately, brands achieve sacredness when consumers believe they are superior, enchanting (mesmerised by their powers), and evoke a sense of social community (Wang et al., 2019).

The participants viewed their preferred brands as idealised partners, whom they unquestioningly trusted to provide a good experience whenever they bought their products. Theo explains that he always goes to McDonald's because he loves the experience and sometimes because it gives him a happy ending to his day. He started going out with one girl, but had a hard time since she did not like the brand: "I can't figure out where to go out with her (...) It's a little weird to go to the mall and not to McDonald's afterwards. They're sort of glued together. And my fondness for her is definitely a little affected". Theo is rethinking the relationship because they cannot share the same passion for McDonald's.

Trusting brands brings comfort, as interviewees feel taken care of and provided with everything they need. When asked about the Apple ecosystem, Lucas thinks that it brings security and protection from viruses and other problems, even helping him with a potential health issue, detected when wearing an Apple Watch: “But it also saved my life. It’s provided me a health alert that indicated that I had a heart condition that I didn’t know I had, so I’m very fond of that”. The same feeling is shared by Hudson, who sees his relationship with Apple as akin to marriage, forgiving minor problems that happened along the way.

The love for the brand can be very intense and often stems from a strong connection with family members. When asked to describe Nestlé as if it were a person, Mia answered that it would be like her mother or her son, associating the brand with traditional values and family bonding. Similarly, Iris connects Nestlé with birthday parties, family gatherings, and sweet memories: “If I make a pudding with condensed milk from another brand, it won’t have that ‘mother’s taste’, that ‘grandmother’s taste’”. Ava has the same familial feelings, talking about being connected with Starbucks since she first met her wife in a store, going there frequently with her professor and mentor, and feeling welcomed as part of a community.

Another aspect of loving brands involves considering them as something special or unique to be savoured. The interviewees saw their relationships with their loved brands as a way to cheer them up, as explained by Aaron. As an autistic, he is loyal to reliable brands, searching for comfort and hedonism: “I like getting excited. And the joy that you get from it and the feel, the escapism that you get from going and just escaping everyday life”. Eleanor discussed her connection with Starbucks and how the brand was vital to maintaining her peace of mind, interacting with the baristas, and refuelling her energy.

Apart from refuelling and escapism, Stanley also consumes polarised brands to display his sense of achievement and power. He feels proud of what he has accomplished after a difficult childhood in a family with a below-average income. Stanley later faced problems when divorced from his wife, turning to Starbucks and Coke as his salvation: “So, I’m gonna have what I want within what my financial means are. And I don’t really care what anybody else says. And one of those things, a big thing, is food that I like and drinks that I like”. In the same sense, Penelope explained how owning an Apple iPhone is a significant achievement that sets her apart from others and makes her feel accepted.

Participants considered the loved brands as aesthetically appealing, perceiving them as beautiful, sublime, and moving (Dagalp & Hartmann, 2022). Some interviewees were drawn to

the brand's identity, such as Cooper, who is fond of Apple and Coke because he enjoys advertising and the appeal both brands have. As a marketing person, Lucas also praises iconic brands (Apple and Coke) and their branding. However, he explains that aesthetics and utility must work together, which is what he appreciates in the brands he loves.

3.4.2 Brand Damnation

Contrasting with brand salvation, brand damnation is used by consumers as a symbolic system to suppress evil and combat vice, anomalous, polluted and aberrant events (Douglas, 2001). Unlike previous research that investigated the journey of salvation by a brand (Fuschillo et al., 2024), brand evangelism and ritualism (Wang et al., 2019), and brand faith (Ryu et al., 2025), this paper addresses the opposite religious meaning of damnation. Damnation happens when the moral wrongdoings are not forgiven, and one is condemned to eternal fire (hell) (McCleary, 2007). Polarising brands trigger the contrast between salvation and damnation, placing consumers on opposite poles.

Brand damnation is not just about anger, contempt, and fear (Zarantonello et al., 2016), or protests, boycotts, avoidance, and complaints (Zhang & Laroche, 2020). There is not only an effect of ideological interest and political knowledge (Flecha-Ortiz et al., 2024), since brand damnation also has a strong moral component that directs consumers' hatred. Consumers feel deceived and retaliate, wanting to protect the universal values they cherish, but not due to a "love becomes hate" effect (Tolunay & Veloutsou, 2025). The participants' values fuel their outrage toward the hated brands without the need for a rival, which complements past research related to moral identity (Cheng et al., 2024; Rosendo-Rios et al., 2025).

Participants who condemn brands to eternal damnation are concerned with universal values, such as human rights, a commitment to equality and justice for everyone, and the preservation of the natural environment (Schwartz et al., 2012). The criticism is concentrated on universal access to natural resources (such as water and harvesting raw materials), deceptive and overpromising advertising (hiding true intentions, being hypocritical, and displaying arrogance), mistreatment of workers (e.g., slave labour or anti-union), political motivations (e.g., not properly supporting Ukraine or Palestine), or ideological views (as a symbol of capitalism, globalisation, commodification or consumerism).

Talking about Nestlé, many interviewees expressed their outrage at the fact that the company was exploiting natural resources, as Dylan explains: "I think a former CEO of Nestlé

(...) has said that it's not a human right to have clean drinking water. And then, that is something that I truly don't have in my own values". They feel deceived and upset because the brands are not only making a profit but also harming the environment. This feeling is even stronger when related to Nestlé's baby formula, as the company has been accused of promoting its product over breastfeeding. For most haters, the polarised brands have crossed a red line and will never be forgiven for their sins, as Peter explains why he would never trust Nestlé.

I personally don't see how they could make things right. And there are more than enough other products out there that I could never buy Nestlé my entire life and suffer zero repercussions. There are plenty of alternatives. So, even if Nestlé somehow reversed time, resurrected all the kids, gave all the water back, paid it. Like, if they somehow managed to do something as ludicrous as that. (Peter)

The participants felt deceived when they discovered that polarised brands were the parent company of other brands they had purchased. It seemed like a game of hide-and-seek, where the big corporations were disguising themselves and their dark secrets. Amelia is a vegetarian and started buying a meat substitute from a Swedish brand called Hälsans Kök when she suddenly discovered something else: "I turned the package over and it says Nestlé on the back. And I was like, 'What the fuck!' I'm trying to do something good for the planet and I'm still supporting this shitty company". Another situation happened with Violet, who felt betrayed by Fairlife, a brand that supposedly sells cruelty-free dairy products. When a whistleblower uncovered the brand's wrongdoings, she became angry and later discovered that the brand was part of the Coca-Cola Company.

The way the polarised brands were narcissistically advertised, portraying an idealised consumer, was seen as problematic and manipulative. The participants complained that Apple's marketing created the perception that its consumers were superior and exceptional, while stating that the brand was overpromising and underdelivering. Evelyn felt particularly annoyed by Apple, arguing that consumers were falling under the brand's spell: "I've never really liked brands trying to manipulate me, saying that if I buy that product, it will make me feel special because I'm the best". Brand haters perceived Apple as arrogant and snobbish because it presented itself as a status symbol or badge of honour. They did not consider the brand superior, enchanting, or communal (Wang et al., 2019). Albert commented about being bullied for using Android, even though he believed his phone was better: "People assume you're poor, people assume you're stupid. It's like if you had half a brain".

Geopolitical and political inclinations influenced how participants evaluated the polarised brands, which were held accountable for their actions and were under greater scrutiny. Henry boycotted McDonald's for not leaving Russia and prioritising its economic interests over human rights, which also prompted Evelyn to stop buying Coca-Cola. After the Israeli-Palestinian conflict started, Edward ceased going to McDonald's because the brand was accused of feeding Israeli soldiers. The participants understand that they can pressure big corporations harming their bottom lines, which is something Karen did with a targeted focus following the Boycott, Divest, and Sanctions (BDS) Palestinian-led movement. Interviewees also see the polarised brands as exploiters and against workers trying to unionise, which made Edward, Henry, and Karen angry with Starbucks.

Another aspect highlighted by the interviewees is the consumerism and commodification that the polarised brands represent, with harmful consequences for consumers. Finley believes that McDonald's sells standardised unhealthy meals, while consumers should look for local small businesses that use more nutritious ingredients. He also thinks that it is paradoxical that the brand once sponsored the Olympics. As a dentist, Oliver follows the same reasoning to explain his hatred for Coca-Cola: "And then, I dislike Coca-Cola even more than fast food brands, because it's kind of ubiquitous, right? When someone is actually, quote, addicted. And then, the health concerns, because it's too much sugar, diabetes, dental problems, cavities...".

With a different approach, Roger uses his art to protest commodification and consumerism, selling T-shirts that mock Coca-Cola and other brands by creating puns, as writing "little water" (*agüita* in Spanish) with Coke's typeface. He also creatively uses a term he saw on Twitch, "jajan't", which combines "jaja" (a Spanish expression of laughter) with the English negative to express that one might be laughing but is actually hurting oneself. Thus, Roger aims to draw people's attention by exposing the contradictions and hypocrisy of consumers, who continue to purchase items that are unhealthy, violate moral codes, or are unnecessary.

Besides consumerism and commodification, participants dislike how big corporations, epitomised by polarised brands, symbolise savage capitalism and do not care about society's well-being. Peter reflects on how brands should be behaving, "So, it would be nice if everyone.... if everything produced, everything done was done with a meaning, and the profit is a means to continue that, as opposed to the profit is the purpose". When asked if brands

should have values and purpose, Evelyn stresses that there needs to be a balanced relationship, as brands cannot only have a utilitarian purpose: “(...) the brand has to give something to humanity too, to have a moral-ethical balance, right? It’s not just profit, profit, profit”.

The interviewees reacted against polarised brands, considering them a collective effort to cause harm to society and universal values. The fact that several people made controversial decisions in a board room is unexcused and worsens the brand’s guilt, as Henry outlines it: “(...) it’s like multiple people had to sign off on that. Multiple people had to say ‘we’re OK with this’, that I’m a lot less forgiving of companies for letting bad decisions happen”. Some participants felt disappointment, anxiety, and despair, as if they were fighting with a higher dark force surrounding them, such as Violet, claiming that it was similar to a deadly disease.

To display their dissatisfaction, participants believed in their collective strength against the polarised brands. Karen rebuffs the idea that brands can be socially or politically neutral (Zaman Malik et al., 2025), saying, “I think anything we do with our money is a moral choice. (...) I think silence is still a message”. Most interviewees stressed that they can vote with their wallets and make a difference, as Dylan and others noted. Thus, interviewees are not only participating in boycotts and protests, or trying to evangelise friends and family, but also silently protesting. Even though some recognise that it is a small gesture, it is a significant one, as when Peter realises that it is like “throwing a tiny stone at a giant monolith”.

3.4.3 Brand Agnosticism

Agnosticism differs from damnation or salvation, as it refers to individuals who neither affirm nor deny religious claims and are less verbally opposed to religion compared to atheists (Baker & Smith, 2009). Brand agnostics neither strongly support nor oppose any brands. Most participants who loved polarised brands had a hard time thinking about brands they hated, and the same was true for the haters, who showed no positive affection for any brands. Haters and lovers believe that their opponents would change their minds if they were adequately informed, agreeing with their beliefs.

Apart from that and in line with past research demonstrating that neutrality concerning social issues does not necessarily lead to negative reactions (Zaman Malik et al., 2025), the interviewees liked brands that remained silent and from which they were purchasing for utilitarian purposes. Participants were willing to give these brands the benefit of the doubt, believing that a whistleblower would uncover the wrongdoing.

When talking about activism, Albert does not like the way brands try to push their agendas instead of selling their products: “If you’re a company that sells Coca-Cola, then sell Coca-Cola. If you want to be an activist in your own time, I think that’s great. (...) I just don’t love when a company is trying to push a message on me”. Peter shares the same opinion, saying that he wants to buy products, not for brands to engage in activism. He comments about McDonald’s and how their burgers are not gay and do not vote: “You know, if McDonald’s says, ‘We support gay rights’. Cool. I’d have a problem if you say: ‘We don’t like gay rights’”. Theo comments that some friends were arguing with him because he did not stop buying from McDonald’s, even with the accusations that the brand was supplying food to the Israeli army against Palestine: “Look, leave me alone! (...) I didn’t do anything. I mean, I didn’t buy this burger out of hate, but they treat you like you’re sending a bomb yourself”.

One interesting story illustrates another facet of brand agnosticism and is told by Jack, who has painful memories concerning Apple. He used to be a brand lover and worshipped everything Apple launched, “I was very much a fan, a loyalist, right? In a way that no rational person would do”. After a whole night finishing a school project, his Mac computer crashed in the middle of the presentation, an embarrassment that made other students mock him. He suddenly started hating Apple and vocalising his anger through social media. As he puts it, he went from a rabid supporter to a rabid hater, and then to apathy. Jack explained how he was affected by “magical thinking”, expecting things to be perfect and now having to be brand agnostic. He compares Apple to a relationship with his ex-girlfriend, who cheated on him, but he did not want to leave her.

It’s a weird thing to say, but I do think it’s the same thought process. (...) In my mind, this person was very irreplaceable. She had certain properties that I appreciated and I thought were important for my life. Like, yeah, those things are still rare, but I’m living very happily without them. (Jack)

3.4.4 Brand Ambiguity

Some participants shared experiences they had with polarised brands that fell somewhere between love and hate. Apart from brand addiction (Cui et al., 2018), these mixed and conflicted feelings have been less explored in the literature (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013), highlighting a need to uncover new relationship types (Alvarez et al., 2023) and understand a middle ground in the attachment-aversion relationships model (Park et al., 2013a). The interviewees are caught in a zone of indeterminacy, where good and evil coexist, and ambiguity

and uncertainty prevail (Appau et al., 2020). Three sets of stories illustrate this brand ambiguity: (1) Ava's and Hudson's abusive relationships with Starbucks and Apple; (2) Penelope's and Iris' guilty pleasures with McDonald's; and (3) Theo's nostalgic and ambiguous relationship with Nestlé.

The relationship between Ava and Starbucks is intense. She regularly visits two different stores to grab her coffee, chat with friends, and socialise. Her life moments intertwine with the brand, as she uses Starbucks to study, work, spend time, and feel part of a community, interacting with the baristas. Ava loves the brand atmosphere since it stands out from competitors: "And that mermaid, I don't even know who she is, but it's just alluring. (...) It's just very magnetic, charismatic, consistent". Her love for Starbucks was first described as a midsummer affair. However, when provoked by the interviewer to explain how it would be considered an affair if she had a long history with the brand, Ava offered a different perspective, realising that she has mixed feelings towards Starbucks.

I think it's so long because I know how bad it is. I'm a Type 2 diabetic. My sugars are super high because of Starbucks. (...) I've drunk it since Middle School from Starbucks. So, I'm 30 now. So, that's a pretty long affair, I guess. But, you know, I know I shouldn't be having it, but I still go to it every day. (...) I love it! It's just the sugar that I feel bad for every time. You know, it's like going back to a domestic abuse situation and like, you know: "Why do you go back?", they ask you. And I'm like, you know, you can't answer it really. (Ava)

Talking about Apple, Hudson explained how he tries to evangelise family members and friends to buy it, recognising that the brand is using him and benefiting from his free advertising. The interviewee also talked about how the brand only started to use the USB-C connector when it was forced, as well as the lack of innovation, showing that Apple is tricking consumers: "So, it's kind of in that sense of 'fool me that I like it'. At the same time, you're not fooling anyone, not even yourself". Thus, Hudson understands that Apple abused its fans by launching high-priced new phones every year with minor updates.

My cousin jokes that I'm a masochist, that I like to be beaten. (...) Then we see that there are times when she [Apple] abuses consumers, and there are many consumers who look and say, "Yes, in fact, here I was whipped and I liked it". (Hudson)

The second set of stories concerns the guilty pleasures interviewees have. Penelope loves McDonald's and associates the brand with affectionate memories from her childhood.

Nevertheless, she believes her relationship with the brand is toxic because of the unhealthy food. Penelope consumes McDonald's by impulse and hides it from her fiancé, who only eats healthy food. She ends up feeling guilty: "But I'm a little embarrassed, maybe, to eat it because it's not so good for my health, because maybe it's like, 'Wow, geez, you're eating that food made out of cardboard', you know? [laughs]".

Iris has a special connection with McDonald's, having worked there during her adolescence, which has instilled in her a deep respect for the brand. The interviewee recounts that she tried for seven years to get pregnant, eating healthily at the beginning to increase her chances. When Iris finally got pregnant, she was regularly eating at McDonald's. At a routine check-up, the doctor said he had to deliver the baby immediately, but she had just eaten at McDonald's. The family was worried that the baby would be born malnourished, "And she was born, the most wonderful thing, with peach skin. I say, 'Oh, thank you, McDonald's!' [laughs]". Iris describes her relationship with the brand as "naughty" because of the pleasure she derives from something that seems wrong.

I say it's naughty, in the sense that if you stop to think about how bread is made, how meat is made, or sauces like mayonnaise, it's completely garbage for the body, right? It's not healthy at all. It's that moment of pleasure where you say, "Oh, I ate it". Then you feel guilty, you say, "Oh, damn, now I'm going to get fat!", but it's that good guilt. (Iris)

The last story is told by Theo, regarding his relationship with Nestlé. He has mixed feelings about the brand, as his father worked at the company when he was a little kid in Venezuela. Theo remembers with affection how his father designed products in the marketing department and, one day, showed up dressed as a cow to promote the brand's chocolates: "So, I can't hate them even though it seems to me that they are incredibly evil, a super horrible company".

3.5 Discussion and Conclusion

3.5.1 Theoretical Contributions

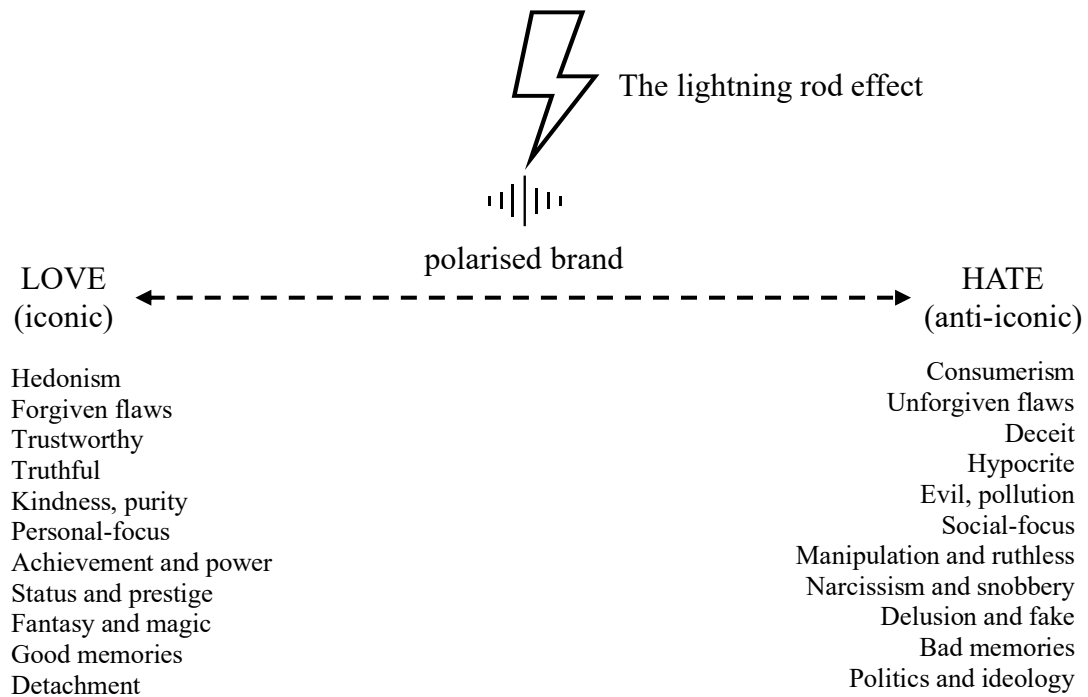
To answer why polarised brands elicit antagonistic feelings and behaviours in consumers (RQ1), the present research describes and explains the phenomenon as *the lightning rod effect*, complementing the brand polarisation literature (Monahan et al., 2023; Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019, 2024). This effect occurs because strong brands elicit a strong, polarised

emotional response from consumers (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019), who discharge their positive and negative reactions on them, as seen in Figure 3.1. In this sense, polarised brands are beacons that guide attention and attract consumer response. Nevertheless, the polarisation is not necessarily sparked by oppositional brand loyalty, confirming past research that identified rivalry as a specific type of brand polarisation (Osuna Ramírez et al., 2019).

The five brands chosen (Apple, Coca-Cola, McDonald's, Nestlé, and Starbucks) are iconic or hold high international status (Holt, 2004). Past research focused on the positive aspects of iconic brands (Holt, 2004) or the de-iconisation of a brand (Testa et al., 2017). However, their iconic status has a double-edged sword effect, epitomised by the lightning rod effect. Thus, this paper also contributes to cultural branding theory by demonstrating that iconicity is not only positive, evoking a sense of belonging, but also negative, as iconic brands can face hatred and despise. Polarised brands can be iconic to lovers but anti-iconic to haters.

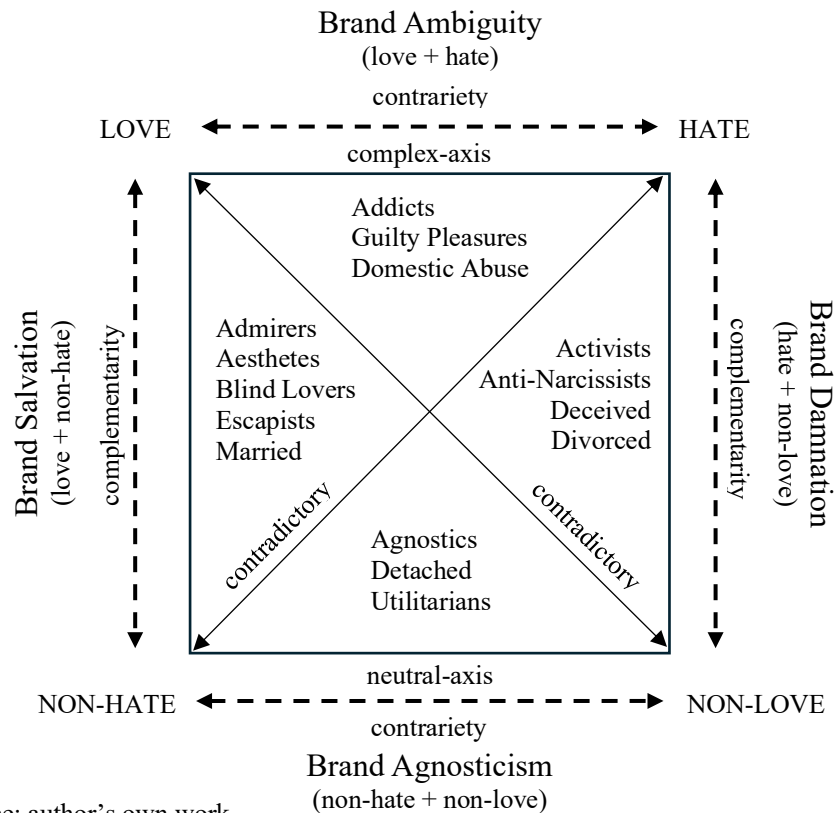
To understand how the polarisation process unfolds (RQ2), this paper analyses and organises how the polarised brands release four emotional states, using the semiotic square (Greimas & Rastier, 1968), as depicted in Figure 3.2. The polarised brands also unearth new types of brand-consumer relationships, which answer a call to capture more diversified ones (Alvarez et al., 2023). The first side of the square is the complex axis, contrasting the emotions of love and hate. In this axis, there is brand ambiguity, as love and hate intermingle, indicating relationships that fall midway in the attachment-aversion model (Park et al., 2013a): dealers/addicts, guilty pleasures, and abused victims. The first relationship was identified by previous researchers (Alves & Strehlau, 2025; Fournier & Alvarez, 2013), but this paper proposes the latter two.

Figure 3.1 - The lightning rod effect of polarised brands.



Source: author's own work.

Figure 3.2 - Brand polarisation semiotic square.



Source: author's own work.

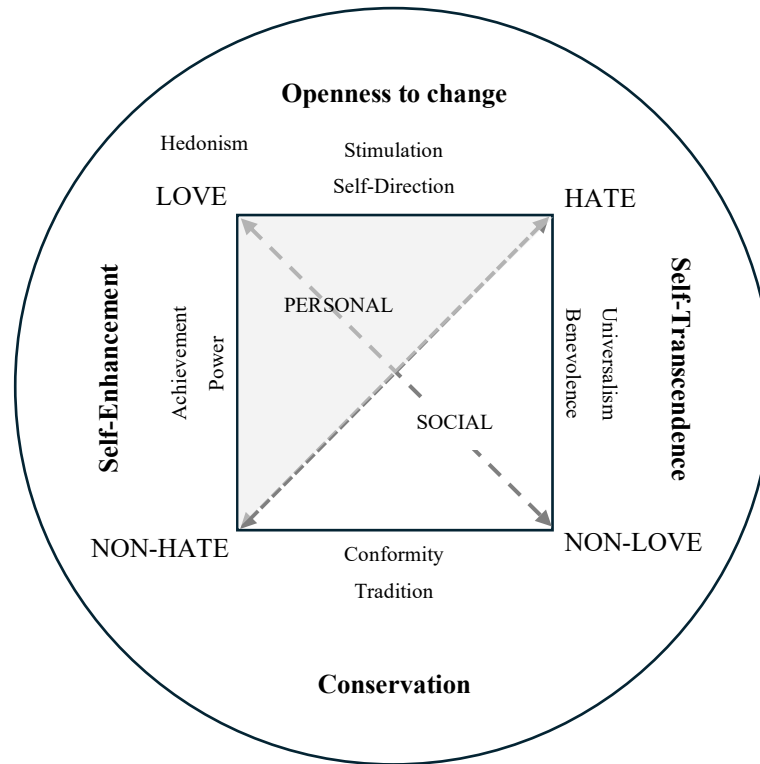
The opposite side is the neutral axis, which contains the terms non-love and non-hate. This axis concerns brand agnosticism, in which consumers view brands as neutral and do not display strong emotions towards them. Brand agnostics remain sufficiently distant from brands to properly evaluate them while still appreciating aspects, such as product features or advertising. Consumers tend to shift towards a strong pole (either love or hate) regarding particular polarised brands, while simultaneously having detached, agnostic, and utilitarian relationships with other brands (polarised or not). The present research extends the attachment-aversion model of customer-brand relationships (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013; Park et al., 2013a) by demonstrating that both lovers and haters can be brand-agnostic towards neutral or utilitarian brands if no tipping point triggers a reaction.

The two remaining sides of the semiotic square illustrate complementary relationships between love and non-hate, and between hate and non-love, showing that love and hate are not exact opposites (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013). The first regards brand salvation, where consumers consider some brands preferred and loved, without harbouring any negative feelings towards other brands. Apart from relationships identified in previous research and also present in this research's findings – such as family ties, childhood buddies, teammates, therapists/patients, soulmates, and vintage mates (Alves & Strehlau, 2025) – new ones are proposed: admirers, aesthetes, blind lovers, escapists, and marriage. The last side of the semiotic square concerns brand damnation, in which consumers express hatred rather than affection towards brands. Although brand divorce has already been discussed in the literature (Ferraz & Dallabrida, 2024), new relationships involving activists, anti-narcissists/snobs, and deceivers/deceived have been uncovered. Activism has not only an ideological and political drive, but also a strong moral-ethical one, which differs from the partisan relationship of past research (Alves & Strehlau, 2025).

To further explain why and how consumers feel and behave regarding polarised brands, the theory of basic individual values was employed (Schwartz et al., 2012). There is a personal focus on how individuals express their inner characteristics, contrasting with a social one on how they interact with the world. Figure 3.3 illustrates the four groups of values adapted from theory (Schwartz et al., 2012), which were combined with the semiotic square depicting the four emotional states associated with polarised brands. Consumers exposed to these brands tend to behave and make decisions based on the underlying values they believe are more critical. Brand haters are concerned about the preservation and appreciation of people's and nature's welfare, which are components of self-transcendence. At the same time, lovers value personal

success, social status, and prestige, which are part of self-enhancement. Brand ambiguity shows that consumers are driven by their independent thought to seek challenge, excitement, and novelty. Finally, brand agnostics are conservative, restraining their actions and looking for safety and stability.

Figure 3.3 - Underlying values of brand polarisation.

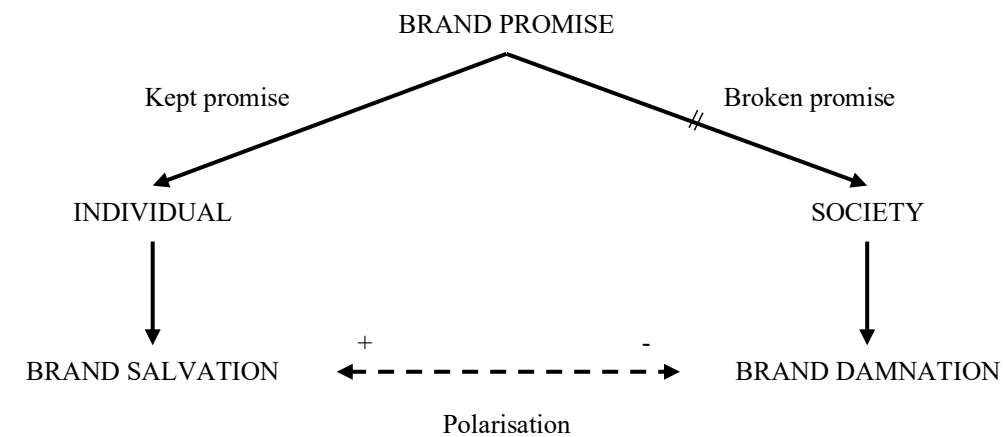


Source: author's own work.

Not only can the theory of basic individual values explain what lies beneath consumers' motivations toward polarised brands, but consumers also expect brands to comply with normatively binding promises that are sometimes not explicitly stated (Bhargava & Bedi, 2022). On the one hand, haters believe that brands are promising to protect society's well-being and should not profit from savagely exploiting resources, the environment, or the workforce. Their self-direction and self-transcendence drive them. On the other hand, lovers are tied to the brand promise of self-enhancement and conservation, unwilling to delve into the brands' secrets or realise that all companies can have some degree of wrongdoing. As seen in Figure 3.4, a brand that keeps its promise, regarding individual values, leads to brand salvation.

In contrast, a broken brand promise concerning social values triggers brand damnation, in line with past research that identified that consumers with high moral identity are more affected by brand transgressions (Rosendo-Rios et al., 2025). Thus, this paper extends the brand as promise theory (Bhargava & Bedi, 2022) by showing how and why consumers respond to polarised brands. However, not all promises and brands trigger a strong reaction from consumers, as brands can get more or less polluted (Douglas, 2001). The level of response depends on the strength of the moral violation and the size and iconicity of the brand. Table 3.3 summarises the differences between salvation and damnation and their relation to the brand promise. Finally, Table 3.4 provides definitions for the emotional states, summarises the new brand relationship types, and presents representative quotations.

Figure 3.4 - Brand promise paths leading to brand polarisation.



Source: author's own work.

Table 3.3 - Brand Damnation versus Brand Salvation.

Attribute	Salvation	Damnation
Brand Promise focus	Brands are accountable for their actions towards individuals and communities.	Brands are accountable for their impact on society.
Approach to moral questions	Teleology	Deontology
Wrongdoing impact	Low	High
Morally obligatory actions	Voluntary	Mandatory
Short-term reaction	Brands repent and are forgiven by the consumer for their sins, which are frailties and weaknesses.	The consumer blames brands for their sins, which are perceived as moral defects and are seen as having evil intentions.
Long-term reaction	Brand Devotion: The brand is cherished for its past virtues for eternity.	Brand Karma: The brand is condemned for their past wrongdoing for eternity.
Relationship	Cooperation leading to salvation	Conflictual leading to damnation
Behaviour	Faithful trust in brands	Profound doubt in brands

Source: author's own work.

Table 3.4 - Consumer emotional states and their respective brand relationship types.

Emotional State	Definition	Brand Relationship	Definition	Representative Quotation	Brand
Brand Salvation	Brands are idealised and praised to eternity because of their virtues and kept promises to self-enhancement and hedonist values.	Admirers	Relationship based on a deep feeling of approval, respect, wonder, and admiration.	“My cousin, my male cousin Sean, he was a couple years older than me, but we were kind of like brothers. He ended up dying of AIDS, unfortunately. And pretty much is just Heather left. But we always had food and soda over there and that just reminds me, you know? Sweet tea and Coke Zero, reminds me of being over there, even though they didn’t have Coke Zero at that time, if that makes sense [laughs]”. (Stanley)	Coca-Cola
		Aesthetes	A sensible and pleasurable relationship focused on enjoying and valuing the aesthetic and beautiful aspects of a brand.	“So, I do like that flair, I do, because I’m a snob, OK? I have to admit it. I like nice things [laughs]. I like fancy things, and I like nice things. I like things that... you know, you admire something that’s beautiful, you can do that at Starbucks. You can’t it on Dunkin’ Donuts because even the flavouring is different. Starbucks uses coffees you go ‘Wow’, you know? It’s the taste, the feel is different.” (Eleanor)	Starbucks
		Blind Lovers	A deep and loving relationship that is strong regardless of the brand’s flaws and imperfections, blinding the person to them.	“Oh, there’s no other brand, my son! Are you crazy? Do you know of any that’s better than Nestlé?” (Mia)	Nestlé

		Escapists	Relationship built on a need to escape from unpleasant and tedious aspects of daily life, seeking pleasurable experiences.	“(…) going out to McDonald’s, for me, is more of a fun activity I do to pass the time and clear my mind, and also to eat something I know I like. So I can wait 20 minutes in a store and eventually get both a burger and fries. Because those are the only two things I think about when I go.” (Theo)	McDonald’s
		Married	A long-term binding relationship between the consumer and the brand, where both are committed to making it work despite minor setbacks.	“It’s a marriage relationship. It’s like, ‘Oh, she [Apple] has some issues there, but it’s so good here.’ It would be in that sense of marriage, like, ‘Oh, we’ve been together for a while, I’ve got used to you, I already feel affection, and there’s no reason for me to leave you. So, we’ll stay together.” (Hudson)	Apple
	Brand Damnation	Activists	A strong political, ideological, environmental, or social motivation against a brand due to its mishaps and wrongdoings.	“I don’t think it’s a secret anymore that Nestlé is a shitty company. I just think a lot of people don’t care. But, of course, it’s not something you will read about on their own website. It is about how much shit they do in the world and how bad they are treating the planet and everything.” (Amelia)	Nestlé
		Anti-Narcissists/Snobs	An intense dissatisfaction against a brand that is self-centred, snobbish, arrogant, and feels that it is unique and superior to others.	“I don’t want them to make me feel like a princess, like I’m flying in a castle [laughs]. I don’t want it: if you buy this, all you need is an iPhone to be a special person in society. I hate that, I hate these categories. It’s an illusion. Deep down, it’s an illusion. And people buy illusions.” (Evelyn)	Apple

Brand Agnosticism	Brands are distant and neutral because they are objectively evaluated and do not evoke strong emotions.	Deceivers/Deceived	A deep sense of disappointment toward a brand for letting the consumer down by promising something and not delivering, or by lying to its own advantage.	“And I was like, ‘Oh, my gosh, how could I have been so stupid? I completely bought into that marketing!’ And that was when I was like, ‘Fuck Coca-Cola! I hate Coca-Cola!’ [laughs] Because it just seems so devious to me, you know? Just have a milk brand, don’t market yourself as cruelty-free if you’re not cruelty-free! It felt so evil! I was like, ‘I’ve been tricked because I put my money into this product to support a cause, and it’s a cause that they were intentionally and knowingly exploiting and violating and supporting the opposite of, and it felt like robbery!’” (Violet)	Coca-Cola
		Divorced	A long-term relationship that was ended due to an unforgivable brand wrongdoing or blatant misconduct.	“But, for me, when a brand has done something like that [not pulling out from Russia when they invaded Ukraine], I find it really difficult for them to win back my trust, and I think that’s kind of the case with McDonald’s. I’m still a bit like, ‘You made a decision, but I still don’t feel quite comfortable eating there.’” (Henry)	McDonald’s
		Agnostics	A feeling of apathy towards brands, having second thoughts about their superiority and special attributes.	“It corresponded with a lot of therapy on my part [laughs]. And it wasn’t about Apple. It was about, you know, personal relationship stuff. But the main feeling was like a shift from the rabid support to rabid opposition to apathy. Now, I don’t care if this MacBook develops a hardware problem, I’m not mad. It’s a piece of technology and sometimes they have known problems (...) I have to be brand agnostic.” (Jack)	Apple
		Detached	A distant relationship between consumer and brand, without a clear preference for it or strong feelings.	“You know, like there are different kinds of chocolate. There are different kinds of products. If it’s from Nestlé, it’s OK I will still buy it. But if it’s another brand, it’s still OK. I like Nestlé, but, you know, I’m not particularly a very big fan or like it’s one of my favourites, you know?” (Freddie)	Nestlé
		Utilitarians	A rational, impersonal, and objective relationship to maximise the utility derived from the brand.	“I don’t necessarily love or hate Apple. Personally, I like my Android phones. I’ve never been a fan of Apple products, not for any political reasons or anything like that. I don’t find them very user-friendly, in my opinion.” (Edward)	Apple

Brand Ambiguity	Brands are ambiguous and elicit mixed feelings because they are simultaneously perceived as having both positive and negative qualities.	Dealers/Addicts	“An obsessive relationship where the person is devoted and dependent on another. It involves feelings of distress, anxiety and uneasiness as if the person is unable to live without a loved partner.” (Alves & Strehlau, 2025, p. 9).	“But Coke Classic, full of sugar, is my greatest passion. Some days you say, ‘Wow, it’s so hot!’ You picture a Coke really cold with ice and lemon. Coca-Cola, I think, is a product I will never, ever, ever stop drinking!” (Iris)	Coca-Cola
		Guilty Pleasures	A guilty feeling that one has about enjoying and consuming a brand that is not held in high regard or is advised by others to be avoided.	“But I’m a little embarrassed, maybe, to eat it [McDonald’s] because it’s not so good for my health, because maybe it’s like, ‘Wow, geez, you’re eating that food made out of cardboard’, you know? [laughs].” (Penelope)	McDonald’s
		Domestic Abuse	A relationship where the consumer feels trapped by the brand’s attractiveness, regardless of the unpleasant and unwelcome consequences.	“I think it’s so long because I know how bad it is. I’m a Type 2 diabetic. My sugars are super high because of Starbucks. (...) I’ve drunk it since Middle School from Starbucks. So, I’m 30 now. So, that’s a pretty long affair, I guess. But, you know, I know I shouldn’t be having it, but I still go to it every day. (...) I love it! It’s just the sugar that I feel bad for every time. You know, it’s like going back to a domestic abuse situation and like, you know: ‘Why do you go back?’, they ask you. And I’m like, you know, you can’t answer it really.” (Ava)	Starbucks

Source: author’s own work.

3.5.2 Managerial Implications

Consumers have distinct relationships with polarised brands, ranging from strongly positive to negative poles. On the one hand, they can be loyal and view brands as idealised partners without displaying strong negative emotions. This type of consumer is more worried about their personal values and how the brand can fulfil them. On the other hand, brand haters strongly oppose polarised brands because of their broken promises towards universal values and society's well-being. Brand managers need to identify the different types to enhance their relationship with lovers while mitigating the negative impact of haters.

Practitioners should be aware of the impact iconic brands have on consumers, as they can both positively and negatively affect brand equity. This understanding can help managers create brand strategies to identify and track movements that can lead to hatred or love. For instance, a move from lovers to ambiguity can weaken the brand strength if it leads to addiction. At the same time, a change of haters to agnostics can diminish a bad reputation. However, once the consumers are drawn to one of the poles, it is unlikely and difficult to move them from there, which is a problem with brand haters.

There is a tipping point that sparks consumer hatred, usually a moral deviation. Companies should be aware that this situation can trigger a chain reaction, leading individuals to distrust their actions and have a ripple effect on the entire market. The wrongdoings of one brand can spill over to the others, turning consumers into activists. There is a Pandora's box risk for brands when they unleash their sinister secrets, which can affect the market.

For brands that are activists and purposely position themselves on one side of the spectrum, they should adopt strategies to cope with haters who will never buy their products and boycott them. However, polarised brands are subject to the lightning rod effect, pushing their consumers to opposite poles, whether they want it or not. Brand strategists need to develop plans that simultaneously address both brand fans, who see it as iconic, and detractors, who see it as anti-iconic.

3.5.3 Limitations and Agenda for Future Research

This study has some limitations that need to be considered. The participants were recruited solely from social media and may already be opinionated or influenced by a polarised environment. A more diverse sample of consumers is needed to understand brand polarisation better. Another limitation concerns the narrow list of brands chosen for the study, which are

global and well-known. Future studies could investigate smaller and local brands to determine whether the results would be the same.

More investigation is needed to understand the relationship between polarised brands and their promises. There may be other underlying consumer motivations that trigger polarisation beyond those suggested in this paper, including individual values and brand promise. The connections between brand salvation, damnation, agnosticism, and ambiguity require further articulation and exploration through studies that focus on brands' symbolic meanings and religiosity. Other types of brand relationships may emerge, particularly those with polarised feelings, whether negative, positive, or ambiguous.

Finally, future research should investigate the relationship between polarised and iconic brands. There is a need to understand further brands' anti-iconicity, their interactions with identity myths, emotional bonds, and storytelling. The clashes between iconic and anti-iconic characteristics should be examined to understand their impact on branding strategies.

CHAPTER 4 – NEGATIVE POLE: FLAWED CONSUMER-BRAND RELATIONSHIPS³

4.1 Introduction

But they do it on purpose. I think there's no way around it; there has to be a way, and they certainly don't want to do it any other way. And so, I think it's quite frustrating because, at that moment, they ruined my dream! And my dream was to have that ticket, and it was really awful! And so, for me, at that moment, Ticketmaster was my enemy. (Sophia)

Consumers have long faced struggles and hardship when developing relationships with brands (Fetscherin, 2019; Fournier, 1998; Fournier & Alvarez, 2013; Grégoire & Fisher, 2008; Ladeira et al., 2026). Prior research has substantially advanced knowledge on brand contestation (Dietrich & Russell, 2021), brand hate (Fetscherin, 2019; Hegner et al., 2017; Zarantonello et al., 2016), brand betrayal (Tolunay & Veloutsou, 2025; Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025), negative relationships triggered by polarisation (Alves & Strehlau, 2026), brand bullying (Kucuk & Aledin, 2022), brand shame (Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025), brand divorce (Ferraz & Dallabrida, 2024; Sussan et al., 2012), brand sabotage, subversion, and consumer revenge (Kähr et al., 2016; Wilson et al., 2022; Zourrig et al., 2009), brand repulsion (Dessart & Cova, 2021), brand addiction and compulsive buying (Cui et al., 2018; Ghorbanzadeh, 2024; Le, 2021; Mrad & Cui, 2017), negative brand personality (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024), and anti-consumption and brand avoidance (Hogg et al., 2009; Lee et al., 2009; Odoom et al., 2019).

Although studies have identified negative consumer-brand relationships and personalities, discussed behaviours and coping mechanisms to deal with them, and identified negative affections such as hate, the literature is concentrated in brand hate (Ladeira et al., 2026), focused on emotions rather than relationships (Aziz & Rahman, 2022; Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022), and lacks an integrated organising structure of antecedents, interactions, relationship types, and outcomes (Alvarez et al., 2023). Moreover, the negative consumer-brand relationships were less discussed in the literature, with some studies defining types such as dealers/addicts (Alves & Strehlau, 2025, 2026; Fournier & Alvarez, 2013), enmities, enslavements (Fournier, 1998), domestic abuse (Alves & Strehlau, 2026), masters/slaves, and

³ This article has the following title: "The Dark Side of Brand Use: a Framework of Flawed Consumer-Brand Relationships".

villains/victims (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013). Other studies focused on anti-branding behaviours and communities, with activities that undermine branding efforts (Wilson et al., 2022), oppose dominant brand discourses (C. J. Thompson & Arsel, 2004), or build a consumer-resistant identity (Brandão & Popoli, 2022), but have not explored how anti-branding is related to negative brand personality or to flawed consumer-brand relationships.

Another research stream studied consumer coping strategies and mechanisms. Coping is a multidimensional construct that refers to responses to life strains aimed at avoiding, preventing, or controlling emotional distress (Pearlin & Schooler, 1978; Skinner et al., 2003). Consumer researchers studied coping when dealing with technology adoption (Mick & Fournier, 1998), facing stressful consumption events (Duhachek, 2005; Yi & Baumgartner, 2004), adopting compensatory strategies (Rauber et al., 2024), confronting or avoiding brands (Bayarassou et al., 2020), engaging in brand communities (Weijo et al., 2019), and considering personality traits and self-compassion (Karanika & Hogg, 2016; Seth & Soch, 2024). However, those studies have not made a connection between negative brand personalities, dysfunctional consumer-brand relationships, and coping mechanisms.

To address these knowledge gaps, our research asks how flawed consumer-brand relationships are fostered, cultivated, structured, and handled. Drawing on this central question, we further ask what types of negative relationships exist between brands and consumers, triggered by negative brand personalities, and what coping strategies and behaviours are used to address them. We conducted phenomenological interviews with consumers, analysed secondary data, and followed an online forum as part of a netnography to understand how consumers deal with broken relationships with brands. Throughout the investigation, we uncovered untheorised negative consumer-brand relationships and coping strategies, relating them to negative consumption experiences.

Our main contribution is the proposal of a novel theoretical framework that shows how flawed consumer-brand relationships are triggered by dark brand personality traits (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024), appraised, cultivated, and coped with through diverse mechanisms and behaviours. Since the seminal work of Fournier (1998), who proposed a brand relationship quality model, no similar attempt has been made to develop a framework for flawed relationships. The closest initiatives were from Dietrich and Russell (2021), who proposed a framework for brand contestation; from Kähr et al. (2016), who developed a contestation model for aggressive consumer behaviour; and from Wilson et al. 2022, who identified four forms of

consumer subversion. Nevertheless, these studies are more closely related to anti-consumption, activism, hostility, and crisis management than to investigating negative consumer-brand relationships, coping mechanisms, or understanding the role of brands' negative personalities.

Second, we advance knowledge of negative consumer-brand relationship types by suggesting novel ones, such as dictator/subjects, absent/orphans, crooks/suckers, and spies/targets. Third, we define four coping mechanisms of accommodating, distancing, confronting, and reframing, adding to the consumer coping literature by explaining how they are connected to negative brand relationships, elicited emotions, and negative brand personalities. Our findings have implications for theory on dysfunctional brand relationships and negative brand personality.

4.2 Theoretical Foundation

4.2.1 Negative Consumer-Brand Relationships

The literature on negative consumer-brand relationships is fragmented and underdeveloped (Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022), leading to theoretical confusion and diverse conceptualisations (Aziz & Rahman, 2022; Ladeira et al., 2026). The efforts to define brand relationship types are limited, and years after the initial typology (Fournier, 1998), only brand love emerged as a key construct (Alvarez et al., 2023). The fact that brand hate has been conceptualised as a combination of negative emotions (Aziz and Rahman 2022) does not help clarify the distinct emotions and behaviours involved.

The first research stream on negative consumer-brand relationships is centred on the definition of brand hate, its antecedents, consequences, and intensity. Most researchers have conceptualised brand hate through a negative-valenced emotional lens (Aziz and Rahman 2022), primarily drawing on the duplex theory of hate (Sternberg, 2003), which considers the negation of intimacy (disgust), passion (anger/fear), and commitment (devaluation/diminution) as components of hate. Studies have explored the active and passive aspects of brand hate (Zarantonello et al., 2016), which some authors consider as a continuum, ranging from mild to extreme hate (Bryson & Atwal, 2019; Fetscherin, 2019; Kucuk, 2019). The idea that consumers do not have ecstatic emotional responses led to the exploration of trajectories from love to hate and vice versa (Grégoire et al., 2009; Johnson et al., 2011; Tolunay & Veloutsou, 2025; Zarantonello et al., 2018).

The fragmentation of studies on brand hate shows that authors consider a myriad of emotions related to it, such as sadness (Zhang & Laroche, 2020), anger (Fetscherin, 2019; Kucuk, 2019; Zarantonello et al., 2016), fear (Zarantonello et al., 2016; Zhang & Laroche, 2020), and worry (Romani et al., 2012). Scholars also studied other emotional states related to branding constructs, such as brand shame (Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025), repulsion (Dessart & Cova, 2021), and negativity (Dessart et al., 2020). One problem with the dispersed theorisation is that brand hate could end up encompassing every non-positive aspect of consumer-brand relationships, behaviours, and emotional states, rather than having a more accurate definition.

Indeed, in the field of psychology, emotions such as fear, anger, love, and sadness are considered fuzzy sets without clear boundaries, represented by prototypes or most representative examples (Shaver et al., 1987). They can be combined into primary and secondary emotions to form other emotional states, like love and sadness, which can give rise to nostalgia or yearning (Kemper, 1987). However, the negative consumer-brand relationship literature has given disproportionate attention to hate rather than exploring other combinations of negative emotions and has treated brand hate as an umbrella construct.

A second research stream has prioritised a behavioural perspective of the negative relationship between consumers and brands. Consumers can adopt a contestation nature to disrupt, negotiate meanings, and resist brands (Dietrich & Russell, 2021). They participate as activists in anti-brand communities to get control over brand meanings (Hollenbeck & Zinkhan, 2010), deconstructing them using humorous and subversive messages (Krishnamurthy & Kucuk, 2009; Kucuk, 2015). Some might engage in opposition to brand hegemonic culture (C. J. Thompson & Arsel, 2004; Thota, 2021), boycotting and culture-jamming (Cova & D'Antone, 2016), while others, imbued with an ideological mindset, consider hated brands anti-iconic (Alves & Strehlau, 2026; Dessart & Cova, 2021).

Dislike for brands can be triggered by moral transgressions (Mahmud & Guzmán, 2025; Romani et al., 2015; Rosendo-Rios et al., 2025), political or ideological incompatibility (Sandıkcı & Ekici, 2009), and the protection of self-esteem and rejection of an undesired self (Hogg et al., 2009). It can also be part of a brand-bullying process, where those who experience it show negative feelings towards brands used for bullying (Kucuk & Aledin, 2022). On the other hand, some scholars have consolidated motivations into a brand avoidance construct, in which consumers choose to avoid or reject a brand due to identity incongruity, ideological incompatibility, or unmet expectations (Lee et al., 2009; Odoom et al., 2019).

The third research stream has studied types of negative consumer-brand relationships. Contrary to other research that analysed nostalgia in a positive light (Alves & Strehlau, 2025; Brown et al., 2003; Davari et al., 2017), one study has found that consumers may be attached to brands due to nostalgic feelings, even when they dislike them (Demirbag-Kaplan et al., 2015). Other articles explored diverse negative relationships related to activism, narcissism, and deception (Alves & Strehlau, 2026); masters/slaves and stalker/prey (Fournier & Alvarez, 2013); and enmities and dependencies (Fournier, 1998).

Another aspect of negative relationships is their dissolution. Few studies have explored how consumers and brands part ways, which can be associated with a change in perception and spiritual transformation (Sussan et al., 2012), be the result of wrongdoing or misconduct (Alves & Strehlau, 2026), or follow trajectories that can lead to brand hate, neutrality, or aversion (Ferraz & Dallabrida, 2024). Opposed to dissolution are relationships where the consumer feels forced to consume, as in abusive (Alves & Strehlau, 2026; Fournier & Alvarez, 2013) or addictive ones (Alves & Strehlau, 2025; Cui et al., 2018; Mrad & Cui, 2017). Even with the identification of some negative consumer-brand relationship types, the literature remains scarce and is more centred on positive bonds, such as brand love, communal relationships, and friendship (Alvarez et al., 2023).

The three research streams – the first focused on emotional aspects, the second on behavioural actions, and the third on negative relationships – lack further integration. Scholars have presented proposals and theoretical discussions, but have been restricted to particular negative consumer reactions, antecedents, or typologies. A preliminary discussion of integrating negative relationships was presented by Fournier (1998), who distinguishes their dissolution into stress and entropic models. The first is caused by environmental, partner-oriented, and dyadic stresses, while the second is due to a failure to maintain the relationship. Nevertheless, the proposed dissolution model focuses on antecedent types rather than elaborating on coping mechanisms, adverse events, or specific negative consumer-brand relationships. Another framework was discussed by Dietrich and Russell (2021), who proposed a contestation wheel with processes of negotiation, disruption, and expression. However, this framework concerns changes in brand meanings unintended by the legal owners (such as those arising from cultural appropriation, cooptation, opposition, and condemnation), not necessarily restricted to negative consumer-brand relationships. Similarly, Wilson et al. (2022) conceptualised and discussed four forms of consumer subversion, but their work is restricted to behavioural actions. It does not elaborate on antecedents, relationship types, emotions, or

coping strategies. Finally, Kähr et al. (2016) presented a conceptual framework to organise consumers' aggressive reactions towards brands, including stimuli, appraisals, and reappraisals. However, the authors analysed only extreme forms of behavioural reactions (e.g., consumer brand sabotage) and did not specify how the negative relationships would unfold.

4.2.2 Negative Brand Personality

Studies on brand personality have predominantly focused on positive aspects (Aaker, 1997), assuming that brands have only favourable attributes. Brand personality is based on the Big Five Model of human personality, although it is not a perfect match, as some factors may or may not apply (Aaker, 1997; Caprara et al., 2001). Since brand personality relies on human-like traits, although not perfectly, other authors have suggested that it should comprise both positive and negative aspects that differentiate the brand (Saeed et al., 2022).

Previous research has acknowledged that brand personality can affect how consumers react when brands misbehave (Aaker et al., 2004), but limited research has examined its less favourable aspects. Negative feelings, such as anxiety, tension, and frustration, were considered part of a negative conceptualisation of brand personality, which, according to an early study, comprises egotistical, illogical, boring, irresponsible, and critical dimensions (Haji et al., 2012). More recent research developed a scale based on the dark triad of human personality (narcissism, Machiavellianism, and psychopathy) to include traits related to manipulation, exploitation, and lack of empathy (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024), reassessing the fragmented and scant literature on this matter. Given the very few studies on negative brand personality (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024; Saeed et al., 2022), its impact on consumer behaviour, emotion appraisal, and coping strategies remains unknown.

4.2.3 Consumer Coping

Coping mechanisms are strategies people use to manage life strains, such as stressful situations, frustrations, conflicts, and threats (Pearlin & Schooler, 1978). Negative events elicit primary and secondary emotions that are appraised in terms of their quality and intensity, triggering coping responses associated with problem-solving, positive reappraisal, confrontation, and distancing, grouped into problem-focused versus emotion-focused categories (Folkman & Lazarus, 1988). However, authors criticised the definition of core categories, as coping is a multidimensional construct comprising several individual behaviours,

cognitions, and perceptions that can form families of coping, such as information seeking, self-reliance, or submission (Skinner et al., 2003).

In the consumer behaviour field, the same criticism was directed to conceptualising coping as either problem-focused or emotion-focused, prompting the proposal of a theoretical model with eight coping strategies, ranging from active coping to avoidance (Duhachek, 2005). Other authors proposed similar coping typologies appropriate for consumer behaviour settings, criticising the abstractness, difficulty in classification, and problems in measuring coping when only problem-focused and emotion-focused categories are considered (Yi & Baumgartner, 2004).

When facing brand transgressions, consumers can adopt active coping strategies that confront the company to seek revenge, or passive ones, such as avoiding and ignoring the problem (Zourrig et al., 2009). Not all coping strategies are detrimental and can be constructive or neutral, even after negative incidents (Klütz & Albrecht, 2025). However, transgressions are not easily forgotten and can become ingrained in a brand community's collective memory, permanently damaging the brand's reputation, as consumers vent, ruminate, avoid, and act against it (Weijo et al., 2019). Other stressful situations demand confrontative and avoidance strategies to manage paradoxes in society, as in the case of technology (Mick & Fournier, 1998), to deal with social and temporal comparisons, catalysing coping mechanisms to pursue self-esteem and self-compassion (Karanika & Hogg, 2016), to mitigate decision-generated negative emotions (Luce, 1998), or to adopt different types of compensatory behaviours, such as escapism, addiction, or compulsive buying (Rauber et al., 2024).

Although the coping literature in consumer behaviour has addressed brand transgressions, negative incidents, compensatory behaviours, and coping strategies and mechanisms, it is unclear how these are connected to negative brand relationships and personalities. The literature on consumer behaviour and branding lacks a more comprehensive understanding of how brand stimuli trigger emotions and broken relationships, which are ultimately handled through coping mechanisms and behaviours.

4.3 Research Methods

4.3.1 Data Collection

We drew on diverse data sources to explore our phenomenon with theoretical depth and achieve a thick description (Geertz 1973), as shown in Table 4.1. The first source was

phenomenological interviews conducted by the first author in English and Portuguese with 30 consumers from 10 countries, scheduling them to accommodate different time zones. To recruit participants for the study, a combination of techniques was applied. Multiple keywords were used in Reddit to find posts related to negative consumption experiences, such as emotions (e.g., hate, sadness, frustration), swearing (e.g., fuck, what the fuck, shit), negative words (e.g., horrible, stupid, insane), behaviours (e.g., boycott, protest, avoid), and brand names (e.g., Apple, Nestlé, Southwest). Potential candidates were direct messaged and invited to participate in the study. Snowball sampling was used to complement the total number of respondents. The interviews lasted an average of 63 minutes and were transcribed verbatim. We followed the ethical procedures approved by the faculty's ethics committee, including a free and informed consent form shared orally with the participants, who verbally agreed to participate.

Our sample comprised 14 female and 16 male respondents, aged 22 to 60, as shown in Table 4.2, and covered a wide range of brands across sectors. The interview started with a non-directive grand tour question (McCracken 1988), asking the respondents to talk about the brands they disliked. Usually, the conversation began with a specific negative consumption experience identified by the researchers during the recruiting phase, and then evolved to explore any other dysfunctional ones. The interviewer followed a phenomenological dialogue as a non-directive listener, avoiding intrusion and allowing participants to provide lengthy and thick descriptions (Thompson, Locander, and Pollio 1989). An interview guide was used as a reference for the conversation, but not as a set of semi-structured, pre-defined questions, prioritising how consumers experience and live through the phenomenon (Adams and van Manen 2008) and focusing on their reflections on the significance of the negative events (Smith, Flowers, and Larkin 2009).

Apart from the interviews, the second source was a netnography conducted from September 2025 to March 2026 on one online Reddit forum: *mildlyinfuriating*, launched in 2012, with 9.6 million weekly visitors (Reddit 2026). We selected this forum since it is focused on venting a wide range of negative experiences, not restricted to a particular brand or sector. The first author engaged as a netnographer and non-participant observer, reading posts and comments to select the ones related to negative consumer-brand experiences. The collected data were organised into field notes, including the posts and relevant comments, following the netnography procedures (Kozinets 2020). To protect users' identities and their content, quotes used in this article were altered to ensure anonymisation, and a new digital pseudonym was assigned (Kozinets 2020).

Table 4.1 - Types of data sources collected.

Source	Type	Purpose of usage	Detail
In-depth interviews with consumers	30 phenomenological interviews (14 female and 16 male) with consumers from 10 countries. Interviews were conducted between December 2025 and January 2026.	To understand how consumers feel and describe their negative relationships with brands, reflecting how they make sense from the negative experiences.	- Participants were recruited from Reddit and via snowball sampling. - Potential informants were direct messaged and invited to participate in the study. - Interviews had an average of 63 minutes and were transcribed verbatim, totalling more than 30 hours of recording, 476 single-spaced pages, and more than 280k words.
Netnography	Six months of non-participant observation (28th September 2025 to 27th March 2026) of one online forum in Reddit about complaints, investigating topics related to negative experiences.	To understand how consumers vocalise their hatred and frustration towards brands, their motivations, narratives, and how they describe the relationship.	- 1,152 collected posts, totalling 143 field note pages (Excel file). - Five hours per week tracking one Reddit forum. - Tracked Reddit forum: Mildly Infuriating (9.6 million weekly visitors in March 2026) https://www.reddit.com/r/mildlyinfuriating/
Consumer-Generated Videos	120 consumer-generated videos complaining about brands posted by consumers between 2008 and 2025.	To understand how negative brand relationships are displayed and enacted in videos posted by consumers.	- Analysis of 120 YouTube videos posted in English (45), Portuguese (60), and Spanish (15), totalling more than 9 hours of recording. - Example of keyword combinations used to search videos: “brand”, “complaint”, “is garbage”, etc.
News Coverage	146 newspaper and online articles reporting consumers’ bad experiences with brands, published between 2008 and 2025.	To analyse and trace negative brand relationships reported by the media, identifying how the hatred is reported and interpreted by news outlets.	- Examples of keyword combinations used for the search: “consumer” and “complaint”, “brand” and “hate”, “boycott” and “brand”. - USA Today (USA) - 39 articles - Folha de São Paulo (Brazil) - 32 articles - Daily Mail (UK) - 63 articles - El País (Spain) - 12 articles - Articles represent different cultures and languages.

Table 4.2 - Research participants and negative brand relationships.

#	Pseudonym	Gender	Age	Country	Occupation	Brands	Min
1	Louise	Female	48	USA	Marketing	Adobe, Chips Ahoy, Google, HP, Little Debbie, Netflix, Samsung, Verizon	65min
2	Martin	Male	40	USA	Automotive Mechanic	Apple, Audi, Comcast, Disney, Nestlé, SpaceX, Tesla, Volkswagen, Walmart, X	70min
3	Wilson	Male	27	Poland	Infrastructure Administrator	Bolt, Google, Microsoft, Uber	70min
4	Cecil	Male	38	UK	Clinics Director	BP, Google, Meta, Microsoft, Samsung, Trago Mills	73min
5	Tim	Male	26	Brazil	Software Developer	Amazon, Google, iFood, Magazine Luiza, Microsoft, Netflix, Samsung, Tok&Stok, Uber	59min
6	Xavier	Male	28	Brazil	Information Technology	Alexa, Apple, Caixa Econômica, D-Link, Fiat, Konami, TikTok, Windows, Xiaomi	64min
7	Justin	Male	31	Brazil	Cemetery Artesan	Carrefour, Claro, Enel, Intermédica, LG, Microsoft, Netflix, Xbox	47min
8	Oliver	Male	24	Brazil	Project Analyst	Claro, EA, Instagram, Microsoft, Opera	66min
9	Damian	Male	60	USA	Real Estate Development	Amazon, American Airlines, Meta, Microsoft, Tesla, USAA	51min
10	Sophia	Female	23	Portugal	Master's Student	Betano, NOWO, Prozis, Ryanair, Shein, Siemens, Tesla, Ticketmaster, TVI	62min
11	Raymond	Male	29	USA	Landlord	Apple, Copilot, Duke Energy, EA, Fox, Gemini, HP, Paramount, Roadie, Salvation Army, Spectrum, Tesla, Ubisoft	74min
12	Alexander	Male	57	USA	Translator	Adobe, Ali Express, Amazon, Japan Tobacco, Meta, Microsoft, Tesla, X	69min
13	Claire	Female	41	USA	Filmmaker	Airbnb, Apple, Disney, Spotify, Tesla, Uber, United Healthcare	63min
14	Scarlett	Female	25	Czech Republic	Unemployed Translator	/ Budweiser, Facebook, Google, Instagram, J&J, Nestlé, O2, Propesko, Purina, TikTok, T-Mobile, X	59min
15	Vera	Female	23	Portugal	Master's Student / Sales Executive	Amazon, Betclic, Brandy Melville, Endesa, ESCOnline, Forbes, Guess, Herbalife, IKEA, Klarna, Michael Kors, Nespresso, Ok! Seguros, Prozis, Red Bull, Tesla, Worten, YouTube	65min

16	Bruce	Male	38	USA	Car Rental	Apple, Bank of America, Facebook, Instagram, NFL, Nissan, Range Rover, Tesla, Verizon, Wells Fargo	70min
17	Zachary	Male	56	USA	Public School Teacher	Amazon, Apple, Fox News, Google, Hobby Lobby, Newsmax, Southwest, Tesla, X	61min
18	Hugo	Male	36	Germany	School Teacher	Aldi, Amazon, Balenciaga, Deutsche Ban, Google, Gucci, Müller, Tesla, TikTok, Vorwerk	55min
19	Daisy	Female	34	USA	Massage Therapist	Airbnb, Amazon, Apple, Bank of America, DoorDash, Facebook, Google, Meta, Shein, Spotify, Tesla, United Healthcare, YouTube	57min
20	Ellie	Female	53	Germany / USA / Italy	Global Director of Sales	Amazon, Apple, Barilla, BP, Exxon, Fiat, Frontier, Home Depot, L'Oréal, Louis Vuitton, MAC, Meta, Microsoft, Mondelez, Nestlé, Ryanair, Shein, Southwest, Spotify, Target, Temu, Tesla, Uber, Uline, Walmart, Wells Fargo	65min
21	Carter	Male	45	New Zealand / Kenya	Sales	Fonterra, Instagram, Microsoft, Mondelez, Nestlé, Reddit, Tesla, TikTok	69min
22	Aaron	Male	34	Ireland	Warehouse	Apple, Dacia, Eir, MINI Cooper, Proper N° 12, PTSB, Reebok, Tesla, TikTok, X, Xiaomi	40min
23	Nathan	Male	34	UK	Events Manager	BrewDog, Deliveroo, Facebook, Google, Instagram, Just Eat, Nestlé, Tesla, Thames Water	71min
24	Maya	Female	51	USA	Cloud Engineer Ops	Amazon, Chick-fil-A, Hobby Lobby, Home Depot, Nestlé, U.S. Bank	60min
25	Zoe	Female	34	USA	Licensing Manager	Amazon, Black Myth: Wukong, BlackRock, Delta, Disney, DoorDash, Facebook, Frontier, Google, Instagram, Microsoft, Nestlé, NV Energy, Southwest, Spirit, Spotify, Starburst, Tesla, Wells Fargo, X, Youtube	67min
26	Layla	Female	53	Canada	Faculty Administrator	Fox News, Loblaws, McDonald's, Nestlé, Shell, Tim Hortons	46min
27	Barbara	Female	22	Brazil	Graphic Designer	Fortnite, iFood, Instagram, Skol	78min
28	Ruth	Female	40	USA	Unemployed	Abercrombie & Fitch, Amazon, Apple, DoorDash, Etsy, Facebook, Fox, Google, Instacart, Meow Mix, Meta, Microsoft, Nestlé, SDG&E, Shein, SpaceX, Tesla, Uber, Volkswagen, Walmart, YouTube	75min
29	Ann	Female	30	Brazil	Auditor	Facebook, Globo, Instagram, McDonald's, OnlyFans, Passaredo, XP	63min
30	Jane	Female	36	Brazil	State Bank Clerk	Havan, iFood, Instagram, League of Legends, Madero, TIM	77min

The interviews and netnography were complemented by secondary data from user-generated videos posted on YouTube that criticised brands, and from news articles published by four media conglomerates: Daily Mail (UK), El País (Spain), Folha de São Paulo (Brazil), and USA Today (USA). The use of varied methods and data sources, as a triangulation strategy, was intended to gather multiple perspectives on the phenomenon, enriching the interpretation and allowing a deeper understanding (Rothbauer, 2008).

4.3.2 Analytical Procedures

We applied the premises of Interpretative Phenomenological Analysis to explore how consumers experience and make sense of significant events, interpreting them through hermeneutics (Smith et al., 2009). Grounded theory was also applied to build and derive theoretical contributions inductively from data (Corbin & Strauss, 2015). The first author coded the interview transcripts, field notes, and secondary data using initial and axial coding (Saldaña, 2013), using MAXQDA 24 qualitative data analysis software. The pieces of data were compared with one another and with the whole, following a hermeneutic circle (Arnold & Fischer, 1994). After that, the three authors engaged in discussions, iterations, and comparisons with theory to fine-tune the interpretation of the data and reach theoretical saturation, as the complete range of constructs comprising the theoretical contribution was represented in the data (Saunders et al., 2018). Ultimately, our research relied first on inductive reasoning and second on abductive theory construction to propose an innovative framework (Janiszewski & van Osselaer, 2022).

4.4 Findings

Our findings show that flawed consumer-brand relationships are organised into three structural blocks. The first concerns stimuli that consumers receive and appraise, specifically negative brand personality, which leads to dysfunctional experiences stemming from how brands act and present themselves. The second is the development of problematic relationships caused by stimuli that elicit a diverse range of emotions. The third and final structural block concerns how consumers cope with negative incidents through four mechanisms: confronting, distancing, reframing, and accommodating.

4.4.1 Dark Brand Personality

Respondents faced dysfunctional experiences with brands, initiated by negative brand personalities. They considered them to have human-like dark personality traits, such as

manipulativeness, deception, coldness, lack of empathy, exploitation, and snobbery. When confronted with a negative incident or impressions stemming from negative brand traits, consumers appraised the situation according to several factors: the situational state, their motivation, the probability of the outcomes, and their agency and power (Roseman et al., 1990).

Brands falling in love with their own image. Narcissistic brands are full of themselves, arrogant, egocentric, controlling, overinflated, annoying, and snobby. Jane felt dominated by Instagram and its algorithm, considering that she was unable to control her feed. She was annoyed by the number of unnecessary things she bought and by not being able to turn off ads. When asked to describe the brand, she thought about a controlling figure:

I think it would be a man. A Trump-like man. Like, “Everything is mine [opening her arms], because I liked this thing, I’m going to buy it. I liked this thing, I’m going to have people killed, fuck what they think! And if you fight with me, I’ll triple the tariffs!” you know? [laughs]. I think it would be a dictator in that sense, like, “Everyone look at me and like what I’m doing. And if you don’t like it, you’re trash!” That’s it. (Jane)

Informants felt frustrated by their dependence on services they cannot get rid of or are obliged to use. Wilson described Microsoft similarly to how Jane thinks about Instagram: “ So, this is Microsoft currently: big, fat, with a lot of money, and can do whatever, absolutely whatever they want.” Tim also commented on how Microsoft dictates how consumers must use their products: “So, when they want to force an architectural change, a structural change at the machine level, they don’t care about you at all. You’ll have to buy it and figure it out.” For them, the brand’s egotistical, arrogant nature is only thinking about itself. Most participants also mentioned how technology brands, such as Google, Microsoft, and Meta, are pushing AI features that nobody wants, as Raymond stressed out: “It is one of the most annoying pushes I have ever seen, both Copilot and Gemini, with how hard they’re trying to shove it down your throat! I don’t want to use it.”

Not only do brands demonstrate their power, but they also suppress local competitors by buying them and wiping out the country’s culture. That is how Scarlett feels about Nestlé since the company bought a Czech chocolate brand. She feels powerless against the brand’s autocratic force, comparing the small Czech brand to barnacles that would not hurt a giant whale: “I can’t imagine someone who would love these big firms that are literally eating all

those small ones, right? What is there to like about it? (...) How can a small company from the Czech Republic hurt such a whale?”

When it comes to arrogance, Aaron, Bruce, Tim, and Xavier dislike how Apple presents itself as overpriced, elitist, and cult-driven. Tim explains his point of view: “I never wanted to participate in the Apple cult either. (...) I find it kind of crazy this whole issue of exorbitant prices and having to constantly upgrade to the latest thing, which doesn’t change much.” With the same reasoning, Ruth criticises luxury brands, such as Prada, Gucci, and Yves Saint Laurent, for showing off and selling only a name: “So, I feel like they upsell and they use brand names to do it. (...) You’re taught that this has value because it’s called Prada. Because it’s called Gucci, because it’s Yves Saint Laurent.”

In this sense, narcissistic brands exercise power by being snobs and superior, but they can also combine several dark traits inherited by their CEOs, which are intrinsically connected to them (Bendisch et al., 2013). One comment on Reddit, in a thread discussing how Elon Musk is covering the Earth with SpaceX satellites, exemplifies it: “Each day, that person increasingly resembles a stereotypical comic book supervillain” (anythingbeatsmuch – mildlyinfuriating). Many participants commented on the CEO’s personality and how it affected the brands they consumed. Alexander explains how CEOs are only thinking about themselves and not about the consumers:

But with Meta, with, you know, Tesla, anything by Musk, with Amazon, you have sociopaths, avowed sociopaths, clearly sociopathic people, charismatic sociopaths who are running the show. And their values and their goals are typically opposed to the values and goals of the consumers using those services or purchasing those products. (Alexander)

Lacking empathy for the consumer. Brands that have psychopathic traits act unscrupulously, lacking moral values and empathy. They are insensitive to consumer demands and feelings, inflicting harm, discriminating, being neglectful and irresponsible. In a Daily Mail news article, chief reporter Sam Greenhill explained his quest against TalkTalk, a British telecommunications provider. He had problems with his phone and tried for months to get it fixed by the company without success, ultimately taking them to court and winning the case:

My efforts to alert TalkTalk to this telephone fault descended into farce. It was like Groundhog Day. I spoke to a different person in its Far Eastern call centre each time, none of whom knew anything about my previous calls. Few seemed remotely

bothered about our problem. (...) TalkTalk's call centre offered me a desultory £5 discount to make up for the problems. We said they should come and fix the damage. (...) I was nearly ready to throw in the towel. I suggested to TalkTalk that I would settle for £300 and an apology — so we could all move on. But TalkTalk stuck to its guns, saying the £60 discount was its 'full and final' offer. And then it added insult to injury. It sent a letter accusing us of 'only noticing' after two months that our phones were not working. The reality was we had 'noticed' when we desperately needed the emergency services, but TalkTalk only took notice of our complaint after two months of phoning its call centre. That was the moment I resolved not to let it drop. It had become a matter of principle. (Greenhill, 2017)

Informants and users reported several incidents involving brands that mistreated them by denying refunds, failing to deliver purchased items, incorrectly charging, cancelling paid services, or selling malfunctioning products. They felt frustrated and angry because the companies did nothing to repair the damage, failed to solve the issue, and showed no concern for them. One Reddit user complained about Air Canada, as the company delayed the flight, made him miss two connections and left the family with a dog for hours without assistance: "Air Canada didn't get us anything: no meals, no hotel, absolutely nothing. We ended up paying \$250 for lounge access so we could sit with our dog. Another family got upgraded, and we were stuck with cramped seats." (320_BootySorcerer – mildlyinfuriating). On YouTube, users posted videos to vent their anger, document the lack of quality, and warn other consumers not to buy the brand, as Emira Tolban did. She recorded a video to "warn the American public" that a Ford Focus was garbage due to several issues, stating that Ford knew about the problems, continued selling the vehicles, and that the dealers lied about it.

Repeated problems with no solution led informants to dystopian realities, as Martin narrates his odyssey against Xfinity, a Comcast subsidiary. It started when the company installed internet in his house, inadvertently cutting off the neighbours' connection the day before the Super Bowl. The relationship with the company went downhill since then, with modem connection problems and not being able to solve them: "And every time I have to interact with their customer service, whether it be on the website, in a chat or on the phone, each time it's just more of a pain in the butt than it was the last time." When technicians went to fix the problems, they blamed the previous ones, leaving him empty-handed. Martin also had his service turned off because the company failed to debit his bank account. In a nutshell,

Xfinity was neglectful, irresponsible, and lacked empathy. He summarises the relationship as painful and burdensome: “So, it’s just been 30 years of frustration with them!”

The lack of care for consumers can reach alarming levels in healthcare. Justin explains that his health insurance, from Intermédica, took a long time to approve his request: “And it’s an emergency surgery, right? So, after appendicitis was detected, I waited almost 48 hours for them to operate on me.” After being asked how he felt and reacted to being left waiting, Justin answered: “Oh, I felt scared, you know? Because if it ruptured, it’s a risk. (...) But at the time, I even had the impression that they wanted it to rupture so the surgery would be more expensive.” Thus, the brand is seen as egoistic and irresponsible, putting consumers in danger. The same feeling is shared by Daisy, who considers healthcare insurance companies terrible and unwilling to help consumers, particularly United Healthcare:

Awful, evil, evil company! I know so many people in the healthcare industry. I have a friend who’s a doctor, and I’ve listened to him talk about the things he has to do to advocate for his patients when insurance doesn’t want to pay for their care. And somebody who’s not even a doctor will make the call that somebody doesn’t deserve to have their care paid for, and it’s fucking absurd! These companies are really evil.
(Daisy)

Manipulating the consumer. Machiavellianistic brands exploit their relationships with consumers for their own interest, deceiving and lying to them, spying, stalking, and making them addicted to their products. Bruce has a hard time with banks, saying they should not exist, though he loves the stock market and uses it for his personal and business activities. He pictures the banking system as a necessary evil that can be managed. However, Bruce dislikes banks for being manipulative and serving their own needs, rigging the stock market. He explains how he won a case against Wells Fargo: “They’re the biggest criminal entity in the world as far as for banking. (...) I’ve been a victim to their fraudulent practices, seriously, to the point that I’ve even gotten checks, you know?”

Informants often commented on exploitation and manipulation, stating that they were being scammed and tricked or that the system is fraudulent. After going to McDonald’s and wanting to try a Monopoly raffle, one Reddit user was flabbergasted and realised that the odds of winning did not seem right: “What the fuck? Odds of 1 in 60 billion??? And it doesn’t stop there: there are others like 1 in 12 billion and 1 in 30 billion. This is completely ridiculous! Is this even legal?” (Kittora2005 – mildlyinfuriating). Answering his question, others jumped in

to comment that it was easier to win the lottery or that McDonald's purposely launched a sweepstakes that is statistically impossible to win.

Several situations prompted consumers to complain online about how brands are shrinking packaging and the amount of products while keeping prices, with some feeling that they are buying empty containers and are being deceived by the brands, as one Reddit user posted about Pampers: "Why is so much stuff for babies a rip-off? People always go on about how expensive it is, but paying the same price for LESS diapers 🙄 is ridiculous!!" (Relentless_Tension642 – mildlyinfuriating). Other users complained about service providers, saying it was difficult to rely on them and that they seemed like parasites: "Instead of cancelling my membership, they wanted to charge me monthly to freeze it. Fuck You LA Fitness!" (_midnightglow_ – mildlyinfuriating). The parasitic nature of some brands is often seen in technology, as another user commented about Motorola pushing Glance, their AI feature: "This motherfucker parasite! (...) I tried hunting down the app so I could delete it. I CAN'T DELETE IT. So I disabled it. It's still fucking running." (Frozen-Sketch1743 – mildlyinfuriating).

Brands can also stalk and spy on consumers, storing information about them and using it for their own interest. Participants were concerned about their privacy, as brands and governments hide their true intentions when collecting data. When asked if tech brands are not being transparent, Damian agrees and adds: "They're collecting it (...), but it's not being disclosed to the consumers and the people about exactly how that data is being used and where it's going, and what it's being used for." As a sales representative of a technology company, Carter understands how companies can be invasive, gathering data to offer products and services, sometimes even embarrassingly, which could cause serious troubles:

And many years ago, Target observed their customers, you know? And the story goes. There was a young lady who bought very specific items when she went there. And those very specific items were very indicative of the behaviours of somebody who is about to be a new mother. (...) Target sends a leaflet, a piece of mail, to that house. And the father sees it and puts two and two together and goes, "Oh my God, my daughter's pregnant!" And how does Target know about it? (Carter)

Participants reported that brands create addictive features to hook consumers to their products and services, manipulating how they feel, behave, and have relationships with other people. Scarlett stresses her distrust of pharmaceutical companies, of how they do not care for patients, and are not interested in finding the cure for diseases to keep consumers buying their

drugs: “They are basically trying to make you ill a bit, just so you would be dependent on their medications over and over and create this loop of dependency.”

Other informants talked about social media and technology brands as problematic and a source of addiction, but most felt they were unescapable, a necessary evil. Carter believes that modern technology is a necessity and that consumers do not have a choice, as if people were selling their souls: “I think there was a Reddit thread that said, ‘Internet and a phone are basic human needs,’ you know? So, people are equating it to, like, shelter.” Even when participants did not think that brands were addictive, they admitted that they were indispensable, as Amazon is to Daisy: “I wouldn’t say it’s an addiction, but I would still say they’re probably like a drug dealer. Like, yeah, I don’t want to deal with them, but I really need this thing right now [laughs].”

4.4.2 Negative Consumer-Brand Relationships

We identified 13 negative consumer-brand relationships associated with the three dark personality traits, as seen in Table 4.3. To provide thicker, deeper descriptions, we selected exemplary stories for each, grouping them according to their respective dark brand personality traits. The relationships are not mutually exclusive, as informants may have multiple relationships with the same brands, consistent with previous research (Alves & Strehlau, 2025).

Narcissistic consumer-brand relationships. Narcissistic brands break promises by leaving their consumers orphans and sad, or betray their trust by going against the beliefs and values they once defended. We start by discussing two stories from Southwest that exemplify the absent/orphans relationship.

Zachary used to be a loyal Southwest customer. He tried to use a flight credit, but the company would not allow it, even after he booked a full-fare ticket. Southwest was convenient for Zachary because one of their airports is 15 minutes from his home. He was upset with the recent changes at the company, which made it more anti-consumer, introduced reserved seating, and dropped its free bag-check policy. When asked how he would describe the brand as a person, Zachary thought about how the changes are affecting the brand’s culture and personality: “It’s like they were an idealistic young person, and as they’ve gotten older, they’ve become more cynical and driven by their needs versus their customer needs (...) they’re making a decision based on just money versus who they are.” Zoe also felt abandoned and orphaned when Southwest changed its policies: “So, I always felt like they were reliable. I felt like I was

taken care of. I never had any issues.” However, Zoe felt that the company was selling its soul by becoming more of the same, similar to other airlines: “So, it’s extremely disappointing, particularly in today’s world, to see them chase after normalcy [laughs] (...) take away all the things that make them unique. It’s just really sad!”

Another way that brands break the consumer’s trust is by going against what they once believed or broadcast as their values. The traitors/betrayed relationship is exemplified by Nathan’s story, who was a fan of BrewDog and its founders because it was an independent company, compassionate towards its employees, and different from other British beer brands. However, internal changes began to surface, damaging the brand’s reputation. BrewDog promised to be an independent beer company, but sold part of the company to expand to the US. Nathan even invested in the firm, but later realised that BrewDog was not issuing real shares, which cost him money. The brand also stood for values such as protecting the environment and having a good workplace. “Then, yeah, sadly, all those things that they said they stood for have faded away. They’ve changed drastically.” Nathan felt betrayed by the changes and, particularly, by the toxic character of James Watt, one of the founders, who was accused of abusing employees: “I think he’s a classic example of someone who just got too rich and too powerful. And it’s probably just been very mean and nasty, and it’s just too full of himself.”

The second aspect of narcissistic brands is how they exert their superior might against consumers. Cecil explains how he is obliged to buy from some companies in a forced marriage relationship. When asked about how he dealt with energy, gas, and water companies, Cecil is not happy to be stuck with limited options and complained about the privatisation of services in the UK, saying that energy prices became the most expensive in Europe. Commenting on British Gas, he believes the company provides poor service for a public concession: “They went private and aren’t very good. I mean, the prices that they offer are about average for most houses, but what they don’t offer is anything beneficial.” Even when there is a choice, like in car insurance, it is mandatory, Cecil points out that all alternatives are equally bad: “ You have to have it. But it’s a racket, you know? There’s no real way of competing, finding a good deal on it because everything is extremely expensive.”

Table 4.3 - Negative brand personality types and their respective consumer-brand relationships.

Negative brand personality	Traits	Action	Consumer-brand relationship	Definition	Data example
Narcissism	Overinflated, arrogant, snobbish, authoritarian, and egocentric	Breaking the Spell	Absent / Orphans	An abandoned relationship in which the brand left the consumer behind by changing its essence.	“I think all companies will screw up. I think that’s the nature of companies. They’re just as flawed as human beings. So, to be fair, if Disney turned around and they were like, ‘Hey, we’re going to support young artists again, and we’re not going to do anything with AI, and we’re making this whole initiative to change it. We’re going to make the parks cheaper so families can enjoy it, just like Walt Disney envisioned back in the day.’ I’d be willing to give them a chance, right?” (Zoe)
			Traitors / Betrayed	A brand that betrays the consumer’s trust by turning against beliefs and principles once professed.	“So, under pressure from Republican lawmakers, Target cancelled all of its DEI policies and equality policies. (...) [I felt] betrayed as anybody can feel by a faceless corporation, of course. But, you know, it disappointed to find out that a place that I would willingly spend my money because I thought they were, quote, ‘a good company’, whatever that means, and finding out that they were not, and willing to bow under pressure from Trump’s administration.” (Ellie)
		Exerting Power	Forced Marriage	A forced relationship in which the consumer is unable to leave, lacks alternatives, or is obliged to remain.	“I was stuck with Comcast here because they had an effective monopoly. So, if I did have a problem with my service (...), complain as I might to them, they knew that I really couldn’t go anywhere.” (Martin)
			Dictator / Subjects	An authoritarian brand that holds absolute power over the consumer, ruling by decree and force.	“This shithead [Copilot] was installed on my iPhone without my permission. My phone is none of Microsoft’s business. It didn’t alert me, give warnings, or notify me that it was installed. It was silently sitting in the background.” (endless017 – mildly infuriating)

Psychopathy	Insensitive, distant, callous, unempathetic, and immoral	Inflicting Damage	Sadists / Masochists	A mixed-feeling relationship in which the brand inflicts pain and suffering, yet the consumer derives pleasure or benefits from it.	“I’ll say something about Verizon. They’re a piece of shit! (...) I use it because I’ve been grandfathered in. You see, it’s something that my dad had. (...) But every time that I try to leave, they’d be giving me some nice deals, and I just keep, you know? [laughs]. (Bruce)
			Domestic Abuse	A close and forced relationship where the brand controls and abuses the consumer emotionally, financially, or psychologically through coercion.	“So, Spectrum dominated our area. They basically had a monopoly here in North Carolina. (...) It was just a horrible experience towards the end. (...) When your only option was one cable company or dial-up, that’s not much of an option.” (Raymond)
			Criminals / Victims	Brands that committed a strong offence against the consumer, inflicting financial, emotional, psychological, and social damages.	“The restaurant can’t prepare the food I ordered since it doesn’t exist. What did Grubhub do? They kept my money anyway! They have become a sophisticated scam operation that robs your money right after you place an order. Grubhub then dares you to fight for a reimbursement you’re obviously entitled to. It’s no surprise that this trash company refuses refunds, lies, stalls, and eventually steals from customers while hiding behind its policy. Absolute horror show. Never using this predatory app again!” (creative_commons97 – mildlyinfuriating)
		Lacking Morality	Moral Enemies	A brand that acts against the consumer values and beliefs, disregarding principles of right or wrong, and permanently damaging the relationship.	“The simple reason is that the owner of Prozis once commented about abortions, and he doesn't support legalised abortion. So, for me, Prozis annoys me because it angers me to see it succeed in something that, behind it, is a person so misaligned with my values. Prozis irritates me a lot!” (Vera)
			Bullies / Bullied	An intentional, aggressive relationship where the brand discriminates, harasses, and humiliates the consumer, or looks the other way for bullying behaviour.	“I didn’t really like playing Fortnite because it has some pretty weird people [laughs]. Especially when it's girls playing. (...) There's some harassment, and I don't like games where there are too many boys, either. (...) I believe that maybe it’s the company that allows this type of behaviour, and there’s no punishment, you know?” (Barbara)

Machiavellianism	Manipulative, liar, calculating, sneaky, and exploitative	Deceiving	Crooks / Suckers	A relationship where the brand is deceiving, dishonest, and can use charm and psychological manipulation to gain the consumer's trust.	"When you get into a Fiat, my impression is that it's generically designed, and it's made with the intention of, let's say, deceiving less informed people." (Xavier)
			Host / Parasite	A dysfunctional relationship in which the brand takes advantage of the consumer by extracting financial, emotional, and social benefits while giving little or nothing in return.	"And so, I don't like it either because they [Ryanair] will use every opportunity they have to take money from the consumer to charge for something. And I think it gets to a point, jeez, it just doesn't feel good anymore, you know? (...) People aren't nice, and then it's cramped, and it hurts." (Sophia)
		Controlling	Dealers / Addicts	An asymmetrical relationship where the brand purposely provides products and services that unleash addictive behaviours in the consumer, profiting from it.	"The crash today just made me realise how pathetic my life is without this app [Reddit]. Refreshed 47 times like a moron during the outage (...) then just sat staring at my phone like a zombie, praying to the gods to bring it back. (...) This site owns me. I might need some fresh air." (@silentmotion2356 – mildlyinfuriating)
			Spies / Targets	A clandestine, obscure, and covert relationship in which the brand spies, observes, and gathers data from the consumer, often without their knowledge, to use it for its own benefit.	"It's espionage, definitely, because they are taking data about you without your consent and without your knowledge. (...) I think with something like Google or Facebook or, you know, Samsung or whatever, they aren't doing it necessarily for themselves, they're doing it on behalf of somebody else." (Cecil)

Apart from forced marriages, brands can act like dictators, subjugating consumers to obey their orders. Carter talks about several big corporations and how ubiquitous they are, making them indispensable and unavoidable: “But I think it is bothersome because the big companies, the biggest companies are Apple, Meta, Amazon, and so on. And they sort of control the narrative, don’t they? They sort of decide.” Talking about Fonterra, a New Zealand dairy corporation, Carter is blunt: “You couldn’t avoid Fonterra because all our milk comes from Fonterra. It would be nearly impossible, unless you stop drinking milk.” He is pragmatic and thinks that people often are cynical and hypocritical when criticising these companies, as he comments about the movie *The Gods Must be Crazy*: “Because, at some point, the bushman is going to drink a Coke, you know? He’s going to submit himself to modernity, as awful as we think it is.”

The last narcissistic relationship regards sadists/masochists. Even though there is asymmetrical power and the brand controls the relationship, the consumer benefits. It might be contradictory, but there is a positive outcome for the person. Bruce complains about Verizon and how the company has got worse over the years: “I remember back in the day, when you had Verizon, there was a difference in quality (...) Right now, hell no! Verizon is like cricket. Damn near like the same shit! [laughs].” However, when he was provoked by the interviewer, saying he kept using it, Bruce confessed that he has been with Verizon for 20 years and was sincere: “But every time that I try to leave, they’d be giving me some nice deals, and I just keep, you know? [laughs] (...) But the thing is what I’m paying, what I’m getting... It’s gonna be hard to match it.”

Psychopathic consumer-brand relationships. Psychopathic brands lack empathy for the consumer, being insensitive and causing harm. The first relationship concerns domestic abuse, which is different from a forced marriage since it involves mistreatment and stronger negative emotions. However, the consumer benefits from the interaction with the brand, or does not have better options, even though they suffer abuse.

Sophia told two consumption stories that illustrate this relationship. She flies Ryanair from Portugal to other countries because it is a low-cost airline that suits her needs. Sophia described a bad experience at the airport when travelling with her girlfriends. A Ryanair employee checked her bags to see if they fit with the stipulated measures: “And the lady was really mean to us, like, I ended up having to put my backpack there [into the bag sizer] four

times, even though mine fit right away.” The employee told another that the girls were a problem, and started complaining that Sophia had brought a second item:

So, I went to swipe my ticket, and the lady who called the supervisor saw that I had my wallet. And she turned to me, looked me in the eyes, and shouted, “I already told you that you can’t bring the second item!” And I just looked at them, “Look, your colleague said I could,” “But I’m the one in charge here!” (Sophia)

Sophia also had a hard time with Ticketmaster. As a Harry Styles fan, she was anxious to buy a good seat for the show and slept two nights in a mall to be one of the first in line. When her way finally came, the Ticketmaster website crashed because of high demand, forcing her to try several times without any luck: “And I think they do it on purpose, because years and years go by and nobody likes buying concert tickets, because it’s always awful!” She felt devastated by not being able to buy the tickets she wanted: “I cried a lot, and it was very dramatic because I spent two nights at the mall, which was horrible!”

Different from domestic abuse, a criminals/victims relationship regards stronger brand wrongdoings, causing severe damages to the consumers, either psychologically, emotionally, or financially. Oliver had a serious problem with a Brazilian phone carrier, Claro, which sold two cell phone lines without his consent. He was not a client, but Claro used his name, ID, and a fake address to sell the lines. Eventually, the unpaid bills were sent to a debt collection agency, as he was trying to fix the problem caused by the brand: “Trying to solve it with them was awful, terrible! In fact, it’s not fixed. I’m taking them to court because of this.”

Another psychopathic relationship concerns moral enmity. Consumers have strong negative feelings towards brands that deviate from moral standards or act against the person’s values. Maya dislikes Hobby Lobby for denying employees access to birth control in their insurance, finding it unethical: “And I don’t think that you, as my employer, except in very specific roles, get to determine what religion I follow, what my ethics or morals are, as long as I’m not doing something illegal.” Zachary also hates Hobby Lobby for being immoral: “I would never, ever shop with them! I consider them just immoral and decrepit in six ways to Sunday.” He explains that the company is anti-LGBT and was convicted of stealing historical artefacts from Iraq: “I teach history, and it’s just the fact that they would be ripping off (...) relics from people’s home countries (...) and lying about it, is just as terrible corporate behaviour as you could possibly imagine!”

The last psychopathic relationship is related to bullies/bullied. In this type of relationship, the brand bullies consumers, is neglective, or creates an environment that lets inappropriate behaviour happen, as in the case of sexism, racism, ageism, or any derogatory conduct. Jane used to play League of Legends, but she no longer does. She dislikes how the game is toxic for women, as a lot of men play it, harassing them: “People will make fun of you, saying things like, ‘Oh, it had to be a woman, go wash the dishes!’, you know? So, sometimes there are these really annoying extremes.” Similarly, Barbara suffered prejudice and sexism for being a woman playing games, sometimes using a male username or muting gamers to deal with the stress: “[Fortnite] is not very accessible for girls to play with. There are a lot of perverted men there.” She also stressed that if a player did not perform well in a match, some users would bully them, without any reaction from the game developer: “That doesn't provide a good experience; it becomes really toxic, you know? It makes playing Fortnite, or any other online game, a really bad experience.”

Machiavellian consumer-brand relationships. Machiavellian brands deceive consumers by manipulation and exploitation, promising something and not delivering. Brands are seen as crooks who build trust, but ultimately trick them and make them feel like suckers. Hugo bought a cleaning robot from a brand called Neato, which worked fine. At some point, Vorwerk bought the brand and promised to maintain the infrastructure to keep the robot working, since it depended on cloud servers. However, Hugo was one day warned by the company that it would no longer support the product. He felt frustrated and deceived by the lack of care:

I was livid! I mean, I had a working robot vacuum that I used at least five times a week, and now I can't use it anymore. It's basically useless! (...) So, from one moment to another, they turned a functioning robot vacuum into a pile of garbage. And I can't do anything about it, and they're not compensating me. So, yeah, I'm furious! [laughs] (Hugo)

Sometimes brands are not directly or necessarily deceiving consumers, but exploiting them in host/parasite relationships. Alexander was a loyal user of Adobe products for years, since he depended on them for graphic design. He is particularly annoyed by the subscription model, which he sees as a money grab, and has led him to stop buying Adobe's products. Alexander goes on to say that the company's mindset is not beneficial for the consumers since the prices are too high, and users depend on their products: “It's geared towards professional users who need it. And it's almost like the mafia. These professional users have to use Adobe. (...) So, it's kind of, you know, like highway robbery in a sense.”

On the other hand, another parasitic relationship concerns Airbnb, as Claire explains how the brand exploits the city where she lives, driving up rents and house prices, and gradually replacing local shops and culture with an infrastructure to serve tourists. Airbnb behaves like a parasite, taking advantage of its host and changing the city for the worse, which might even kill it:

I do think it is parasitic. (...) So, whenever those people, the culture bearers of the area, the reason why people come here, can't afford to live here, then the city's going to die. Then, I think at a certain point, people won't want to come here if it's just a bunch of half-empty houses being rented as Airbnbs. It won't be interesting anymore. So, I could see it even killing the culture of a place. (Claire)

Machiavellian brands also resort to asymmetrical power, such as in relationships between dealers and addicts. Three distinct negative aspects of Instagram illustrate this type of relationship. Barbara reports the first one, calling attention to how people are not themselves on the platform, only praising their qualities, especially influencers: "It's very bad when someone uses the platform to do evil, to show off a life they don't have." She used to spend eight hours per day on Instagram and felt an abstinence crisis after deciding to stop using it.

A second harmful aspect concerns social comparisons and a sense of group. Ann felt bad using Instagram because she compared herself with slimmer girls who went to the gym and had beautiful bodies. After leaving the platform, she was surprised that her friends did not look for her, as if they had a fake bond: "So, the impression I get is... after I left social media, I'm dead. I'm dead! I don't feel like I have any real friends, like, that I can count on, you know?"

The third negative aspect concerns consumerism. Jane was addicted to Instagram, spending a lot of money on things she did not need. She tried to avoid ads, but the app continued to bombard her with them, as a dealer filling her with drugs: "I kept saying I didn't want to see it anymore, but then another one would come along. (...) No matter how many ads you don't wanna see, they'll put one back in its place." Reflecting on how social media works, Zoe sums up the relationship with them: "Not feel like I'm forced, like I have to keep looking. And I can turn it off when I want to. It's like somebody stopped giving me cocaine. It's really nice [laughs]."

The last Machiavellian relationship regards how consumers feel spied on by brands, as if they were targets. Wilson works with IT and, because of that, he knows how technology companies have been making their products worse over the years, calling it *enshittification*, a

recurring theme among most informants and Reddit users. He is worried about brands spying on what he does, as he comments about Microsoft: “This is my computer, I want to use it, and I don’t want you and your over 3000 partners to know what I’m doing on my computer.” Wilson complains that Google is forcing users to provide their real names and IDs to develop applications. He also affirms that Apple listens to conversations even when told not to: “They also sell your data. They also collect a lot of your data. I could pull up my pie hole statistics right now and see that every 15 minutes, my wife’s MacBook is sending a ping to Apple’s servers.”

Tim also dislikes how brands gather data that they were not supposed to store, explaining that Google had information that he lived in a rented apartment based on his search history: “That’s when things start to get scary when you don’t explicitly provide them, because it gives them a lot of power over how they present the information or (...) how they want you to act online and as a consumer.” Cecil shares the same level of worry about technology companies spying on consumers and getting annoyed by ads that stalk him across the internet. However, he sees it more as spying rather than stalking: “It’s espionage, definitely, because they are taking data about you without your consent and without your knowledge.”

4.4.3 Consumer Coping Mechanisms and Behaviours

So far, we have covered evidence on negative brand personalities and flawed consumer-brand relationships. However, one final piece of the puzzle is missing: how do consumers cope with their bad experiences? We have identified four coping mechanisms: accommodating, distancing, confronting, and reframing, which are shown in Table 4.4. The connections among coping strategies, branding constructs, emotions, and behaviours are depicted in Table 4.5. Consumers blend diverse coping mechanisms with emotions and behaviours, adopting several combinations.

Table 4.4 - Consumer coping mechanisms.

Accomodating	Distancing	Confronting	Reframing
Accepts the unpleasant brand relationship as unavoidable, weighing the potential benefits against it and showing resignation.	Avoids the problematic brand relationship by divorcing from it, finding alternatives, or ignoring it.	Confronts the stressful brand relationship by attacking the problem through boycotting, venting, or subversive actions.	Uses cognitive strategies to manage the meanings associated with the brand relationship, rationalising, minimising negative aspects, or changing the perception.

Table 4.5 - The interplay of coping mechanisms, emotions, behaviours, and brand-related constructs.

Coping mechanism	Emotion	Coping behaviour	Brand-related construct	Prior research example
Confronting + distancing	Anger + fear	Boycotting, venting, retaliating, attacking, and complaining	Brand hate; brand repulsion; brand revenge; brand negativity; brand shame	Dessart & Cova, 2021; Grégoire et al., 2009; Grégoire & Fisher, 2008; Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025; Zarantonello et al., 2016
Reframing + confronting	Anger + happiness	Mocking, subverting, schadenfreude, and doppelganger	Brand sabotage; brandjacking; consumer subversion	Kähr et al. 2016; Thompson, Rindfleisch, and Arsel 2006; Thota 2021; Wilson et al. 2022
Accommodating + reframing	Happiness + sadness	Forbearing, conforming, yearning, addicting, and positive and rational thinking	Brand nostalgia; brand resignation; brand addiction; compensatory consumption	Demirbag-Kaplan et al. 2015; Mrad and Cui 2017; Rauber et al. 2024
Distancing + accommodating	Fear + sadness	Avoiding, divorcing, and switching	Brand avoidance; brand divorce	Ferraz and Dallabrida 2024; Lee et al. 2009

Confronting brands. Some informants dealt with the stress of flawed consumer-brand relationships by planning actions to address the problem or by expressing their emotions. Layla is disappointed with Tim Hortons for lowering their service quality over the years and losing their Canadian tradition, eventually being sold to an international group. She coped with the situation by boycotting the brand, which is also true for other brands sold to American corporations: “I’ve always, in my whole life of being, boycotting America [laughs]. (...) So, yeah, of course it bothers me to see that slowly but surely other companies, basically, be swallowed up by American ones.”

Another confrontational strategy is when consumers vent their rage against brands to make it even with them. Even after 10 years of a bad experience with Eir, a telecommunications provider in Ireland, Aaron does not get tired of complaining and spreading negative word-of-mouth, which was his main motivation to participate in the interview: “Any opportunity I have to talk about Eir, I’ll convince people to stay away from them. They’re just brutal! They’re really, really bad.” When participants expressed hatred, it reverberated in their behaviour, as Xavier avoids being near Fiat cars and warns everyone about them: “I don’t like seeing them, and I avoid stopping near them. (...) I even have a friend who (...) wants to buy a Fiat Doblò. So I tell him not to, because it will ruin his life.”

In some situations, participants had to file formal complaints to solve their problems or even go to court. That happened to Damian, who had his flight cancelled by American Airlines

and was left without accommodation or meals, leading him to file a complaint against the company. Another type of reaction regards how consumers creatively resort to subversive actions to cope with a bad experience. Martin does not approve of how Disney is using AI in their productions and decided to boycott its newer movies, but still consumed the old content. However, Martin decided to be subversive: “I would gladly pirate their content to avoid giving them money because I don’t like what they’re doing now.” Similarly, Oliver cancelled Netflix after realising that the third *Twin Peaks* season was not available and decided not to trust the streaming services anymore, resorting to piracy as well.

Distancing from brands. Another way that consumers cope with flawed relationships with brands is by avoiding, quitting, or fleeing them. Cecil avoids Trago Mills, a British retailer, since the company does not care about the environment. Also, the CEO was involved in controversies and discriminatory behaviours: “(...) he’s an extremely homophobic man who advocated for gay men to be chemically castrated immediately, which isn’t really a good look for a large company [laughs].” With the same rationale, Alexander explains that he avoids companies for their lack of moral values, such as Nestlé and, particularly, Japan Tobacco:

They know they’re harming society, and they do it anyway. I was going to work with Japan Tobacco at one point. They wanted me to be an account manager for their consumer research projects. And they wanted me to figure out a way to get smokers not to quit. (...) “They’re already smoking. Why quit? And let’s find out what we can say to them, so they don’t quit”. And I quit that job. I quit that company, the company I was working for. “No, I’m not going to do that”, and I just left. (Alexander)

The way companies operate and their philosophy also prompt participants to avoid them, as Raymond and Louise noted that Hewlett-Packard forces consumers to subscribe to its services while delivering a poor experience. Louise once trusted the brand but changed her mind: “(...) your printer doesn’t function right if you don’t sign up for their subscription has completely changed the way I feel about them. (...) I will avoid that brand because of that.” Raymond has a similar understanding, which stopped him from using his HP printer: “They were trying to get me to buy a subscription for printer ink. The moment it was plugged in! (...) That feels rather predatory in ways.”

Reframing the brand relationship. Not only do consumers confront brands and distance themselves from them, but they also re-evaluate their appraisal of the relationship. Some participants rationalised their choices, understanding that they were the best available option.

Although disliking American brands, Layla still shops at Walmart: “They’re cheaper. I hate the fact that they’re Walmart and they’re American. But what can you do?” In the same sense, Sophia explains she grew up with fast-fashion retailers like Zara and is familiarised with them, but avoids Shein: “They’re both bad, but Shein is like ten times worse.”

Another strategy to reframe how the brand is perceived is to cultivate a positive mindset. Zachary commented on the way Chick-fil-A, an American restaurant chain, supported causes he disagreed with. However, he reformulates his thinking to justify going there: “(...) they offer amazing customer service. And they’re locally managed, and locally they’re franchises. (...) And, you know, they get back to the community and all that.” Maya also minimises the fact that Chick-fil-A corporation was accused of being anti-LGBT: “(...) we finally, you know, have a Chick-fil-A where I live here, and I go, I would say about half the employees are clearly LGBT. So, it’s like what their corporate says and what they do seems quite different.”

Accommodating to the brand experience. The last coping strategy concerns how consumers resign themselves and accept the flawed relationship with the brand. Even though having negative feelings towards Google, Louise keeps using it because the research results are good, conforming to the situation: “And I think that that’s part of the conversation, that how difficult will it be to make a switch or find an equal alternative over just accepting something that’s an annoyance.” Sometimes, the product can be irresistible, despite the bad brand reputation. Zoe thinks Nestlé is an evil company, but makes an exception: “But do I still buy? Did I buy a chocolate chip cookie, Nestlé cookies, literally this morning? Yes, they’re in my fridge. (...) But I really want a cookie, though [laughs].”

There are also situations in which the consumer feels helpless, unable to confront the situation. Several informants reported that they could not do anything other than accept having a relationship with a particular brand. This situation is common for public concessions, such as water, energy, and gas. Xavier commented that the water company in his area is not trustworthy, as it fails to keep a steady water supply, but conforms to the situation: “It’s like you’ve been forced only to have this option your whole life, you know? You never expected another alternative. So, I think it’s a conditioning to accept it.” It is an unescapable harsh reality to be forced to buy from some companies, as Aaron points out: “It’s just the price of electricity and gas has gone very expensive. But everyone has to pay. So, what can you really do?”

Although consumers tolerate a bad brand relationship, that does not mean they are happy with it. In some cases, they yearn for what the brands used to be. Louise dislikes how Chips

Ahoy tastes today to the point of giving up on it: “I used to love Chips Ahoy, and now we buy them, and we don’t even finish the package because they’re just like, ‘Nah!’”. However, she still got excited about a new co-branded packaging with *Stranger Things*, reminding her of her childhood in the 80s. Ellie also feels nostalgic about Fiat, which reminds her of her young years living in Italy. Nevertheless, she is mad about the corporate fusion with Chrysler, but it did not prevent her from buying a Fiat car: “I felt sad. (...) But I will tell you, I did buy a used Fiat Cinquecento. Used. It was five years old, stick shift. I missed Italy! [laughs].”

4.5 Discussion

This research reveals how flawed consumer-brand relationships are triggered, appraised, developed, and coped with. We extend knowledge of a growing body of studies on negative aspects towards brands, including brand hate, betrayal, avoidance, sabotage, and divorce (Ferraz & Dallabrida, 2024; Kähr et al., 2016; Lee et al., 2009; Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025; Zarantonello et al., 2016). Our research answers a call to investigate new brand relationship types, define triggers, and explore the interactions and outcomes of these relationships (Alvarez et al., 2023).

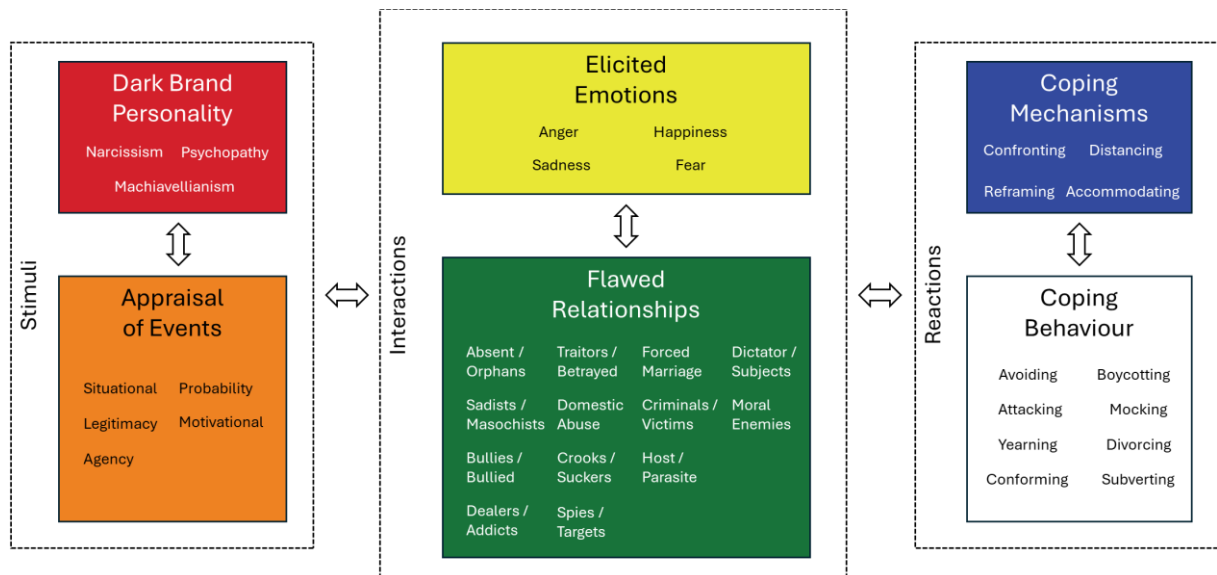
Since the initial work by Fournier (1998), whose primary focus was on positive consumer-brand relationships, few studies have proposed frameworks to organise and explain negative consumer-brand relationships. We expand on prior literature that proposed typologies and theoretical models directed to brand contestation (Dietrich & Russell, 2021), consumer subversion (Wilson et al., 2022), and brand sabotage (Kähr et al., 2016). Our research also has implications for negative brand personality (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024), showing how it interacts with emotions, behaviours, and coping mechanisms.

We make three interconnected contributions to literature. First, a framework is introduced to explain the flawed consumer-brand relationships and their connection to stimuli and coping mechanisms. Second, we discuss that dark brand personalities, appraisals of events, relationships, emotions, coping strategies, and behaviours are interrelated and multidimensional. Third, we build on the fragmented literature on brand hate to examine how negative brand-related constructs relate to emotions and coping mechanisms. We detail these contributions next.

4.5.1 Development of flawed consumer-brand relationships

Flawed consumer-brand relationships are developed through a series of processes and interactions, as shown in Figure 4.1. Consumers face negative experiences triggered by the dark brand personality traits (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024). Their emotions will be influenced by appraising the events along five dimensions (Roseman et al., 1990). Motivation refers to seeking awards or avoiding punishments, while the situation determines whether they are present. Probability concerns whether the event is certain or uncertain, and legitimacy regards whether a positive or negative outcome is deserved. Finally, the agency determines if the event was caused by the self, the other, or the circumstances.

Figure 4.1 - Flawed consumer-brand relationships.



Source: author's own work.

After appraising the negative events, consumers interact with the brands, eliciting emotions and developing flawed relationships (Table 4.3). The emotions are combined with coping mechanisms and behaviours (Table 4.5), leading to confrontation, accommodation, distancing, or reframing. The proposed framework organises and explains how diverse, flawed consumer-brand relationships are structured, developed, nurtured, and handled. Different from other models that focused on contestation, which refers to a change in brand meaning by consumers (Dietrich & Russell, 2021), or on sabotage and how consumers aggressively attack brands (Kähr et al., 2016), our framework is more comprehensive to encompass a diverse range of negative reactions, relationships, and coping strategies. The identified negative consumer-

brand relationships surface more complex and nuanced experiences, not limited to anger or meaning hijacking.

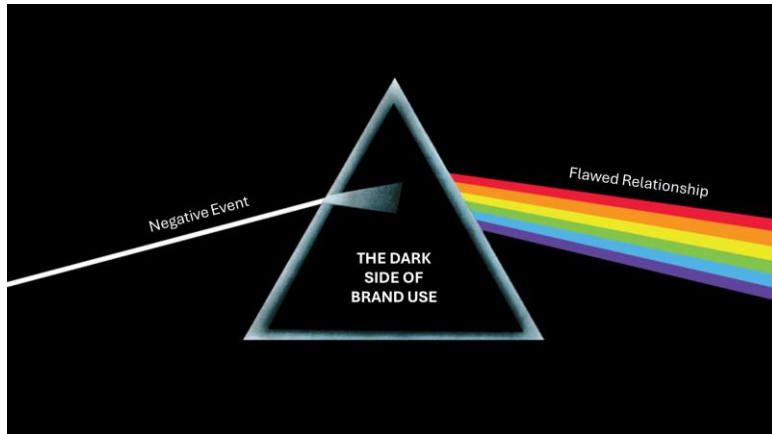
We also contribute to the scarce research on negative brand personality (Saeed et al., 2022) by expanding the dark personality traits identified by previous research (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024). Our research illustrates how the dark traits, relationships, emotions, and coping mechanisms interrelate, as consumers struggle to handle psychopathic, Machiavellian, and narcissistic brands. Dark personality traits influence how consumers interact with brands, with implications for consumer-brand relationship theory and customer relationship management.

4.5.2 Multidimensional flawed relationships

Although we present a framework that could be seen as a linear movement from stimuli to reactions, our research revealed that consumers are affected by dysfunctional relationships not necessarily in a linear order. They might be coping with negative experiences for years, unable to get rid of the brand, or they could gradually divorce from a brand relationship. Rather than defining a monolithic phenomenon, we draw on rock music, specifically Pink Floyd's *The Dark Side of the Moon*, for a metaphor. Figure 4.2 shows that when negative events pass through a prism (*The Dark Side of Brand Use*), like white light, their composition can be seen.

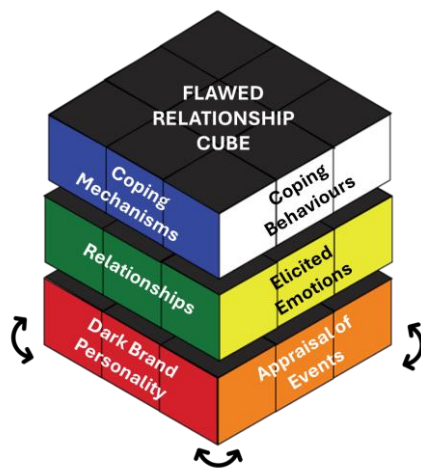
Figure 4.3 draws on another metaphor to illustrate how the brand's negative event can be broken down. In a Rubik's Cube, there are multiple combinations of colours, as the player can rotate it upwards, downwards, and sideways. In the same vein, negative experiences with brands are multidimensional, comprising dark brand personality traits, appraisal of events, emotions, relationships, coping mechanisms, and behaviours. These dimensions can take on an infinite number of combinations depending on the consumer's experience, forming a flawed relationship cube.

Figure 4.2 - The Dark Side of Brand Use.



Source: author's own work.

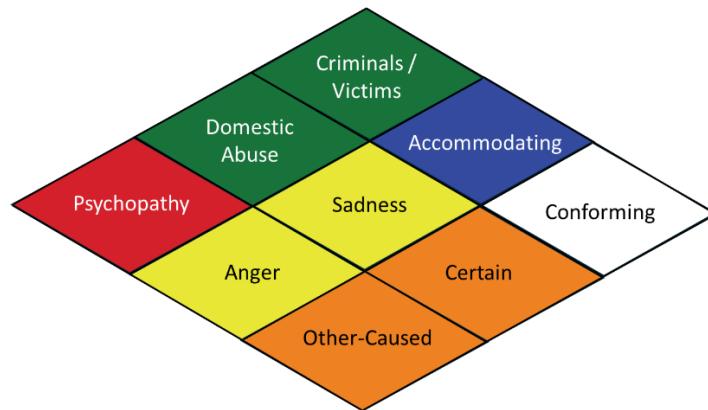
Figure 4.3 - Flawed relationship cube.



Source: author's own work.

Figure 4.4 illustrates how one possible combination could be formed. Ticketmaster's dark brand personality is psychopathic, as Sophia sees it. She struggled to buy a show ticket that only Ticketmaster sold, as in a domestic abuse relationship. The company's website and system crashed, preventing her from buying what she wanted, leading her to view the event as certain and caused by the brand. Sophia cried a lot, feeling sad, and was very angry at Ticketmaster, considering herself a victim of a criminal (in her words, an enemy). However, she went to the show because she could only accommodate the situation and conform to it. As this example shows, multiple combinations are possible, extending the theory of dysfunctional brand relationships.

Figure 4.4 - Sophia's flawed relationship with Ticketmaster.



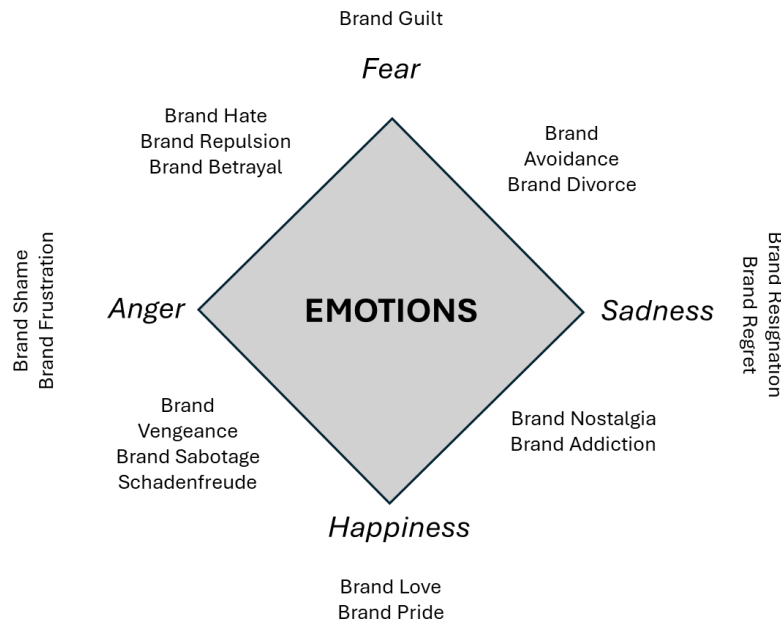
Source: author's own work.

4.5.3 Going Beyond Brand Hate

Our research shows that life exists beyond brand hate. The fragmentation of the literature (Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022), multiple conceptualisations, a focus on psychological rather than behavioural aspects (Aziz & Rahman, 2022), and the lack of a cohesive framework (Ladeira et al., 2026) have turned brand hate into a fuzzy umbrella construct. Also, there are a multitude of negative related constructs, such as brand shame (Weitzl & Hutzinger, 2025), brand repulsion (Dessart & Cova, 2021), brand sabotage (Kähr et al., 2016), brand avoidance (Lee et al., 2009; Odoom et al., 2019), brand divorce (Ferraz & Dallabrida, 2024; Sussan et al., 2012), and brand negativity (Dessart et al., 2020).

The proposed flawed consumer-brand relationship framework (Figure 4.1) helps organise and integrate the different negative brand-related constructs. They can also be combined with emotions and coping mechanisms (Table 4.5). These combinations show that negative experiences go beyond anger and fear, encompassing sadness and happiness as well (Figure 4.5). When sabotaging or expressing *schadenfreude*, for example, the consumer is simultaneously angry and happy. On the other hand, it is possible to feel happy and sad if one is addicted to a brand or yearns for an idealised past. In this sense, brand hate cannot account for all negative consumer-brand emotions, relationships, and coping strategies and behaviours. The multidimensionality of dysfunctional consumer-brand relationships shows that consumers navigate a complex phenomenon far beyond mere hate.

Figure 4.5 - Brand relationship constructs and respective emotions.



4.5.4 Limitations and Future Research Directions

This research does not fully capture the complexity of negative consumer-brand relationships. The limited interview sample and data from netnography and secondary sources provide a partial understanding of how flawed relationships are triggered and developed. Future research should further investigate how dysfunctional relationships can be theorised and integrated with brand constructs, such as brand hate, shame, and sabotage. Our framework is an initial step towards a theory of negative consumer-brand relationships, which should also be compared and contrasted with the brand relationship quality framework from past research (Fournier, 1998). Future studies could empirically test our model to determine whether the proposed appraisals, emotions, coping strategies, and behaviours align with theoretical expectations.

We encourage future investigations to increase our understanding of negative consumer-brand relationships. The identified types in this research are not exhaustive, as more nuanced and distinct ones might emerge from other research. There is a need to develop the brand relationship spectrum further and clarify its boundaries (Alvarez et al., 2023), as well as to compare negative and positive relationships. The development and the trajectories of flawed consumer-brand relationships also deserve more attention. Future studies could investigate how they start, grow, develop, and end over time, comparing the trajectories of different dysfunctional brand-consumer relationships.

CHAPTER 5 – CONCLUSION

The objective of this doctoral thesis was to investigate idiosyncratic consumer-brand relationships, understanding and identifying the peculiar positive and negative bonds derived from them. Although prior research examined a diverse range of relationships, they were concentrated in a few, such as brand love and friendship (Alvarez et al., 2023) or brand hate and avoidance (Mushtaq et al., 2024; Yadav & Chakrabarti, 2022). Chapter 2 explored the positive consumer-brand relationships, epitomised by brand tattoos, while Chapter 3 investigated polarised brands, explaining the different motivations regarding love and hate feelings. Finally, Chapter 4 discussed the flawed relationships consumers have with brands, focusing on negative brand experiences.

5.1 Theoretical contributions

Our research has three key contributions to the consumer-brand relationship theory. First, we have identified 34 new or less theorised idiosyncratic relationships, evaluated as positive (13), negative (14), ambiguous (4), or neutral (3). The identification of these relationships responds to a call to investigate other types that have not been previously studied (Alvarez et al., 2023). Table 5.1 summarises all relationships identified in this work.

Table 5.1 – Idiosyncratic brand relationship types identified in this research.

Valence	Relationships
Positive	Admirers, Best Friends Forever (BFF), Blind Lovers, Childhood Buddies, Escapists, Family Ties, Gurus/Disciples, Married, Partisans, Soulmates, Teammates, Therapists/Patients, and Vintage Mates.
Negative	Absent/Orphans, Activists, Anti-Narcissists/Snobs, Bullies/Bullied, Criminals/Victims, Crooks/Suckers, Deceivers/Deceived, Dictator/Subjects, Divorced, Forced Marriage, Host/Parasite, Moral Enemies, Spies/Targets, and Traitors/Betrayed.
Ambiguous	Dealers/Addicts, Domestic Abuse, Guilty Pleasures, and Sadists/Masochists.
Neutral	Agnostics, Detached, and Utilitarians.

Source: author's own work.

The identified relationships show that consumers have complex interactions with the brands they love and hate, which can bring intense positive emotions and benefits, as in a therapist-patient bond, but can also be dysfunctional and stressful, as in a criminal-victim relationship. Other relationship types lie in the middle, such as in a guilty pleasure one, revealing ambiguous bonds that can be simultaneously beneficial and detrimental.

Second, our work revealed that consumers have dynamic, polysemic, and multiple relationships with the same brands. They use brands to develop identity projects (Arnould & Thompson, 2005), seeking a desired, stable self in a fragmented world (Appau et al., 2020). The connection with brands is evaluated based on consumer values and the implicit brand promise (Bhargava & Bedi, 2022), thereby unearthing strong feelings towards them. Consumers build their individual and social selves through intricate, complex, and idiosyncratic relationships with brands, tattooing them (Chapter 2), developing polarised feelings (Chapter 3), or coping with negative experiences (Chapter 4).

Third, this doctoral thesis extends consumer-brand relationship theory by investigating the dark side of brand use. Our research shows that negative brand personalities (Malär & Giuffredi-Kähr, 2024; Saeed et al., 2022) foster broken relationships, which consumers cope with through accommodation, distancing, confrontation, or reframing. While previous research focused primarily on brand hate as an umbrella construct, this work pursued a broader investigation of negative emotions and behaviours. The proposed framework helps explain how dysfunctional relationships are nurtured, developed, understood, and confronted.

5.2 Managerial implications

The first key implication of our research for marketing and branding managers concerns the identification of several consumer-brand relationships. Understanding them enables addressing consumers as idiosyncratic individuals rather than a monolith. They develop strong, deep relationships based on emotions and experiences. Managers need to identify these relationships, quantify them, manage their implications, and propose marketing strategies to enhance their positive aspects while minimising their negative ones. Promotional activities can be tailored to each relationship, enhancing the bond with the company's brands. For example, a vintage-mates relationship can be nurtured through the launch of nostalgic products, while teammate-based relationships can reinforce the idea that the brand is a vehicle for the consumer's success.

Given that consumer-brand relationships are dynamic and multifaceted, this should be considered a point of attention for brand managers. Practitioners cannot consider that their brands foster only one type of relationship. If multiple relationships occur simultaneously, it is crucial to investigate how they interact and impact the brand's development. It is also important to understand whether a particular product or service fosters one type of positive relationship, while another might trigger a negative one. For instance, a soulmate relationship is beneficial

to the brand, but it can also lead to addiction, which would need to be addressed by a responsible policy from the company. Thus, there is no “one size fits all” strategy regarding consumer-brand relationships.

The dark side of brand use demands a reflection from managers and companies. Practitioners need to revisit how their brands interact with consumers and investigate whether they exhibit negative brand personality traits. A change in approach is needed to address the negative aspects, minimising or suppressing them. Bad experiences deeply affect how consumers buy and express their feelings, shaping how the brand performs not only in the present but also in the long run. Even minor mistakes can haunt the brand for many years, condemning it to damnation. Apart from that, brand managers need to understand that even iconic brands are not unanimous, sparking strong reactions from detractors, who consider them anti-iconic. The management of these brands thus has to consider palliative measures to address anti-brand activists.

5.3 Research limitations and future research opportunities

This work has some limitations that need to be disclosed. The relationships identified, either positive, negative, ambiguous, or neutral, are pieces of a greater puzzle. Our research does not fully capture the interrelations between them and brands. There is a need for further development of a general theory of consumer-brand relationships that accounts for the myriad of beneficial and dysfunctional bonds. We encourage scholars to delve into current research and propose innovative approaches to understanding how consumers build relationships with brands and to discover other relationship types. As we have argued that the relationships are multiple, complex, and polysemic, future studies need to take that into account for proposing new theoretical perspectives. Our proposal for a flawed consumer-brand relationship framework is a preliminary, modest step towards this end, but it focuses solely on negative experiences.

Although our research unearthed new consumer-brand relationships, it was focused on idiosyncratic ones, which can be restricted to specific groups. Future studies need to investigate further their frequency and deepen their understanding across other brands, sectors, and companies. In this sense, this work relied only on qualitative methodology, prioritising a phenomenological approach. Our narrow methodological choice needs to be complemented with other qualitative and quantitative methods. Other epistemological views would diversify how consumer-brand relationships are understood and theorised.

5.4 Social Implications

The research conducted in this PhD thesis has several social implications that could be subject to future public policies. Findings from the three studies show that consumers nurture intense relationships with brands, which are not always beneficial. They reported addictive behaviours towards brands that have implications for mental and physical health. For example, some ingested high doses of sugar while others spent hours consuming digital technology. Also, there were alarming accounts about bullying and sexist behaviours while consuming brands. Public policies and regulations should be proposed to control and lower the exposure of individuals to addictive behaviours and to punish brands for allowing bullying and discriminatory episodes while using their services.

Another social implication regards consumer rights protection. Our informants brought innumerable examples of flawed consumer-brand relationships that were triggered by negative brand personalities. There were reports of mistreatment, manipulation, misleading advertising, monopolistic enforcement, deceptive promotions, and many others. Governments could propose regulatory measures to strengthen consumer rights protection, thereby disincentivising predatory company behaviour and the development of negative brand personalities.

Finally, our work also has implications for environmental and social policies. Participants reported a strong aversion to brands that polluted, mistreated workers, disregarded unions, took advantage of universal public goods (such as water), tested products on animals, failed to protect minorities, or backed countries that started wars. Government bodies could rethink public policies to increase companies' responsibility towards the United Nations' Sustainable Development Goals (e.g., responsible production and consumption and good health and well-being), thereby diminishing the corporate impact reported by our informants.

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